

MALVIYA NAGAR AND SAKET TRAGEDIES

CM announces ₹10 lakh aid for victims' families

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Friday announced an ex gratia payment of ₹10 lakh for the families of those who lost their lives in the Malviya Nagar fire and the building collapse in Saket, while also declaring financial assistance of ₹2 lakh for those injured in the two tragedies.

The announcement was made during a special programme at the Delhi Secretariat, where the Chief Minister paid tribute to the victims and honoured citizens, police personnel, rescue workers, and officials who played a crucial role in saving lives during the emergencies.

Several individuals involved in the rescue operations were presented with commendation certificates and cash awards of ₹21,000 each in recognition of their courage and service.

Addressing the gathering, the Chief Minister expressed deep sorrow over the loss of



lives in the fire at Hauz Rani in Malviya Nagar and the building collapse in Saidulajab, Saket. She said the Delhi Government stands firmly with the affected families and has directed officials to ensure that compensation and relief are provided quickly and transparently. A two-minute silence was observed in memory of those who died in both incidents.

The Chief Minister said the tragedies had caused immense pain not only to the affected families but also to society at large. Referring to the Hauz Rani fire, she noted that an entire family lost its life

in the incident. She also mentioned that some foreign nationals who had come to India for medical treatment were among those affected by the disaster. Among those specially honoured was Riyazuddin Mansoori, who displayed exceptional courage during the Malviya Nagar fire.

According to officials, he quickly arranged mattresses below the building, helping several people escape and survive. The Chief Minister not only honoured him with a cash award but also ensured reimbursement of the cost of the mattresses used during the rescue effort.

Delhi BJP set for major organisational reshuffle

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi BJP is all set for a major organisational reshuffle in the wake of Union State Minister (MoS) Harsh Malhotra's recent appointment as the party's state unit head. It is learnt that about 75 per cent of the party's state office bearers are likely to be replaced by new and young faces.

Insiders said the state unit BJP leadership is preparing for a comprehensive overhaul of its Delhi organisation, aimed at strengthening the party structure after a year of its return to power and ahead of the crucial next years' municipal polls in the national capital.

The exercise is expected to bring in a new team of office-bearers, with an emphasis on younger turks and old guards who have been active at the grassroots level. Insiders said that more than 75 per cent of the current state office-bearers are likely to be replaced with the new ones. The proposed changes are expected to cover several key organisational posts, including vice-presi-

dents, general secretaries, and secretaries.

After taking over the reins of the party last month, Malhotra had said addressing organisational gaps at the district level will be a top priority. "The teams in the districts will be formed within the next 15 to 20 days, and we expect to complete the reorganisation of the state unit and the appointment of office bearers within the next two months," Malhotra had said.

Insiders said the reshuffle is being viewed as an effort to align the Delhi unit with the BJP's broader organisational strategy of promoting fresh leadership while balancing social and regional representation. The move is also expected to strengthen coordination between the party organisation and the government.

It also aims to remove several deadwoods who have been holding onto the positions despite lagging on performance. Insiders indicated that consultations are underway and the final list of office-bearers could be announced after discussions with the central leadership.

LG chairs DDA meeting to review key environmental, infrastructure projects

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Friday chaired a meeting of the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) at the Yamuna Sports Complex to review the Action Taken Report on critical environmental and infrastructure projects across the national Capital.

The LG Secretariat said that detailed assessments were undertaken on the Yamuna Riverfront development and the comprehensive plan to revitalise Yamuna Bazar and the adjoining ghats.

The review also evaluated the time-bound restoration of 101 water bodies under Phase-I, including flagship projects in Dwarka and Rohini. Additionally, progress of major socio-economic infrastructure projects across Delhi, including hospitality, healthcare, luxury retail, and logistics hubs, was closely scrutinised.

To ensure absolute preparedness ahead of the monsoon, the status of the



Desilting Action Plan 2026 across critical zones and waterlogging locations was rigorously monitored, alongside the operational readiness of the Central Flood Control Room before the June 15 deadline. Timely execution of these initiatives remains fundamental to building a resilient, progressive, and Viksit Delhi.

Additionally, progress of major socio-economic infrastructure projects across Delhi, including hospitality, healthcare, luxury retail, and logistics hubs, was closely scrutinised. To ensure absolute preparedness ahead of the monsoon, the status of the Desilting Action

Plan 2026 across critical zones and waterlogging locations was rigorously monitored.

Besides this, the LG along with Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Friday renamed Britannia Chowk, located on Lawrence Road, as 'Ashwini Chopra (Minna) Chowk' in honour of late senior journalist, former Member of Parliament, social worker and former editor of the Punjab Kesari Group, Ashwini Kumar Chopra (Minna).

On the occasion, the Lieutenant Governor and the Chief Minister jointly inaugurated the chowk and unveiled the naming plaque.

Police bust sex racket in Paharganj, one arrested NDMC rolls out new plastic recycling drive

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Police busted an alleged sex racket operating from a building on Qutub Road in Paharganj and rescued four women during a raid conducted Thursday evening.

Authorities arrested one person accused of running the racket and initiated separate legal action against the premises owner.

According to police, the operation was launched after a secret informant approached the Station

House Officer (SHO) of the Nabi Karim police station on June 11 and provided information about an alleged prostitution racket being run from a local building.

After confirming the illegal activity, the team conducted a raid at the premises and allegedly uncovered the sex racket. Four women, aged 20 to 34, were rescued during the operation.

Police arrested Shahrukh, 29, a resident of Laxmi Nagar, who is alleged to have been operating the racket from the premises. A case has



been registered under Sections 3, 4 and 5 of the Immoral Traffic (Prevention) Act (ITP Act) at the Nabi Karim police station.

In a parallel action, police also booked the owner of the rented property, Harikishan alias Raju

Champion, 58, a resident of Dwarka, under Section 223A of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS) for allegedly allowing the premises to be used for unlawful activities. A separate FIR has been registered in this regard.

Investigators said relevant evidence was seized from the spot and taken into possession.

Authorities are questioning the arrested suspect to determine the involvement of others linked to the alleged racket and to uncover the wider network behind the operation.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) on Friday launched a new initiative aimed at strengthening plastic waste management through scientific collection, segregation, and recycling across the Lutyns' Delhi area.

Named 'Project D.R.O.P.' (Develop Responsible Outlook for Plastic), the initiative has been launched in collaboration with Kia India and the Indian Pollution Control Association (IPCA), according to a statement.



At the launch, NDMC Vice Chairperson Kuljeet Singh Chahal unveiled community bins made from recycled plastic waste and flagged off

a collection vehicle that will be used for the systematic collection and transportation of plastic waste in the NDMC area.

Addressing the event, Chahal said the initiative aligns with the vision of Swachh Bharat, Mission LIFE, and Viksit Bharat @2047, and seeks to promote responsible disposal of plastic waste while encouraging greater public participation in environmental protection.

"NDMC's jurisdiction includes Parliament House, central government offices, embassies and other key institutions, making cleanliness and environmental initiatives in the area significant at both national and international levels," Chahal said.

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER (ROADS), PUBLIC WORKS ROADS DEPARTMENT,
ASSAM, GUWAHATI-03

No. CE/DEV/TB/293/2025-26/11

PRESS NOTICE INVITING TENDER (RE-BID)

In continuation of the tender invited vide Press Notice no. CE/DEV/TB/293/2025-26/02 Dtd. 27.02.2026, The Chief Engineer (Roads), PWRD, Assam, Chandmari, Guwahati-3 invites Re-Bid on behalf of Governor of Assam for **1 (one)** no. of package for construction of Roads under SOPD-G for the year 2025-26 in **Jorhat District** of Assam amounting to **Rs. 1.607 crore** (approx.) including GST etc. from approved & eligible Contractors registered with PWRD, Assam.

Details may be seen from 15-06-2026 at website www.assamtenders.gov.in. Amendment/Addendum to the SBD, if any, and further notifications shall appear in this website and also at the office of the undersigned during office hours. The contractor/bidder must be registered with the Electronic Tendering System (ETS) of PWRD, Assam website www.assamtenders.gov.in.

(The Bid price may vary at the time of detail tendering for which no claim will be admissible)

Chief Engineer (Roads), PWRD,
Assam, Chandmari, Guwahati-3.

DIPR/C/PIO/90/13-Jun-26

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER :: PWD BUILDING::
ASSAM, GUWAHATI-03

No. নিবিদা প্রসংগ নং. CE/TB-III(B)/08/2026/08

PRESS NOTICE
নিবিদা আহ্বান করা জাননী

It is for general information to all concerned that the bid invited earlier vide Press Notice No. CE/TB-III(B)/08/2026/06 Dated 13-05-2026 is hereby cancelled and fresh Bid is invited by the Chief Engineer, P.W.D.(Building), Assam on behalf of the Governor of Assam from eligible Firm/Contractor of repute having requisite experience in similar nature of works for the following work through Engineering, Procurement and Construction (EPC) Mode-I of contract. Details of bid may be seen at e-procurement portal www.assamtenders.gov.in. The bidders must be enrolled in www.assamtenders.gov.in.

পূর্বে Press Notice No. CE/TB-III(B)/08/2026/06 তারিখ ১৩-০৫-২০২৬ যোগে আহ্বান করা নিবিদায়ন ইয়াব দ্বারা বাতিল করা হৈছে। বুলি সকলো সংশ্লিষ্ট অবসরার্থে জনোরা হৈছে। অসমৰ ৰাজ্যপালৰ পক্ষে মুখ্য অভিযন্তা, পি.ডব্লিউ.ডি. (বিল্ডিং), অসমে সামগ্ৰসাপূৰ্ণ কামৰ ক্ষেত্ৰত প্ৰয়োজনীয় অভিজ্ঞতা থকা সুপ্ৰতিষ্ঠিত যোগ্য ফাৰ্ম/ঠিকাদাৰৰ পৰা Engineering, Procurement and Construction (EPC) Mode-I চুক্তিৰ অধীনত তলত উল্লেখিত কামৰ বাবে পুনৰ নতুন নিবিদা আহ্বান কৰিছে। নিবিদাৰ বিস্তৃত বিৱৰণ e-procurement portal www.assamtenders.gov.in ত চাব পাৰিব। নিবিদাদাতাসকলে www.assamtenders.gov.in ত নামভৰ্তি কৰা বাধ্যতামূলক।

Sl. No. ক্র. নং	Name of work কামৰ নাম	Approx. Value of work (in Rs.) কামৰ আনুমানিক মূল্য (টেকাত)	Bid Security নিবিদা পত্ৰ সুৰুকা	Bid Processing Fee নিবিদা প্ৰক্ৰিয়াকৰণ মূল্য (টেকাত)	Completion period সমাপ্তী সময়সীমা
1.	Infrastructure Development near Bhootnath Kali Mandir (Phase-II), ভূতনাথ কালী মন্দিৰৰ ওচৰত আন্তঃগাঁথনি উন্নয়ন (দ্বিতীয় পৰ্যায়)।	Rs. 8,40,37,949.00 বাৰ্শি: ₹ ৮,৪০,৩৭,৯৪৯.০০/-	For General category, Rs. 16,80,759.00 and For Reserved category Rs. 8,40,379.00 ক্ষেত্ৰাধীন শ্ৰেণীৰ বাবে ₹ ১৬,৮০,৭৫৯.০০/- আৰু সংৰক্ষিত শ্ৰেণীৰ বাবে ₹ ৮,৪০,৩৭৯.০০/-	Rs. 16,81,00.00 ₹ ১৬,৮১০.০০/-	12(Twelve) Months ১২ (বাৰ) মাহ

Note নোট:

(i) Value of work may vary according to the detail NIT. কামৰ মূল্য বিৱৰ্ত্তন হ'ব পাৰে।

(ii) All terms and conditions will be as per the Bidding Documents. সকলো চৰ্ত আৰু নিয়মাবলী নিবিদা নথিপত্ৰ অনুযায়ী হ'ব।

(iii) The Press Notice will be a part of the Bidding Documents. নিবিদা আহ্বান কৰা জাননী নিবিদা নথিপত্ৰৰ অংশ হ'ব।

sd/-
Chief Engineer, PWD (Building)
Assam, Chandmari, Guwahati-3.
মুখ্য অভিযন্তা, লোক নিৰ্মাণ (গৃহ) বিভাগ,
অসম, চান্দমৰি, গুৱাহাটী-৩।

DIPR/C/PIO/91/13-Jun-26

AXIS BANK Retail Assets Centre, Axis Bank Lt. Axis House, Tower T-2, 2nd Floor, I-14, Sector-128, Noida Expressway, Jaypee Greens Washburn, Noida (U.P.)-201301-1, Axis Bank Ltd. Retail Asset Centre at 1st Floor, Vipul Square, Shastri Park-1, Gurgaon-122009. Axis Bank Limited, Himalaya House, Upper Ground Floor and first floor, Kasturba Gandhi Marg, Connaught Place, New Delhi - 110001 Corporate Office: Block-B, Bombay Dyeing Mills Compound, Pandurang Bhukhar Marg, Worli, Mumbai-400 025 Registered Office: Trench, 3rd floor, opposite Samantheswar Temple, Law Garden, Ellisbridge, Ahmedabad-380006

DEMAND NOTICE

Whereas the borrowers/co-borrowers/guarantors/mortgagors mentioned hereunder had availed the financial assistance from Axis Bank Ltd. We state that despite having availed the financial assistance, the borrowers/guarantors/mortgagors have committed various defaults in repayment of interest and principal amounts as per due dates. The account has been classified as Non Performing Asset on the respective dates mentioned hereunder in accordance with the directives/guidelines issued by Reserve Bank of India, consequent to the Authorized Officer of Axis Bank Ltd. under Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 & in exercise of powers conferred under Section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 issued Demand Notices on respective dates mentioned below under Section 13(2) of SARFESI Act, 2002, calling upon the following borrowers/guarantors/mortgagors to repay the amount mentioned in the notices together with further interest at the contractual rate on the amount mentioned in the notices and incidental expenses: cost, charges etc. until the date of payment within 60 days from the date of receipt of notices. The notices issued to them on their last known addresses have returned un-served and as such they are hereby informed by way of public notice about the same.

Name Of The Borrower / Address/ Co-borrower And Guarantor Name: 1. Mr. Manoj Kumar S/o Kasturi Lal Chopra J-168 G.F. Saket District Court Complex Saket, South Delhi 110017 Also, At: Mr. Manoj Kumar S/o Kasturi Lal Chopra Gali No. 12 Shanti Mohalla Gandhi Nagar Delhi 110031 Also At: Mr. Manoj Kumar S/o Kasturi Lal Chopra Shivam Cloth House 5474 Na Sarak, Ground Floor Lakshmi Building, Chandni Chowk Delhi 110006 Also At: Mr. Manoj Kumar S/o Kasturi Lal Chopra H No. A-2719 First Floor, Greenfield Colony Faridabad-121010 (Apartment) 2. Mrs. Ranu Chopra W/o. Mr. Manoj Kumar J-168 Entire Ground Floor, Saket, South Delhi 110017 Also At: Mrs. Ranu Chopra W/o. Mr. Manoj Kumar H No. A-2719 First Floor, Sector-a, Greenfield Colony Faridabad-121010 (Co-apartment)

Outstanding Amt (rs.) As On Date Of Notice : Rs. 1,11,92,825/- (Rupees One Crore Eleven Lakh Ninety-Two Thousand Eight Hundred Twenty-Five Only)

Property Address Of Secured Assets: Property No. 2719, First Floor, Sector-a, Greenfield Colony Faridabad Haryana-121001 Measuring 459.38 Sq.Yds Part Of Kharsa No. 55/20, And Bounded As Under-East : As Per Title Deed, West : As Per Title Deed, North : As Per Title Deed, South : As Per Title Deed

NPA Date :	Date Of Demand Notice :	Loan Amount (Rs.) :
08-June-2026	09-June-2026	Rs. 1,25,00,000/-

Name Of The Borrower / Address/ Co-borrower And Guarantor Name: 1. Mr. Kunal Motwani S/o Hansh Motwani Flat No. Q-19, 3rd Floor Rajon Garden, J-6 Tاجر Garden, Delhi -110027 Also, At: Mr. Kunal Motwani S/o Hansh Motwani Asian Hospitality G-12, North West Avenue Club Road Punjab Bagh-Delhi-110028 Also, At: Mr. Kunal Motwani S/o Hansh Motwani Flat No. D-5/24, 3rd Floor, Road No. D-5 DLF City Ph-1 Gurgaon-122002(Applicant) 2. Mr. Maninder Singh S/o Balbir Singh Rajpal D-110, Surajmal Vihar, Shakarpur Barramand, Delhi 110092(Guarantor)

Outstanding Amt (rs.) As On Date Of Notice : Rs. 3,03,09,280/- (Rupees Three Crore Three Lakh Nine Thousand Two Hundred Eighty Only)

Property Address Of Secured Assets: Entire Third Floor Without Rooftop/Terrace Rights, Consisting Of Drawing Room, Kitchen, Lobby, Four Bed Room, Pula, Four Toilet, W.C, Dress, Lift Well And Stairs Case Only Having Covered Area 238.108 Sqm+11.193 Sqm=249.301 Sqm, (283.47 Sq.Ft.) Along With The Together With 3 (Three) No. Car Parking Space In The Still Ground Area Together With Impartible And Under Right Share 1/3th (25%) In Residential Plot Bearing No. 24 On Road D-5 Measuring 420 Sq. Mtrs. (502.32 Sq. Yards), Situated In The Residential Colony Known As Dlf City (earlier Known As Dlf Outab Enclave Complex), Phase-1 In And Around Village Chakkarpur Tehsil Wazirabad District Gurugram Haryana And Bounded As Under- East : Plot No. D-5/23, West: Plot No. D-5/25, North : Road, South : Plot No. D-6/9

NPA Date :	Date Of Demand Notice :	Loan Amount (Rs.) :
08-June-2026	09-June-2026	Rs. 3,08,00,000/-

Name Of The Borrower / Address/ Co-borrower And Guarantor Name: Rohan Kumar (Borrower) House No-301, Sun City Heights, Sector-54, Gurgaon, Haryana-122001. Pankaj Srivastava (Co-borrower)/House No-301, Sun City Heights, Sector-54, Gurgaon, Haryana-122001

Outstanding Amt (Rs.) As On Date Of Notice : Rs. 1,15,92,431/- (Rupees One Crore Fifteen Lac Ninety Two Thousand Four Hundred Thirty One Only)

Property Address Of Secured Assets: Flat No-1502, 14th Floor, Tower Kft-014, Krescent Home, Jaypee Green, Sec-129, Noida Bounded As Under- East : As Per Site Plan, West : As Per Site Plan, North : As Per Site Plan, South : As Per Site Plan

NPA Date :	Date Of Demand Notice :	Loan Amount (Rs.) :
10-Dec-17	21-May-26	Rs. 4,668,374/-

Name Of The Borrower / Address/ Co-borrower And Guarantor Name: Nitin Verma (Borrower) House No- 1001, Free Hold Colony, Near Sharanu Public School, Sector-23, Ghazabad, Uttar Pradesh-201001. Asha Verma (Co-borrower)/House No- 1001, Free Hold Colony, Near Sharanu Public School, Sector-23, Ghazabad, Uttar Pradesh-201001

Outstanding Amt (Rs.) As On Date Of Notice : Rs. 1,01,10,467/- (Rupees One Crore One Lac Ten Thousand Four Hundred Sixty Seven Only)

Property Address Of Secured Assets: Flat No. B-1/C-2, Shubhkamya, Jeev Homes, Plot No. Gh-06/B, Sec 137, Noida Bounded As Under- East : As Per Site Plan, West : As Per Site Plan, North : As Per Site Plan, South : As Per Site Plan

NPA Date :	Date Of Demand Notice :	Loan Amount (Rs.) :
09-Oct-18	21-May-26	Rs. 53,00,000/-

Name Of The Borrower / Address/ Co-borrower And Guarantor Name: Manik Singh (Borrower) S/o Meharban Singh, A-47 Sector 31, Noida, Gautam Buddha Nagar, Uttar Pradesh- 201301 Meharban Singh (Co-borrower) A-47 Sector 31, Noida, Gautam Buddha Nagar, Uttar Pradesh- 201301, Meena Singh (Co-borrower) A-47 Sector 31, Noida, Gautam Buddha Nagar, Uttar Pradesh- 201301

Outstanding Amt (Rs.) As On Date Of Notice : Rs. 3,37,02,054/- (Rupees Three Crore Thirty Seven Lac Two Thousand Fifty Four Only)

Property Address Of Secured Assets: Flat No B1401, Tower-B, The Amadeus, Plot No. Gh-02, Sec-143 Expressway, Noida Bounded As Under- East : As Per Site Plan, West : As Per Site Plan, North : As Per Site Plan, South : As Per Site Plan

NPA Date :	Date Of Demand Notice :	Loan Amount (Rs.) :
09-Nov-20	21-May-26	Rs. 17,467,172/-

In the circumstances as aforesaid, the notice is hereby given to the above borrowers, co-borrowers and/or their guarantors (where ever applicable) to pay the outstanding dues as mentioned above along with future interest and applicable charges within 60 days from the date of the publication of this notice failing which further steps will be taken after the expiry of 60 days of the date of this notice against the secured assets including taking possession of the secured assets if by public auction, by invoking quotations, tender from public or by private treaty. Please also note that if the entire amount of outstanding dues together with the costs, charges and expenses incurred by the Bank is not tendered before publication of notice for sale of the secured assets by public auction, by invoking quotations, tender from public or by private treaty, you may not be entitled to redeem the secured asset(s) please note that under Section 13 (13) of the said Act, no Borrower shall, trans by way of sale, lease or otherwise any of his secured assets referred to in the notice, without prior written consent of the secured creditor.

Dated: 13.06.2026, Place: Noida U.P. Authorized Officer, Axis Bank Ltd.

Baba Farid University of Health Sciences, Faridkot
Ph: 01639-256232, 256236

Advt. No. BFU-26/21

VACANCIES

Online applications are invited w.e.f 15-06-2026 to 05-07-2026 from eligible candidates through University website i.e www.bfuhs.ac.in for the recruitment to the posts of **Junior Engineer (Civil-01 & Mechanical-01)** under Baba Farid University of Health Sciences, Faridkot.

For Application form, fee, Category wise distribution and other terms & conditions, visit University website: www.bfuhs.ac.in

Sd/-
REGISTRAR

31/08/12/02/26-27/12/282 Dated CHD - 12/06/2026

GOVERNMENT OF ASSAM
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF ENGINEER, PWD (BUILDING)
ASSAM, CHANDMARI, GUWAHATI-3

No. CE/TB-III(B)/08/2026/07

CANCELLATION NOTICE

It for information to all concerned that the tender invited for the work "Infrastructure Development near Bhootnath Kali Mandir (Phase-II)" on Engineering Procurement and Construction (EPC) Mode-1 vide **Press Notice No. CE/TB-III(B)/08/2026/06** dtd 13th May'2026 is hereby cancelled due to some technical reasons.

Sd/-
Chief Engineer, PWD (Building)
DIPR/C/PIO/92/13-Jun-26 Assam, Chandmari, Ghy-03

कार्यालय नगर पालिक निगम, रायगढ़ (छठगढ)

क्रमांक 1261 / न.पा.नि. / 2026 रायगढ़ दिनांक 12-06-26

॥ ई-प्रोक्वोरमेंट निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना ॥

नगर पालिक निगम, रायगढ़ द्वारा निम्नलिखित कार्य हेतु ऑनलाइन (Online) निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है :-

क्र.	सि.क्र.क.	कार्य का विवरण	अनु. लागत राशि रु. (लाख में)	निविदा डाउनलोड करने की अंतिम तिथि
1	2	3	4	5
01	193338	DEVELOPMENT OF RAJ MAHAL TO CIRCUIT HOUSE AT RAIGARH. (2nd Call)	529.80	02.07.2026

उपरोक्त निमाण कार्यो की निविदा को सामान शर्तों, धरोहर राशि, विद्वत निविदा विज्ञापित, निविदा दस्तावेज व अन्य जानकारी ई-प्रोक्वोरमेंट वेब पोर्टल <https://eproc.cgstate.gov.in> से डाउनलोड की जा सकती है।

हस्ता/-
कार्यालयन अभियन्ता न.पा.नि., रायगढ़

कार्यालय, नगर पालिक निगम, कोरबा (छत्तीसगढ)

क. 706/2026/ दिनांक 08.06.2026

ई-प्रोक्वोरमेंट निविदा सूचना

नगर पालिक निगम, कोरबा द्वारा निम्नलिखित कार्य हेतु व्यवसाय से संबंधित निविदाकारों/फर्मों से शेड्यूल अनुसार आइटम दर पर ई-टेंडर निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है:-

क्र.	कार्य का विवरण	अनुमानित लागत (रु.लाख में)	निविदा डालने की अंतिम तिथि
1	नगर पालिक निगम क्षेत्रांतर्गत दरी नगर जोन में नाली, सड़क, भवन एवं विद्युतीकरण कार्य का परम्पन एवं संधारण कार्य हेतु वार्षिक दर निर्धारण (परम्पन एवं संधारण यद) (द्वितीय निविदा)	100.00	23.06.2026 (T.No. 192794)

उपरोक्त कार्य की निविदा की जानकारी ई-प्रोक्वोरमेंट वेब पोर्टल <http://eproc.cgstate.gov.in> से डाउनलोड की जा सकती है, साथ ही निगम के वेब साईट www.korbamunicipal.in एवं www.korba.urbanecpg.gov.in पर भी देखी जा सकती है।

॥ स्वच्छ भारत निर्माण में योगदान ॥

अग्रोक्षेत्र अभियन्ता
नगर पालिक निगम
कोरबा (छत्तीसगढ़)

PUBLIC NOTICE

Under instructions from my client, Mr. Rakesh Kumar Malik, S/o Sh. Ishwar Singh, R/o Kharsa No. 179A, 1st Floor, Block-4, Weerat, Kunj Enclave, New Delhi-110070, it is hereby notified that his son, Mr. Mohit Malik, has been disowned and debarred from all family relations and from all his self-acquired movable and immovable properties. My client shall not be responsible for any act, debt, liability, or transaction undertaken by Mr. Mohit Malik. Any person dealing with him shall do so at his/her own risk.

Chanderjeet Yadav (Advocate) Ch.
No. 905, Patiala House Court,
New Delhi-110001, Mo: 8860273371

PUBLIC APPEAL

We, "Devayan Foundation" 252-E, Front Portion, Third Floor, Sant Nagar, East of Kailash, New Delhi-110065, are a registered charitable trust (under Section 80G). Our objective is to expand educational, health and yoga centres across India to provide better opportunities and services to the underprivileged. We appeal for your cooperation and generous donations.

Contact : schooladmn@shreevidya.school
Your support is our strength.

PUBLIC NOTICE

Be it known to all that my client Pooja W/o Mata Prasad Gupta R/o T-220, Road No. 20, Baljeet Nagar, West Patel Nagar, Delhi-110008 has severed her all relation from her son Pawan Gupta and disown him from her all moveable and immovable properties due to his disobedient conduct. My client shall not be responsible for any act, deeds and things of her above named son in future.

Manoj Kumar(Adv.) Ch. No.232,
Saket Court, New Delhi-110017

PUBLIC NOTICE

The general public is hereby informed that my client, Rakesh Sharma, Son of Sh. Raja Ram, resident of G-128, Vijay Vihar, Phase-2, Sector-7, Rohini, North West Delhi, Delhi-110085, has, on account of the misconduct and irresponsible behaviour of her son, KUNAL SHARMA, severed all relations with him. It is further notified that my client has disowned and debarred the said KUNAL SHARMA from any and all rights, claims, or interests in her movable and immovable properties, whether present or future. Accordingly, any person dealing with the said KUNAL SHARMA shall do so entirely at his/her/their own risk, cost, and consequences. My client shall not be held responsible or liable for any act, deed, transaction, or obligation undertaken by the said.

KHUSHI JINDAL (ADVOCATE)
Ch.No.731, Rohini Court, Delhi-65

PUBLIC NOTICE

Notice is hereby given on behalf of SHRI DEV SHARMA AND SMT. HIMANSHI who are purchasing the FLAT No. 03, ON 3RD FLOOR, AREA MEASURABLE AND PLOT NO. 41, AREA MEASURABLE 157.33 SQ. YARDS, I.E. 131.54 SQ. METERS, TO TAL. AREA AND BOTH PLOTS ARE A AREA MEASURING 157.33 SQ. YARDS, I.E. 131.54 SQ. METERS, TO TAL. AREA AND BOTH PLOTS ARE A SQ. YARDS I.E. 263.08 SQ. METERS, RELATED IN KHARSA No. 1241, SITUATED AT RESIDENTIAL COLONY RAJ COMPOUND, NEW DELHI-110048, to LATE BISHAMAR DAYAL SHARMA DEDATED 20.04.2021 AND SMC of Late Bishamhar Dayal Sharma has been lost/misplaced/not available to comply the requirements of BANK/NBFC, we give this public notice that if any Person having any type of claim/right/interest/claiming mortgage over the said property, may inform in writing, at the address mentioned below, about his objections, within 7 days from today, failing which it shall be presumed that the said property is free from all type of Encumbrances/interests.

Lucam Legal LLP
N-161, Ground Floor, Saket Tower, Gautam Nagar
Near Yusuf Sarai Community Centre, New Delhi-110048
Contact @ 011-40046316 & 41667323

DIP/Shabbardh/031/26-27



नरेन्द्र मोदी
प्रधानमंत्री

व्यापार हुआ आसान

- पुलिस लाइसेंस स्वतः
- MCD फैक्ट्री लाइसेंस में छूट
- ग्रीन इंडस्ट्री को 20 दिन में मंजूरी
- सिंगल विंडो से फ़ास्ट अप्रूवल

12 साल

विश्वास के, विकास के, जनकल्याण के



ईज़ ऑफ़ इज़ा
बिजनेस



रेखा गुप्ता
मुख्यमंत्री, दिल्ली सरकार



संघीय लोकतान्त्रिक गणतन्त्र
दिल्ली सरकार

DERC allows Delhi discoms to recover higher surcharge

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Electricity Regulatory Commission (DERC) has allowed Delhi discoms to recover higher FPPA surcharge from consumers due to the rising electricity purchase costs amid the energy crisis triggered by geopolitical tensions.

The move will impact the consumers not covered by subsidy schemes. However, those getting subsidies (full or 50 per cent) will not be affected. The fuel and power purchase adjustment surcharge (FPPAS) is applied as a percent-

age of total energy and fixed costs. It is dependent on fuel prices.

According to the DERC order, the FPPAS for April stood at 31.5 per cent in the case of BRPL, 35.26 per cent for BYPL and 16 per cent in the case of TPDDL. The Commission allowed a relaxation in the 10 per cent FPPAS recovery limit to "remove the difficulties" faced by discoms in recovering "a reasonable part" of the increase in the power purchase cost. It permitted BRPL and BYPL to recover an additional 7.94 per cent and 7.43 per cent FPPAS, respectively, for April. The

TPDDL was allowed to recover the entire 16 per cent FPPAS, according to the order.

Following the DERC order, the total FPPAS permitted to be recovered has increased to 17.94 per cent in the case of BRPL and 17.43 per cent for BYPL for the month of April.

"...the Distribution Licensees namely BSES Rajdhani Power Limited (BRPL) and BSES Yamuna Power Limited (BYPL) shall be permitted to recover, in addition to the capped FPPAS of 10 per cent, the additional FPPAS for April 2026 at 7.94 per cent in the case of BRPL and 7.43 per cent in the case of BYPL.



Accordingly, the total FPPAS permitted to be recovered is 17.94 per cent in the case of BRPL and 17.43 per cent in the case of BYPL for the month of April, 2026," the DERC said in its order.

"Tata Power Delhi Distribution Limited (TPDDL) shall also be permitted to recover, in addition to the capped FPPAS of ten per cent (10 per cent), the additional FPPAS for April 2026 as 8.50

per cent. As the actual FPPAS claim of TPDDL as per their representation is approximately 16 per cent, the Commission is restricting the total FPPAS to be recovered by TPDDL to 16 per cent instead of 18.5 per cent.

However, the same shall be allowed only on the submission of Statutory Auditor Certificate Certifying the quantity & amount of power purchase by the TPDDL during the month of April, 2026, and a supporting affidavit pertaining to the FPPAS claim for the month of April, 2026.

Delhi's power distribution companies - BRPL, BYPL and

TPDDL - in their representations to the Delhi Electricity Regulatory Commission (DERC), in May, sought relaxation on the recovery of FPPAS, which is capped at 10 per cent.

In their representation, the discoms had urged the DERC to increase the FPPAS recovery limit for April. They submitted that the actual power purchase cost in April increased significantly as compared to the approved base power purchase cost considered in the prevailing tariff order of September 30, 2021.

Recently, there has been a significant increase in coal prices due to higher imports

and transport costs, officials said. The regulator clarified that the relaxation will be applicable on a month-on-month basis till further order.

Till March 2026, the FPPA surcharge was imposed on a quarterly basis. From the April billing cycle, it will now be recovered on a monthly basis, and this is the first order to that effect, officials said.

In future months, if the calculated FPPAS is below the existing limit, the unrecovered amount from earlier months can be added and recovered gradually, subject to the overall capping provisions, they added.

Neighbours break grille, firefighters scale building in Govindpuri rescue

KHUSHI MEHROTRA
■ New Delhi

Hours after a predawn fire claimed three lives in a residential building in Govindpuri's Tughlakabad Extension, the narrow lanes around Madhya Marg appeared deceptively normal. Shopkeepers opened their shutters, customers trickled into stores, and children walked through the neighbourhood. Yet nearly every conversation centred on the same tragedy: the desperate rescue attempts and the cries for help.

Residents recalled waking up to frantic screams as thick smoke engulfed a five-storey residential building shortly after 2:31 am on Friday.

Rahul Agarwal, who runs a grocery store outside Gali No. 1 where the fire broke out, said the neighbourhood sprang into action after hearing people trapped inside pleading for help.

"Late at night, we heard people screaming and begging to be rescued. Since it was so late, it was even more worrying. Everyone rushed out of their homes," he said.

As panic spread through the lane, residents began moving parked vehicles to create space for emergency responders while others called the fire brigade and police, said Agarwal.

According to eyewitnesses, the flames originated in the ground-floor parking area, but the smoke proved deadly.

"The fire itself was not very extensive, but the smoke was terrifying," Agarwal said. "You cannot tell from the building's facade that such a major incident happened. The staircase acted like a furnace, carrying the smoke and heat upwards." The narrow stairwell quickly became impassable, trapping residents on upper floors.

Agarwal noted that the casualty count could have been much higher had several residents not been away on summer vacation at the time.



Police officers keep watch after a fire broke out in a five-storey residential building in the Tughlakabad Extension area of New Delhi

PANKAJ KUMAR

CM CONDOLES TUGHLAKABAD FIRE DEATHS

New Delhi: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta condoled the loss of lives in the fire at a residential building in Tughlakabad Extension in south-east Delhi and assured medical care for the injured people. The Delhi government is closely monitoring the situation, and all concerned departments are working in coordination to provide timely support and assistance to those affected, she said in a post on X.

"The loss of lives in the fire incident in Tughlakabad is deeply saddening. Heartfelt condolences to the bereaved families. Prayers for the speedy recovery of those injured and strength to all those affected by this tragedy," the chief minister said. (PNS)

"The family on the first floor was not at home, and only one resident was present on the second floor while the rest of his family was away. The family on the third floor was the worst affected, where all three deaths occurred," he said.

When firefighters arrived, they found several occupants stranded inside the building. Delhi Fire Service personnel launched a rescue operation from multiple sides, climbing to the terrace, cutting open a locked gate and entering from above to reach those trapped by smoke.

Officials later confirmed that two young women stranded on the rooftop were rescued and rushed to the hospital.

Residents also joined the rescue efforts. Vivek, an employee at a nearby hardware store, said he and several neighbours, including a handyman, attempted to reach those trapped inside before emergency teams gained access to the upper floors.

"We broke the building's grille and punctured the terrace water motors so that

water could flow down and help control the fire," he said.

According to Vivek, he helped rescue five people, including four women. "The people we brought out had turned black due to the smoke. They were terrified and struggling to breathe," he said.

Eyewitnesses described scenes of confusion as residents shouted from windows and terraces while neighbours searched for ways to reach them.

Agarwal said the heat emanating from the building was intense, despite the fire appearing to be concentrated on the lower floors.

"I salute the firefighters. They did a tremendous job. Even when I stepped a little closer to the building, I could feel my skin burning," he said.

Among the stories that have emerged from the tragedy is that of 28-year-old Pankaj, who was among the three people who died in the blaze. According to neighbours, Pankaj may have initially escaped the building but returned inside in an attempt to save his family members.

CM Rekha hails 12 years of PM Modi's governance

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Friday highlighted various achievements of the Modi government over the last 12 years, saying that India has been on a "historic" journey of change and transformation under the leadership of the prime minister.

In a joint press conference with Delhi BJP president Harsh Malhotra, the chief minister said the last 12 years under Modi's leadership marked achievements in various fields and earned the "unshakeable" trust of 140 crore people. She said PM Modi has scripted a new definition of change and transformation in urban transport, witnessing the Metro rail network expand to over 1,000 kilometres in the last 14 years, India emerging as the third-biggest aviation market, and digital transformation.

The chief minister said 'Atmanirbhar Bharat' led to a sixfold growth in electronics manufacturing during



Delhi BJP state President Harsh Malhotra, left, along with state Chief Minister Rekha Gupta addresses a press conference regarding 12 years of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's governance in New Delhi

PTI

the period, defence sector corridors were set up in UP and Tamil Nadu, and India now exports defence items to over 100 countries. Cultural heritage received a boost with the construction of the Ram Temple in Ayodhya and the redevelopment of religious corridors in Varanasi, Kedarnath, and Ujjain, she said. Modi set the record for the longest-serving elected prime minister

on June 10, coinciding with the BJP's 12 years in power at the Centre.

The Chief Minister highlighted Delhi-specific infrastructure delivered with Central support over the past 12 years. Delhi has received Rs 1.25 lakh crore for road development. Projects completed or underway include the Delhi-Meerut Expressway, Dwarka Expressway, Eastern and

MANOJ TIWARI RELEASES NEW SONG TO MARK 12 YEARS OF PM MODI'S GOVERNMENT

New Delhi: Delhi North East MP and well-known Bhojpuri singer Manoj Tiwari on Friday released a song titled 'Sapna Hai Yahi Modi Ka' to commemorate the completion of 12 years of the Government led by Prime Minister Narendra Modi. Tiwari, who wrote the song, said the 3:50-minute video is dedicated to PM Modi's dream for India and his "tireless" work to keep the country's flag flying higher. The song features visuals of Modi at temples,

the Parliament, and various science exhibitions. Its lyrics highlight the Prime Minister's deep love for the nation and his dedication to upholding its honour. Sapna Hai Yahi Modi Ka' also narrates the warm receptions Modi has received at rallies across the country over the years. The North East Delhi MP said the song highlights Modi's concern for the country, the poor, and the farmers, and expresses the people's affection towards him. (PNS)

Western Peripheral Expressways, Urban Extension Road-II, Delhi-Dehradun Expressway, and the Namoo Bharat Corridor.

A nearly 10-kilometre new Metro corridor from R.K. Ashram Marg to Indraprastha has been approved, providing direct connectivity to Bharat Mandapam, India Gate, the Central Secretariat, and Kartavya Bhavan. "Twelve years of develop-

ment, twelve years of trust, and twelve years of commitment to public service have written a new chapter every single day, ensuring that the benefits reach all 1.4 billion citizens of the country," the Chief Minister said.

She said Delhi has received 4,550 electric buses under the FAME scheme, with approval for 6,130 additional buses under the PM e-Drive initiative.

City records coolest June day so far

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Rain and thunderstorm activity brought temperatures down sharply across Delhi on Friday, making it the coolest day of June so far, while the India Meteorological Department (IMD) has forecast more thunderstorms, rain and gusty winds through Saturday.

The maximum temperature at Safdarjung, the city's base station, settled at 34.6 degrees Celsius, 5.3 degrees Celsius below normal and 4.1 degrees Celsius lower than the previous day.

The minimum temperature was recorded at 22.8 degrees Celsius, 5.2 degrees Celsius below normal and 7.2 degrees Celsius lower than a day earlier. At Palam, the



maximum temperature was 33.5 degrees Celsius, 6.7 degrees Celsius below normal and 4.3 degrees Celsius lower than the previous day. The minimum temperature was 21.6 degrees Celsius, 6.5 degrees Celsius below normal and 7.0 degrees Celsius lower than the previous day.

At Lodhi Road, the maximum temperature was 33.1 degrees Celsius, 5.9 degrees Celsius below normal and 4.7 degrees Celsius lower than the previous day.

Rising leopard sightings in Asola Bhatti Sanctuary reflect improving habitat: Forest officials

VARSHA SAGI
■ New Delhi

Leopard sightings have become an almost daily occurrence in Delhi's Asola Bhatti Wildlife Sanctuary, with forest officials reporting a rise in the big cat population and frequent camera-trap recordings of leopard pairs — a development they say reflects improving habitat conditions.

Officials estimate the leopard population in and around the Asola Bhatti landscape has increased from around 12-14 animals in 2022 to about an estimated 16 at present. However, they cautioned that the figure is based on camera-trap records and field observations and can only be confirmed through a

detailed census exercise.

Among the developments that have particularly excited wildlife officials are repeated sightings of leopard pairs near water bodies inside the sanctuary. Officials said such sightings are relatively rare because leopards are generally solitary animals and are usually seen together only during courtship, mating or while raising cubs.

"A few years ago, seeing leopards this frequently was uncommon. Today, our camera traps are recording them almost every day. We are also seeing repeated sightings of leopard pairs, which is significant," a forest official said.

The increase is not limited to leopards. Officials said



A leopard is captured on a camera trap at Asola-Bhatti Wildlife Sanctuary in New Delhi

PTI

sightings of spotted deer and wild boar have risen substantially, while the peafowl population has grown so much that the birds are now commonly seen occupying roads and tracks across parts of the sanctuary.

"Peacocks are visible almost everywhere now. Their numbers have increased significantly and in some stretches they can be seen across roads and pathways inside the sanctuary," an official said.

According to officials, the rise in wildlife activity points towards a broader ecological improvement within the sanctuary. They said the growing presence of several species indicates that food, water and shelter are becoming more readily available across the

landscape.

Another senior official said that species such as peafowl, francolins and deer serve as important indicators of habitat quality.

"There are certain species that we call indicator species. Their presence helps us understand whether a habitat is improving or deteriorating. An increase in species such as

peafowl, francolins and deer suggests that habitat conditions are getting better," he said. Officials attribute the trend to a combination of habitat management measures undertaken over the past several years.

More than 200 water holes have been developed and maintained across the sanctuary, ensuring year-round water availability for wildlife. At the same time, plantations carried out several years ago have matured, with many trees now forming dense canopy cover.

"The plantations undertaken in earlier years have now matured and started forming canopies. The forest is gradually becoming denser, offering more shade, cover and suit-

able habitat for wildlife," an official said. The improved habitat has also resulted in a stronger prey base.

Officials said sightings of spotted deer and wild boar have increased considerably, providing favourable conditions for predators such as leopards to remain within the sanctuary.

Historically, leopards have used the Asola Bhatti landscape as part of a larger movement corridor connecting forested areas of the Aravallis in Haryana with Delhi. While such movement continues, officials say recent camera-trap records suggest some animals are now spending longer periods within the sanctuary.

"Earlier, many leopards

would largely move through the landscape. We are now seeing signs that some are establishing territories within the sanctuary itself," an official said.

Officials also believe that cubs recorded in recent years have now matured and started occupying territories of their own, contributing to the growing number of sightings being captured on camera traps. Apart from leopards, hyenas are also being recorded during nighttime monitoring exercises.

Officials said the simultaneous increase in sightings of predators, prey species and indicator species presents one of the clearest signs yet that the sanctuary's ecosystem is becoming more robust. (PTI)

IN FOCUS



A woman holding a placard thanking commuters for opting public transport during the Weekly Public Transport Day campaign launched by Mumbai Metropolitan Region Development Authority in Mumbai

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

IMD confirms El Niño onset, warns of monsoon impact

The India Meteorological Department on Friday declared the onset of El Niño conditions over the equatorial Pacific Ocean. It also said these conditions are expected to strengthen further during the southwest monsoon season.

“The atmosphere has responded to the warming sea surface temperatures, and the coupled ocean-atmosphere system now exhibits characteristics consistent with El Niño conditions,” the India Meteorological Department (IMD) said.

The last time El Niño conditions developed was in 2023. Since 2000, these conditions have emerged in 2002, 2009 and 2015.

El Niño is one of the three phases of the El Niño Southern Oscillation (ENSO), a climate phenomenon characterised by changes in sea temperatures along the central and eastern tropical Pacific Ocean, accompanied by fluctuations in the atmosphere overhead. While El



SDRF personnel at the spot after a 15-member trekking team, which had set out from Badrinath, lost its way due to dense fog and adverse weather while crossing the Saraswati river near Musa Pani in Chamoli, Uttarakhand

PTI

Niño is known to have a warming effect over the planet, its opposite phase, called La Nina, usually results in a cooling effect. ENSO also has a neutral phase. El Niño leads

to less rainfall in India, and its emergence could be one of the reasons why the country this year is expected to receive below-normal rainfall during the monsoon season,

according to experts. On May 29, the IMD said rainfall this monsoon is likely to be about 90 per cent of the long-period average (LPA) with a model error of 4 per cent. LPA

refers to the rainfall recorded over a particular region for a given interval, such as a month or season, averaged over a long period, typically 30 to 50 years.

The LPA of seasonal rainfall over India, based on data from 1971 to 2020, is 87 cm. If the monsoon season sees less than 90 per cent of the LPA rainfall, the IMD classifies it as ‘deficient’. India receives more than 70 per cent of its annual rainfall during the monsoon months, making the season critical for farming, drinking water supply, hydroelectric power generation and groundwater replenishment.

This year, the arrival of monsoon got delayed, as its onset over Kerala occurred on June 4.” Typically, it takes place on June 1.

On Friday, the IMD said that conditions are favourable for the monsoon to advance into some more parts of the central Arabian Sea, Maharashtra, the remaining parts of Karnataka, Telangana, Andhra Pradesh, and West Bengal over the next two to three days.

TMC rebel MPs to seek recognition as main party from LS Speaker

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The Trinamool Congress ran into more trouble on Friday as dissident MPs, claiming support from 19 Lok Sabha members, said they would seek recognition from Speaker Om Birla next week as the main TMC parliamentary group. The party, led by Mamata Banerjee, dismissed the move, citing the anti-defection law.

Rebel MP Jagadish Chandra Barma Basunia said the group had already sent a letter to the Speaker and would officially present its claim on Monday.

Basunia said the group has already submitted the letter and will present its claim to the Speaker on Monday. He said they started collecting signatures on



Jagadish Chandra Barma Basunia

June 8, and 19 MPs have signed the letter. Sources said the exact time for the meeting with the Speaker was still undecided.

The TMC said the dissidents’ claim is not legally valid. Party MP Mahua Moitra said the 91st Amendment to the Constitution removed the option for a split, so

lawmakers who want to leave a party must merge with another political party.

This situation comes as the TMC continues to face internal problems that started after its loss in the West Bengal assembly elections and have now reached Parliament. During the turmoil, a list reportedly including 19 TMC Lok Sabha MPs was shared online.

The letter to Birla has not been made public, and while dissident TMC leaders say it backs their claim, it has not been independently verified.

The list is said to include Kakoli Ghosh Dasgupta, Satabdi Roy, Bapi Haldar, Sharmila Sarkar, Prasun Bandyopadhyay, Jagadish Barma Basunia, Asit Kumar Mal, Arup Chakraborty, Rachna Banerjee, Saayoni Ghosh, Khalilur Rahaman,

Abu Taher Khan, Yusuf Pathan, Mitali Bag, Mala Roy, Kalipada Soren, Deepak Adhikari, June Malia, and Partha Bhowmick.

TMC MP Kirti Azad alleged that the BJP is trying to cause defections through Operation Lotus and said attempts to split the party have failed.

He cited a visit by Rajya Sabha MP Prakash Chik Baraik to BJP leader Nishikant Dubey’s residence, a meeting of dissident MPs at Union minister Bhupender Yadav’s residence, and BJP leader Suwendu Adhikari’s visit to TMC MP Satabdi Roy’s residence as evidence of an organised effort to weaken the party.

Baraik became the third TMC parliamentarian this week to quit both the party and the Rajya Sabha, after Sukhendu Sekhar Ray

and Sushmita Dev.

The crisis has also revealed divisions within the party.

On Thursday, senior TMC leader Kalyan Banerjee criticised national general secretary Abhishek Banerjee and said he would remain in the party only if Abhishek is removed from all leadership positions.

At the same time, Basunia supported Kalyan Banerjee’s criticism of Abhishek Banerjee and pushed back against Azad’s claim that dissident MPs were being paid to change sides.

Basunia called Kirti Azad a liar and said it was wrong to make such allegations. He said there are 19 MPs and that Azad is also an MP, so the claim is unjustified.

The turmoil has also led to changes in the party’s setup in

Delhi. The TMC has moved its operations from 20, Rajendra Prasad Road back to the residence of Rajya Sabha MP Md Nadimul Haque at 61, South Avenue.

Bhowmick, one of the MPs linked to the dissident group, gave up his bungalow and asked for a flat instead, according to sources. The West Bengal-based party has seen several departures this week, with three Rajya Sabha MPs — Sukhendu Sekhar Ray, Sushmita Dev, and Prakash Chik Baraik — resigning from the party.

However, Lok Sabha MPs Sougata Roy, Shatrughan Sinha, and Pratima Mondal, along with Rajya Sabha MP Babul Supriyo, have denied being part of any dissident group and said they will stay with the party.

TN CM announces ₹134.83 crore Kuruvai package for paddy farmers



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chennai

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay on Friday announced a ₹134.83 crore Kuruvai special package for paddy growers to mitigate the impact of the delayed southwest monsoon, which has deferred the customary opening of the Mettur dam on June 12 for irrigation.

The package covers the Cauvery delta districts—Thanjavur, Tiruvallur, and Nagapattinam—as well as non-Cauvery delta districts, to help farmers raise the Kuruvai, a short-duration paddy crop sown in June and harvested in September. It would also help farmers raise the 120-day crop during the Kar and Sornavari seasons, which begin in April and May, respectively. Normally, the Mettur reservoir is opened on June 12 every year to facilitate agricultural operations. However, with the weather office forecasting below-normal rainfall due to the El Niño phenomenon, the southwest monsoon has been severely delayed.

“The water level in the Mettur dam currently stands at 79.56 feet, and as a result, there is no possibility of opening the sluice gates today,” a government release said. While the delayed water release has restricted the standard cultivation of five lakh acres in the Cauvery delta.

District administration releases route map of Kozhikode Nipah patient

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kozhikode

The district administration on Friday released the route map of a 43-year-old man infected with the Nipah virus and admitted to the Government Medical College Hospital, officials said.

The Ramanattukara native is currently on ventilator support. The district administration has taken preventive measures, including quarantining people who came into contact with him.

According to the route map, the patient remained at home on May 30 and June 1. On June 2, he visited a private hospital in Feroke, where he stayed in the OP waiting area, visited the laboratory and day-care ward, and returned home by car at 12.50 pm.

On June 3, 4, 5, and 6, he visited a post office near Feroke College by car and returned home.

He again visited the private hospital on June 7, travelling by autorickshaw. He was first admitted to the casualty department and later shifted to a private room. On June 8, he was discharged from the Feroke hospital and shifted to a private healthcare facility in Kozhikode.

He was admitted to a



ward there, underwent several tests, and was shifted to an isolation ward at 4.30 pm on June 9. On June 10, after preliminary tests indicated a Nipah infection, he was shifted to Kozhikode Government Medical College Hospital at 11.30 pm.

The district administration has so far identified 77 persons on the contact list. Of these, 58 are healthcare workers, 14 are family members, and five are friends and colleagues. Among the 77 contacts, two have been classified in the highest-risk category, 13 in the high-risk category, and 62 in the low-risk category. All those in the highest-risk and high-risk categories have been placed under quarantine, a statement said.

A document on the Kerala Directorate of Health Services website states that the Nipah virus is a zoonotic virus capable of transmission between animals and humans. Fruit bats, also

known as flying foxes, are its natural reservoir. The virus can also cause illness in pigs. Nipah virus infection is associated with encephalitis (swelling of the brain) and can cause mild to severe illness and even death. Outbreaks occur almost annually in parts of Asia, primarily Bangladesh and India, the document said. The document states that Nipah virus infection can be prevented by avoiding contact with sick pigs and bats and by not consuming raw date palm sap, which may be contaminated.

Standard infection-control practices can help prevent transmission in hospitals during outbreaks, it added.

The Animal Husbandry Department has set up a district-level control room in Kozhikode following the confirmation of the Nipah case to prevent animal-to-human transmission and coordinate surveillance and preventive measures.

Timeline for AI-171 crash report declined

RAJESH KUMAR ■ New Delhi

The Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau (AAIB) on Friday refused to make public a definitive timeline for the final report on the causes of the air crash in Ahmedabad on June 12, 2025.

“The final report will be released upon completion of all investigative activities and the requisite international review and consultation processes prescribed under ICAO Annex 13,” it said. ICAO (International Civil Aviation Organization) Annexure 13 refers to investigations into aircraft accidents.

The probe agency’s statement came as families of victims, friends and members of the aviation community gathered in Mumbai to mark the first anniversary of the Air India AI-171 crash. It offered condolences to families and



Family members of victims of the Air India AI-171 plane crash attending an event organised on the first anniversary of the tragedy in Ahmedabad on Friday

PTI

assured the probe is being conducted in a comprehensive manner to ensure blame or liability is not assigned inappropriately.

Air India’s Boeing 787-8 or Dreamliner with registration VT-ANB en route to London Gatwick crashed soon after takeoff on June 12, 2025, killing 241 people onboard and 19 on the ground. A lone passenger

survived. Victims included citizens of India, the UK, Portugal and Canada.

Civil Aviation Minister K Ramamohan Naidu paid tribute to the victims, saying the investigation into the tragedy was continuing with “diligence and professionalism”. “The investigation continues with diligence and professionalism in accordance with established

national and international procedures. We remain committed to a thorough and objective determination of the causes of the accident and to further enhancing aviation safety,” he said.

AAIB urged all stakeholders, including the media and the public, to refrain from speculation or premature conclusions while the investigation remains in progress.

Pradhan releases two strategic documents on Bharat Innovates

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan on Friday released two strategic documents on Bharat Innovates, showcasing India’s emerging innovation and startup ecosystem rooted in higher education

and research institutions. The documents were released ahead of Bharat Innovates 2026, to be held in Nice, France, from June 14-16 under the aegis of the India-France Year of Innovation.

Speaking on the occasion, Pradhan said that one of the core objectives of the National Education Policy



(NEP) 2020 is to transform India from a system of knowledge consumption to a system of knowledge creation and innovation.

He noted that the startups featured in the Bharat Innovates Strategic Documents are emerging from India’s premier institutions, incubators

and research ecosystems, reflecting the growing innovation capacity of the country’s higher education sector. “Bharat Innovates reflects the vision articulated by Prime Minister Narendra Modi to take India’s innovation capabilities to the global stage,” Pradhan said.

India defends energy choices

He said there was broad agreement that the international community must continue efforts to mitigate the consequences of conflicts and create conditions conducive to diplomacy.

Jaishankar also emphasised the importance of “de-risking and diversifying” supply chains and “building greater resilience and redundancy in an increasingly volatile world”.

On energy security, he reiterated that India’s energy choices are guided by national interest and that purchases are based on considerations of affordability and availability.

Referring to India’s engagement with West Asia, Jaishankar underscored the centrality of the Gulf region in New Delhi’s foreign policy, “underpinned by strong people-to-people ties, energy cooperation, and growing strategic and defence partnership”. The minister also observed that the nature of warfare is undergoing rapid transformation, with emerging technologies, new weapons systems and evolving tactics coexisting with conventional forms of conflict.

He said these developments were opening new avenues for defence and strategic cooperation between India and Europe.

Highlighting the growing momentum in India-Europe ties, Jaishankar noted that India and the

European Union had this year concluded negotiations on a Free Trade Agreement, signed a Strategic and Defence Partnership, and finalised a Comprehensive Mobility Cooperation Framework. He said these developments reflected the “growing depth” of the relationship.

Earlier in the day, Jaishankar arrived in Finland from Bulgaria on the concluding leg of his two-nation tour to participate in the Kulturenta Talks.

The annual dialogue, hosted by Finnish President Alexander Stubb, brings together senior leaders and policymakers to discuss global and regional security challenges.

Three of family killed in Delhi building fire

DFS personnel climbed to the terrace, cut open a locked gate and entered from above. CATS ambulances and PCR personnel then rescued two young women stranded on the rooftop and rushed them to the hospital.

Mohan, a resident of the third floor who was travelling to Jaipur when the fire broke out, rushed back after receiving a phone call from neighbours.

“I got a call from one of the neighbours. I returned just an hour ago. My wife and I stay in this flat. I haven’t been allowed to enter because

the crime team and forensic experts are still examining the building,” he said.

The incident has once again raised concerns about fire safety in Delhi’s densely populated residential colonies, where narrow lanes, inadequate ventilation, and EV charging in parking areas can complicate firefighting operations and increase the risk of smoke-inhalation fatalities. Police said the investigation is underway to ascertain the exact cause of the blaze.

Security intensified for Amarnath Yatra

To ensure safety, traditional security measures will be strengthened through the extensive use of drones, CCTV monitoring, surveillance systems, and other modern technologies. Senior officers from CAPFs and J&K Police will continuously monitor camp sites. Following Union Home Minister Amit Shah’s review meeting in June 2026, a robust security system has been established.

Officials said that over 670 companies of the Central Armed Police Forces, or about 67,000 personnel, will be deployed. Apart from CAPFs, personnel from J&K Police and the Army, including women’s units, will be deployed. Several checkpoints will be set up along both the Pahalgam and Baltal routes. Drones will be used for aerial

surveillance; CCTV cameras will be placed at camps and key locations; and advanced screening will include X-ray baggage systems, metal detectors, explosive detectors, RCIED jammers, and sniffer dogs.

The area will be a “No Flying Zone” from July 1, 2026, until the yatra ends. Senior officers will monitor camps at all times, and locals and animals involved in the yatra must register with a QR code.

Screening at entry points will include thorough checks to prevent contraband or threats.

These protocols ensure a secure and welcoming environment for pilgrims. The next area is Health and Medical Safety. 4. Health and Medical Safety Protocols. Because of the high altitude, Medical Aid Centres are set up about every 2 km along the routes. These centres have oxygen cylinders, life-saving medicines, and trained staff.

There will be 4x4 ambulances, shuttle services, and emergency response teams available at key points, including Pissu Top, Zoji Bal, Pancharni, and Domail.

Comprehensive arrangements cover every aspect of the pilgrimage, including pilgrim registration through the Shri Amarnathji Shrine Board, accommodation in camps, healthcare services for high-altitude challenges such as Acute Mountain Sickness, and disaster management plans for weather-related risks, including snow,

rain, and landslides. Real-time weather forecasts will guide the movement of pilgrim batches.

National Security Advisor Ajit Doval, Jammu and Kashmir Lt Governor Manoj Sinha, Army Chief Gen Upendra Dwivedi, Home Secretary Govind Mohan, Intelligence Bureau Chief Tapan Kumar Deka, CRPF Director General GP Singh, and other senior officials attended the meeting. Central and Union Territory agencies are coordinating closely for a massive yet seamless security deployment.

All rise! She walked in, slammed the gavel...

How an unauthorised person was able to access a restricted area, reach the judge’s dais, and handle official case files has become a major talking point. Videos of the incident, showing Vandana Gupta on the bench giving orders and banging the gavel, have gone viral on social media. As of Friday evening, she is still in police custody at Cantt Police Station. No formal FIRs or charges have been confirmed yet, but authorities are looking into possible offences, including trespass and disruption of court proceedings. More details are expected as the investigation continues. The incident points out weaknesses in court security, especially when judges are on leave.

Modi Govt model advancing respect, safety of women: Shah

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Friday said the Modi Government's "women-led development" model is advancing the respect, safety and empowerment of 'nari shakti'.

In a post on social media, Shah highlighted a range of welfare and empowerment measures undertaken during the tenure of the NDA Government, which completed 12 years in office this week.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi became India's longest continuously serving elected PM this week.

"From 'Beti Bachao, Beti Padhao' to over 10 crore gas



connections under the Ujjwala scheme and more than 12 crore toilets, the dignity and convenience of women have been accord-

ed the highest priority," Shah said.

A large share of beneficiaries under the Mudra scheme are women entre-

preneurs, he said.

"Through the Mudra scheme, 70 per cent of women have been linked to self-employment by providing loans without collateral. 'Lakshpati Didi', 'Crorepati Didi', and self-help groups have made them economically self-reliant. Meanwhile, the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam has paved the way for 33 per cent participation of women in politics," he added.

Shah said the impact of these initiatives is visible across diverse fields.

"The result of this is that today women are playing leading roles in every field, including the Army, space, sports, research and industry," he said.

Suvendu to meet rebel TMC MPs in Delhi



PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari plans to meet a group of rebel Trinamool Congress (TMC) Lok Sabha MPs in Delhi on Sunday. The group is scheduled to meet Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla on Monday to claim recognition as the "real TMC" parliamentary group.

This meeting comes as the TMC's parliamentary wing faces a crisis after the

party's heavy defeat in the May 2026 West Bengal Assembly elections. The loss ended TMC's 15-year rule and made Suvendu Adhikari the State's first BJP Chief Minister. Sources say that about 19 of the TMC's 28 Lok Sabha MPs have joined the rebel group, which is led by senior MPs such as Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar and Jagadish Chandra Barma Basunia from Cooch Behar. The group has already sent a representation to Speaker Om Birla.

Rebel MP Jagadish Chandra Barma Basunia told reporters that the group began collecting signatures on June 8, and plans to push for recognition as the legitimate TMC parliamentary group. "We have submitted the letter... On Monday, we will go to the Speaker and stake our claim," he said. The rebels say their actions reflect the public's will after TMC's election loss. They have denied any inducement or involvement in "Operation Lotus," and Basunia called loyalist MP Kirti Azad's accusations baseless.

Sunday's meeting with Suvendu Adhikari comes after earlier talks, including one at Union Minister Bhupender Yadav's home, where several rebel MPs met the West Bengal Chief Minister and BJP leaders. The rebels have named Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar as their Chief

Whip and Shatabdi Roy as deputy. These moves are a major challenge for Mamata Banerjee's TMC, which has already been weakened by several resignations in Parliament, including those of Rajya Sabha MPs Sukhendu Sekhar Ray, Sushmita Dev, and Prakash Chik Baraik in recent days.

Political observers view Sunday's meeting as a strategic move by the new BJP-led State Government to build support in Parliament and put more pressure on the TMC leadership. With almost two-thirds of TMC's Lok Sabha MPs said to be with the rebels, the party could soon face a formal split in Parliament. In the next few days, it will become clear whether the rebels gain separate recognition from the Speaker and whether this split leads to further political changes in West Bengal and at the national level.

CPI(M) hails Delhi HC verdict quashing cases against NewsClick



CPI (M) General Secretary MA Baby, NewsClick Editor-in-Chief Prabir Purkayastha

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Polit Bureau of the Communist Party of India (Marxist) on Friday welcomed the Delhi High Court judgement quashing the FIR registered by the Economic Offences Wing of the Delhi Police and the subsequent Enforcement Directorate (ED) case against news portal NewsClick and its Editor-in-Chief, Prabir Purkayastha.

Terming the verdict a major victory, the CPI(M) stated that the high court's ruling serves as a "stern warning" against the targeted misuse of Central Government agencies to carry out political vendetta.

In a press statement issued by the party's Central Committee Office, the left party claimed that indepen-



dent media platforms like NewsClick have come under severe attack from the establishment for refusing to align with corporate-political interests.

"It was their fearless reporting of people's movements that resulted in the concocted charges that have now been quashed," the CPI(M) statement said, adding that the portal became a "thorn in the side" of the BJP-led Union Government due to its relentless coverage of the year-long farmers' struggle.

The party further noted that the relentless journalism of the portal had led to an intensified state crackdown, culminating in the invocation of the draconian Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act (UAPA) and the prolonged imprison-

ment of Purkayastha.

"Right from the outset, it was clear that the action against NewsClick and Purkayastha by agencies under the Union Government was nothing but a plot to target critical journalism and suppress dissent," the statement added, hailing the judicial outcome as a triumph for the freedom of the press and the democratic rights of citizens.

Citing the observations of the Delhi High Court, which categorised the ED case against the news portal as a "gross abuse of the process of law", the CPI(M) demanded that the Union Government and its investigation agencies immediately withdraw and quash all other pending cases foisted upon NewsClick and its Editor-in-Chief.

Vaishnaw calls for greater accountability in railway recruitment system

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Railway Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw on Friday held a high-level review meeting with senior officials on the functioning of the Railway Recruitment Board and underlined the need for a more transparent, accurate and technology-driven system.

Vaishnaw noted that the annual recruitment calendar, coupled with quarterly notifications of vacancies, has been well received by candidates, the railway ministry said in a statement.

He said the calendar-based recruitment framework has enabled aspirants to plan their preparation more effectively as it brings greater predictability to the recruitment process.

Emphasising the need for continuous improvement, Vaishnaw stated that the railway recruitment system must keep evolving through the use of technology, faster processes and greater accountability, the statement said.

Vaishnaw also reviewed the progress made in shifting departmental examinations to Computer-Based Test (CBT)

BJP demands Rahul Gandhi's apology over RS nominee row

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP on Friday launched a sharp attack on the Congress after the Supreme Court rejected Meenakshi Natarajan's plea challenging the rejection of her Rajya Sabha nomination papers in Madhya Pradesh, saying Rahul Gandhi should apologise to the people of India.

During the hearing on Friday, the top court said that once a candidate's nomination is rejected by the returning officer, the only remedy available is to approach the Election Commission.

In a post on social media, BJP national spokesperson Pradeep Bhandari alleged that the episode exposes infighting within the opposition party and accused Gandhi of playing the "victim card".

"After Supreme Court's rejection of Natarajan's plea, Rahul Gandhi should apologise to the people of India," he said.

The BJP spokesperson claimed that Gandhi's "own house is not in order" and alleged that his preferred candidate is defeated because of rivalry within the Congress.

Bhandari also alleged that the Congress government in Telangana facilitated the defeat of the party's candidate and accused Gandhi of repeatedly portraying himself as a victim.



BJP national spokesperson Pradeep Bhandari

"His own Government in Telangana facilitated the defeat of Congress candidate; Rahul should stop over playing the 'victim card'. Even Congress workers are bored of it; can see through it," he said.

Claiming that the developments have exposed divisions within the Congress, Bhandari said, "The only truth is: Congress defeats Rahul Gandhi's Rajya Sabha candidate nominee."

Another BJP national spokesperson Shehzad Poonawalla called the court's decision a "huge slap" for the Congress and alleged that the party seeks to create doubts about constitutional bodies.

"This is a Supreme slap for the Congress party. It is a huge setback for them," he said in a video statement.

Claiming that the Congress has repeatedly targeted institutions, Poonawalla said, "The Congress is constantly trying to create an atmosphere against constitutional institutions. They claimed the Election Commission was wrong and accused it of stealing seats. Will they now say the verdict has been stolen as well?"

"The Supreme Court has categorically rejected the allegations being made by the Congress party and its ecosystem. The Congress must introspect. Why did Meenakshi Natarajan not disclose details of the case against her?" he said.

Nation Focus



NO SINDHU WATER FOR TERROR PATRONS: RAJNATH SINGH

Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Friday condemned Pakistan's support for terrorism and said the NDA Government would not allow the waters of the Sindhu river to reach those who sponsor it.

Addressing an 'Intellectuals Meet' organised in Hyderabad by Telangana BJP, he said that through Operation Sindoor, the government had shown the world that it knows how to respond to those who do not understand the language of peace and harmony, in their own language.

He criticised Congress and other Opposition leaders for questioning Operation Sindoor and the bravery of soldiers, saying the Government had stated it would stop the supply of grain and water to Pakistan if terror attacks were carried out against India. (PTI)



INDIA SPACE CONGRESS TO BEGIN IN NEW DELHI FROM JUNE 15

Policymakers, diplomats, and industry leaders from several countries will gather in New Delhi for the India Space Congress (ISC) 2026 from June 15 to June 17 to deliberate on the future of India's space sector. The three-day event, organised by Satcom Industry Association (SIA)-India, will host over 600 participants, including 200 speakers and moderators, from over 25 countries. Representatives from Government agencies, international organisations, private industry, research institutions, and strategic stakeholders are expected to take part in the event. The congress comes at a time when the global space economy is moving towards the trillion-dollar mark, and India has set a target of building a \$44-billion space economy by 2033. (PTI)

CBI files charge sheets in ₹657 crore bank fraud cases

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) on Friday filed two separate charge sheets over the alleged siphoning of funds belonging to the Haryana Government and Chandigarh Smart City Limited (CSSL) from IDFC First Bank, officials said.

Officials said the funds, cumulatively worth ₹657 crore, were siphoned off.

The case concerns a scheme in which Government funds were allegedly funnelled through fictitious transactions into accounts linked to shell entities.

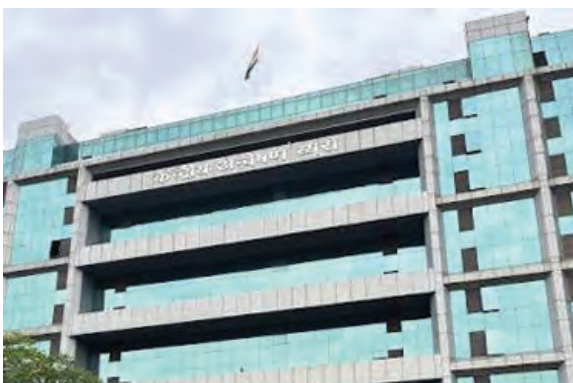
According to a CBI spokesperson, the loss is ₹504 crore in the Haryana Government case and ₹153 crore in the CSSL case.

In the Haryana government's case, the CBI filed a chargesheet before the Special Court in Panchkula.

The case involving eight departments of the Haryana government was transferred to the CBI from the State Vigilance and Anti-Corruption Bureau.

Two private individuals, both recipients of the ill-got money, were accused in the case.

"This is the second



chargesheet in the Haryana Government case. The CBI has already charged 15 accused persons and companies, including three Government servants, six bankers, two companies and four private persons," the spokesperson said.

In the CSSL case, the chargesheet was filed before the Special Court in Chandigarh against seven people, including five bank officials, one CSSL official and one private person. This is the first charge sheet in this case.

The CBI had taken over two cases from the Economic Offences Police Station in Chandigarh, one relating to CSSL and the other to CREST Chandigarh.

"Offences cited in the chargesheets relate to criminal conspiracy, criminal

breach of trust, forgery and cheating, along with offences under the Prevention of Corruption Act," the CBI spokesperson said. The agency will file more charge sheets in these cases, officials said.

The probe shows that huge funds were transferred to shell companies and minor jewellery entities, and then siphoned off under the guise of gold purchases and real estate investments, sources said.

They said a significant number of cash withdrawals were also noted in this money trail.

The role of a Chandigarh-based hotelier involved in real estate projects in the Tricity is also under the scanner. AU Small Finance Bank is also under the scanner.

ABRSM seeks PM's help to protect pre-2010 teachers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A national-level teachers' organisation on Friday said it will seek legislative and policy protection for teachers appointed before the TET was notified as a mandatory qualification in 2010.

A letter in this regard will be submitted to Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan, the Delhi unit of the Akhil Bharatiya Rashtriya Shaikshik Mahasangh (ABRSM) said in a statement.

Over 25 lakh teachers across the country are facing anxiety and uncertainty following the Supreme Court's May 29 order disposing of review petitions related to TET eligibility requirements, the organisation said.

It further said the National Council for Teacher Education notified the Teacher Eligibility Test (TET) as a minimum qualification for teachers on August 23, 2010. Before that, appointments in various states had already been made in accordance with the rules.



Union Minister of State for Health and Family Welfare Anupriya Patel exchange greetings with Jordan Ambassador to India, Youssef Abdelghani, during the 80th Independence Day celebrations of the Hashemite Kingdom of Jordan in New Delhi on Thursday. PANKAJ KUMAR

FIR against Mamata over provocative remarks during Bengal poll campaign

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

An FIR has been registered against former West Bengal chief minister and TMC supremo Mamata Banerjee for allegedly making provocative remarks during the last Assembly poll campaign, a senior officer said on Friday.

A person lodged a complaint at the Netaji Nagar Police Station, alleging that Banerjee's comments at a party programme at the Metro Channel in Kolkata's Esplanade area on March 9 were "capable of promoting



enmity between communities", he said.

The case was initially registered as a "zero FIR", and later transferred to the Hare Street Police Station as the place where the TMC supremo had allegedly made the comments comes

under its jurisdiction, the officer said.

"The complainant alleged that Banerjee's statements had the potential to disturb peace and adversely affect communal harmony and democratic norms," he said.

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States Focus

■



CM NAIDU ASSURES SUPPORT TO SLAIN ANDHRA SAILOR'S FAMILY

Andhra Pradesh CM N Chandrababu Naidu on Friday expressed grief over the death of chief engineer Patnaala Suresh from Visakhapatnam in a missile strike on a commercial vessel off the Oman coast and directed officials to extend all possible assistance to his family.

Suresh was among three Indian crew members killed in the attack on an oil tanker off the Oman coast. Officials said the vessel is currently stranded about 30 nautical miles offshore, and Omani authorities have initiated measures to bring it to port. As per the chief minister's directions, Andhra Pradesh Bhavan in New Delhi is closely monitoring the situation and is in constant touch with the Centre, the Oman Government and the Indian Embassy to expedite the repatriation process. Bhargavi, Suresh's wife, said she had received a call from the Indian Embassy in Oman informing her that officials were continuously following up on the matter and would keep the family updated as developments emerged. (PTI)



KARNATAKA CM SHIVAKUMAR CALLS ON VP RADHAKRISHNAN

Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar on Friday called on Vice President CP Radhakrishnan in New Delhi. This is Shivakumar's first meeting with the vice president after taking over as the chief minister.

Shivakumar took charge as the state chief minister on June 3, replacing Siddaramaiah. Separately, governor of Punjab and administrator of Chandigarh, Gulab Chand Kataria, called on the vice president in New Delhi, the Vice President's Secretariat said. (PTI)

J&K Minister Sakina Itoo calls for revocation of armed forces Act

MOHIT KANDHARI

Jammu

A senior woman Cabinet minister in the Omar Abdullah-led council of ministers on Friday called for the revocation of the Armed Forces (Special Powers) Act (AFSPA) from the Union Territory, arguing that if the Centre believes the security situation has improved elsewhere, the same principle should apply to Jammu and Kashmir.

The statement made by Health and Education Minister Sakina Itoo has once again brought the contentious issue of the revocation of the Armed Forces Special Powers Act to the centre stage after a long gap.

During his previous tenure as Chief Minister, Omar Abdullah aggressively pursued the partial withdrawal of AFSPA from specific districts where the army had no active operational role. Reacting to the recent statement by Union Home Minister Amit Shah that the AFSPA would be withdrawn from the entire Northeast next year, except for one or two states, Sakina Itoo said Jammu and Kashmir also deserves similar consideration if the Government main-



tains that the situation on the ground has improved.

"If it is better, then it should be removed from here too. If they say that the situation has improved, now there is nothing here. Now there are no stones, nothing is happening. After that, I think it should be removed from here first," Itoo told reporters.

The minister also reiterated the demand for the restoration of statehood to Jammu and Kashmir, saying the elected Government has consistently raised the issue with the Centre.

"We have been trying for two years. Our Chief Minister

■

Suvendu warns of stringent action against vandalism

■

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

Kolkata

West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari on Friday issued a stern warning against incidents of vandalism and attacks on police personnel, declaring that "no one will be worse than me" if anyone attempts to disturb law and order in the State.

Projecting his Government as one pursuing a policy of "zero tolerance" towards unrest and anti-social activities, Adhikari said the stringent legal action would be taken against those who indulge in violence or take the law into their own hands.

Addressing a press conference organised by the state BJP to mark 12 years of the Narendra Modi-led Government at the Centre, the chief minister sought to draw a sharp distinction with the previous TMC regime, asserting that maintaining peace and public order remained a top priority of his administration. "After we came to power,



West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari exchanges greetings with BJP state General Secretary Locket Chatterjee during a press conference in Kolkata

there have been certain incidents, and we tackled them firmly, thus giving a clear message that there will be zero tolerance towards this kind of unrest, hooliganism and anti-social activities. We will not allow such things to continue," he said. Issuing a

stern warning, the chief minister said, "If such incidents happen again, no one will be worse than me."

The strictest action will be taken against those involved in vandalism and taking the law into their own hands." Referring to recent distur-

bances in parts of the State, he claimed that except for isolated incidents in areas such as Park Circus and Asansol, where protests took place over the use of loud-speakers at religious places and the use of bulldozers against illegal buildings, the

CID summons Abhishek again on June 14

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

Kolkata

West Bengal CID on Friday issued fresh summons to TMC leader Abhishek Banerjee for a second round of questioning on June 14 in connection with the alleged signature forgery case after investigators were reportedly dissatisfied with his responses during questioning at the department headquarters a day ago, an officer said.

Banerjee, who appeared before the state investigating agency on Thursday after skipping three earlier summonses and following directions from the Calcutta High Court, was questioned for several hours by a team of senior officers.

Banerjee replied "I do not know" to several questions relating to the disputed res-



olution submitted to the Assembly, and allegedly lost his temper at certain stages, the officer claimed.

"Several questions relating to the resolution, the signatures appearing on it, and the supporting documents could not be conclusively addressed during questioning. Certain records sought

by the investigating team are yet to be produced. He has, therefore, been asked to appear again on Sunday with relevant documents," he said. Investigators sought clarification on how signatures of legislators who were allegedly absent from the party meeting appeared on the resolution, who had signed the document, and where the original copy was located, he said.

"The investigation is focused on establishing the authenticity of the documents and the circumstances under which they were prepared and submitted. Further verification is required before any conclusion can be drawn," the officer added. On Thursday night, after leaving the CID headquarters, the TMC national general secretary

went to party supremo Mamata Banerjee's Kalighat residence, where he attended a meeting with several senior party leaders.

He later left the residence without speaking to reporters.

On May 6, TMC legislators met at Banerjee's Kalighat residence and proposed the name of Sovandeb Chattopadhyay for the post of Leader of the Opposition. Legislators present at the meeting reportedly expressed support by a show of hands.

The formal proposal, however, was not immediately submitted to the Assembly. Following the swearing-in of TMC MLAs on May 13 and 14, the Assembly Secretariat sought a resolution from the party naming its nominee for the post.

TN Speaker issues disqualification notices to 4 ex-AIADMK MLAs

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

Chennai

Tamil Nadu Assembly Speaker JCD Prabhakar on Friday said he had initiated legal proceedings against four former AIADMK legislators who quit the party and joined the TVK.

The notices seeking an explanation from them over a petition by the AIADMK to disqualify them under the Anti-Defection Law, were issued on June 9, he said.

The four former legislators — Maragatham Kumaravel, S Jayakumar, P Sathyabama and Esakki Subaya — joined the ruling Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam barely hours after resigning as AIADMK MLAs. They were among the 25 rebel leg-



Tamil Nadu Assembly Speaker JCD Prabhakar

islators who voted in favour of the TVK Government during the floor test in the Assembly on May 13.

The members have been provided a window of seven days to provide an explanation, Prabhakar told reporters.

BJP, SAD target Mann over Golden temple sacrilege

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

Chandigarh

BJP and Shiromani Akali Dal on Friday condemned the sacrilege attempt at Shaheed Baba Gurbaksh Singh Ji within the Golden Temple complex, where a man allegedly picked up a 'Sri Sahib', or sacred sword, placed in front of the Guru Granth Sahib.

The incident occurred on Wednesday night, when a man entered the sanctum during an Akhand Path and, after a 'parkarma' (circumambulating) of the Guru Granth Sahib, he suddenly picked up the Sri Sahib placed before it.

However, sewadars present at the gurdwara overpowered the man and handed him over to the police. The



BJP National spokesperson RP Singh

accused is currently in police custody.

BJP national spokesperson RP Singh called the incident a direct attack on the Sikh community's religious sentiments. "Such an act is not merely an

incident of misconduct or a security breach; it is a direct attack on the religious sentiments, faith and collective consciousness of the Sikh community," he said on X.

Singh urged the Punjab Government and law enforcement agencies to conduct a transparent, time-bound and comprehensive investigation. "Every individual connected to this incident, directly or indirectly, must be identified and brought to justice. The truth must be placed before the public, and accountability must not stop at the lowest level," he said. He added that any attempt to violate the sanctity of Sri Harmandir Sahib has consequences far beyond the immediate incident.

overall law-and-order situation in Bengal remained under control.

The remarks assume significance against the backdrop of recurring political clashes and allegations of violence that have long dominated Bengal's political discourse, with the BJP frequently accusing the previous TMC Government of being soft on anti-social elements and political intimidation.

Seeking to reinforce the BJP's governance narrative, Adhikari also highlighted what he described as the benefits of the "double-engine Government" model, asserting that coordination between the Centre and the State was already delivering tangible results.

"We will work under Modi ji's leadership and guidance. Even in this short period, we have already accomplished some work. The public has started to see the benefits of the double-engine Government, and these benefits will become even more

Debate on real TMC settled; ex-CM Mamata represents fake one: BJP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

New Delhi

The BJP on Friday claimed that a document carrying the signatures of 20 Trinamool Congress Lok Sabha MPs establishes that the "real TMC" is led by Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar, and not by Mamata Banerjee and her nephew Abhishek Banerjee.

The remarks came amid reports that 19-20 Trinamool Congress (TMC) MPs have signed a letter addressed to Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla.

In a video statement, BJP national spokesperson Shehzad Poonawalla alleged that the TMC is witnessing an "implosion" due to dynastic politics and Mamata's preference for her nephew over the party. "Proof is now out in the open. A document carrying the signatures of 20 Lok Sabha MPs of the real TMC under Kakoli Ghosh's leadership shows that the real TMC is different from what Mamata and Abhishek are representing. They are now the fake TMC," he said.

TMC plunged into a crisis following the party's defeat in the West Bengal Assembly elections in 2026, as the BJP ended Mamata's 15-year rule in the State. This included former chief minister Mamata losing her seat to Suvendu Adhikari in Bhabanipur by a margin of 15,105 votes, and a rebellion by a large section of its legislators. The turmoil later spread to

apparent in the days to come," he said.

On national security, the chief minister said his Government was expediting the transfer of land to the Border Security Force (BSF) for strengthening border infrastructure.

"Regarding national security, we have handed over land to the BSF. This process is continuing. In north Bengal, particularly in areas adjoining the Chicken's Neck corridor, fencing work has already begun," he said.

The strategic Siliguri Corridor, popularly known as the Chicken's Neck, connects the northeastern states with the rest of the country and has long been viewed as a sensitive national security zone.

CM Adhikari said his Government was committed to completing the border infrastructure projects in a time-bound manner, describing them as essential for safeguarding national security.



Shehzad Poonawalla

Parliament, with dissident MPs claiming the support of more than 20 Lok Sabha members.

Poonawalla alleged that around 65-70 TMC MLAs, as well as several Rajya Sabha MPs, are also with the "real TMC". "In the Vidhan Sabha too, around 65-70 MLAs have come together under the real TMC. Rajya Sabha MPs are also with the faction. It is a complete implosion of TMC. It is now called tukdo mein Congress," he said.

"Because she puts her nephew first and not the party, the party has moved away from her. This is what happens when you push dynastic politics. Those who have the numbers are the real TMC. Unfortunately, Mamata has very few options left. She may want to merge her party with the Congress," Poonawalla said.

Drawing parallels with other regional parties, Poonawalla alleged that leaders who promote dynastic politics eventually lose control of their parties.

Odisha CM announces free education from KG to PG

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

Bhubaneswar

Odisha Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi on Friday announced free education from the kindergarten to post-graduate levels in Government schools and colleges.

Majhi, while addressing a press conference here on the occasion of the BJP Government completing two years in the state, said the move will benefit all students of Odisha, especially those from the economically backward classes and girls.

"In order to make education truly free and universal, my Government is announcing to make education from KG to PG completely free of cost. "This will benefit all the students of the state, especially the economically backward classes and girls.

Perhaps, such a step in the field of education will be implemented for the first time in the entire country in Odisha," the chief minister said.



Union Minister Shivraj urges BRICS nations to empower small farmers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

Indore

Union Agriculture and Farmers Welfare Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan on Friday called upon BRICS nations to work together to empower small and marginal cultivators, ensure food security and promote sustainable agricultural development.

He stressed that challenges confronting the agriculture sector, including climate change and growing pressure on natural resources, could be effectively addressed only through collective efforts.

Chouhan was chairing the



Union Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan poses for photographs along with BRICS delegates during the '16th BRICS Agriculture Ministers' Conference', in Indore, Madhya Pradesh

inaugural session of a two-day meeting of agriculture ministers of BRICS countries in Indore.

He also led the ministerial dialogue on the theme "Smallholder Farmers, Women and Youth: Securing the Future of Food". "If small farmers become stronger, global food security will automatically become stronger," he said at the meeting being held under India's presidency of the grouping.

Chouhan insisted India has always stood for global unity, peace and cooperation. "Under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, India's approach is based on the principle of 'peace, not

war; coordination, not conflict'. This can serve as a guiding philosophy for global agricultural partnerships," the Union minister affirmed.

Chouhan said the BRICS platform provided an important opportunity to deliberate on the challenges facing small and marginal farmers and exchange experiences among member countries.

He maintained policy cooperation and partnerships among BRICS nations could provide a new direction to global agriculture.

The minister said the ongoing dialogue was particularly significant in finding collective solutions to issues such as climate change, pres-

sure on natural resources and market uncertainties confronting small farmers.

"We should jointly work towards empowering small farmers and promoting sustainable agricultural development," he told the gathering.

Expressing confidence that the discussions would strengthen cooperation among member nations, Chouhan opined that the exchange of experiences and best practices would benefit the agriculture sector globally. he said the country's agriculture sector had recorded notable growth over the past decade, with steady increases in foodgrain, horticulture and fisheries production.

NEET-UG 2026: NTA extends exam time, adds rough space

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The National Testing Agency (NTA) on Friday announced a series of student-friendly measures for NEET (UG) 2026, including additional rough-work space and an extended examination window.

The medical entrance examination is scheduled to be held on June 21.

According to the NTA, the examination will be conducted from 2 pm to 5.15 pm, providing a total window of 195 minutes. The duration of the examination has been extended by 15 minutes.

"This window is designed to accommodate the invigilation formalities at the start and end of the examination, such as the signing requirements, which candidates earlier felt reduced their effective working time," the agency said. The NTA has also doubled the number of



pages provided for rough work in the question-paper booklet from two to four pages, giving candidates additional space for calculations and reasoning.

"Candidates may preferably use the rough-work pages provided at the beginning and at the end of the booklet for this purpose," it said. In another change, the agency has redesigned the placement of rough-work pages to better support left-

handed candidates.

Earlier, rough-work pages were provided only at the end of the booklet. Under the revised format, two rough-work pages will be placed at the beginning of the booklet, immediately after the instruction page, in addition to those at the end in both English and regional-language versions of the question paper.

"The booklet now offers rough-work space at both the front and the back, allow-

ing every candidate to work comfortably, and is especially helpful for left-handed candidates, who account for nearly 10 per cent of all candidates," it said.

The NTA said these measures reflect its recognition that small, thoughtful changes in examination design can make a meaningful difference to a candidate's comfort during the high-stakes hours of the examination. "NTA reaffirms its commitment to conducting NEET (UG) 2026 in a fair, secure and candidate-friendly manner, and to continuously improving the examination experience for the lakhs of aspirants who appear for it," it added.

The NEET-UG for admissions into medical courses took place on May 3 this year, but was cancelled by the NTA on May 12 amid allegations of a paper leak. The CBI is currently investigating this matter.

Karnataka approves 50 AI labs in Govt colleges



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

To expand access to emerging technologies and enhance employability among youth in Tier-2 and Tier-3 cities, the Karnataka Government has approved the establishment of 50 AI laboratories in Government colleges across the State, officials said on Friday.

The initiative, announced in the State Budget for 2026-27, will be implemented in partnership with the Government of India's AI Mission and is aimed at equipping students with industry-relevant skills in emerging technologies, they said. In addition, the Karnataka Government has approved Rs 10 crore to support the initiative, of which ₹6.29 crore will be released in the first year.

The AI laboratories will provide students with hands-on exposure to artificial intelligence, machine learning, data science, and other advanced technologies through practical training, skill development programmes, and innovation-oriented learning, officials said.

ED issues fresh summons to Kerala ex-CM's daughter in PMLA case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Kochi

The ED, which is probing a money laundering case involving minerals company CMRL, has issued a fresh summons to Veena T, daughter of former Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan, directing her to appear for questioning on June 17, sources said on Friday.

The ED had earlier asked Veena to appear before its Kochi unit on Friday. However, following an email from Veena seeking more time, citing health issues, the agency issued a fresh summons, sources said.

The ED has asked Veena to appear at its Kochi office at 10 am on June 17, along with relevant documents related to transactions involving her IT firm, Exalogic Solutions Private Limited. The probe pertains to allegations that Cochin Minerals and Rutile Ltd



(CMRL) made payments amounting to ₹2.78 crore to Exalogic without receiving any services in return.

According to the ED, another company, Empower India Capital Investments Private Limited (EICPL), operated by CMRL Managing Director Sasidharan Kartha, had extended loans worth ₹50 lakh to Exalogic despite the company allegedly failing to make timely repayments.

India became 4th largest economy under Modi: Bihar CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Patna

Bihar Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary on Friday lauded Prime Minister Narendra Modi, saying under his leadership India has become the world's fourth-largest economy.

Addressing a media interaction programme organised here to mark 12 years of the Modi Government, Choudhary also underscored the "enormous trust reposed by the people in his leadership at every critical juncture".

"When Modi announced demonetisation in 2016, the entire nation stood behind him. During the COVID-19 pandemic, people across the country heeded his advice to stay indoors during the lockdown. Now, amid another global crisis



triggered by the war in West Asia, people trust Modi's ability to steer the country through the situation," said Choudhary, who took over as chief minister less than two months ago.

Congratulating Modi on the milestone of becoming

the country's longest-serving prime minister, Choudhary said, "New India is confidently establishing its identity on every global platform. Under his leadership, India has leapfrogged from the 11th-largest economy in the world to the

fourth-largest." "The BJP, under Modi ji, is a party that fulfils its commitments, including the abrogation of Article 370 in Jammu and Kashmir and the construction of the Ram Temple in Ayodhya," he said.

Referring to the prime minister's vision of 'Viksit Bharat 2047', Choudhary said it was an ambitious blueprint to transform India into a fully developed nation.

"Similarly, the NDA Government is committed to building a Viksit Bihar. We are confident that under the guidance of Modi ji, Bihar will further advance on the path of progress, prosperity and self-reliance, infusing new energy and momentum into the resolve of 'Viksit Bihar 2047'," he said. The chief minister said

the State Government has decided to make it mandatory to grant all industrial and investment approvals within 30 days to promote investment in Bihar.

"We are confident that the State will attract investments worth ₹5 lakh crore by November 20 this year," he said. The State Government has also decided to develop airports/heliports/airstrips in most of the districts in the State, he added.

Highlighting initiatives for women, he said the NDA Government has launched several development schemes aimed at their empowerment.

Praising the Centre's efforts to eliminate Left-wing extremism, Choudhary said, "Naxalism has been eradicated in Bihar."



Sita Ben Patni, mother of Akash Patni who died in the Air India AI-171 plane crash on June 12, 2025, mourns as she pays tribute to her son at the crash site on its first anniversary in Ahmedabad

One year after Air India crash, families still await answers

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

One year after an Air India Boeing 787 Dreamliner crashed shortly after takeoff from Ahmedabad, killing 260 people in one of the world's deadliest aviation disasters in a decade, families of the victims are still waiting for a definitive explanation of what brought down the aircraft and the investigation to reach its conclusion.

Flight AI171, bound for London's Gatwick Airport, crashed on June 12, 2025, less than a minute after takeoff from Ahmedabad, killing 241 of the 242 people on board and 19 people on the ground when the aircraft slammed into a medical college hostel. The accident marked the first fatal crash involving a Boeing 787 Dreamliner.

The anniversary comes with India's Aircraft Accident Investigation Bureau (AAIB) yet to issue a final report,

which investigators had been expected to complete around the first anniversary of the crash. Instead, the probe has been delayed as authorities continue examining critical evidence linked to the aircraft's GE Aerospace engines and associated control systems. Investigators are expected to issue a status update or interim report, with a final report now likely within the next three months, according to people familiar with the matter.

The preliminary report released last year found that both engine fuel control switches moved almost simultaneously from "RUN" to "CUTOFF" seconds after takeoff, starving the engines of fuel and causing a catastrophic loss of thrust. The report, however, stopped short of assigning blame or identifying the cause of the switch movement, and Indian authorities have repeatedly cautioned

against drawing conclusions before the investigation is completed. The prolonged investigation has fuelled speculation and competing theories ranging from technical malfunction to human action. The Federation of Indian Pilots this week renewed its demand for a judicial inquiry and opposed the release of any interim report, arguing that partial findings could lead to confusion and misinterpretation before the investigation is complete.

For Air India, the disaster became the biggest crisis since the airline's acquisition by the Tata Group and threatened to overshadow efforts to rebuild its reputation through an ambitious fleet renewal and transformation programme.

Over the past year, Air India and Tata Group companies have focused on compensation, family assistance and support for the survivors and victims' relatives.

Jharkhand seeks ₹1.36 lakh crore coal dues from Union Government

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi/Ranchi

Jharkhand Chief Minister Hemant Soren has urged the Centre to release pending dues of Rs 1.36 lakh crore from coal companies and central public sector undertakings against coal mining in the State. He also requested the Union Government to provide the remaining Rs 6,000 crore under the Jal Jeevan Mission, and support the State's transition from a mining-based economy to a manufacturing and innovation hub.

Addressing the 11th Governing Council meeting of NITI Aayog on Friday, Soren said Jharkhand wanted to be seen not merely as a source of mineral extraction State but as a partner in India's development journey towards 'Viksit Bharat 2047.' The chief minister sought a review of District Mineral Foundation Trust norms to strengthen the role of State Governments in project planning and fund management.

He also requested greater flexibility in land acquisition and land-use approvals for social infrastructure projects in districts falling under the command areas of the Damodar Valley Corporation, Coal India subsidiaries CCL and ECL, and other central undertakings. Calling for value addition within the State,

Ahmedabad honours victims on Air India crash anniversary

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

Grieving families said prayers and offered flowers at the site of last year's Air India plane crash in Ahmedabad on Friday as friends, strangers, as well as dignitaries joined them in observing the sombre anniversary of their loss, standing in remembrance near a hostel complex that will be rebuilt as a medical hub to serve as a lasting memorial to the departed.

The families await closure, seeking to know what exactly happened in the moments before the plane went down, as the crash investigation has not been concluded. In April, families of 30 victims wrote to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, requesting the release of the Cockpit Voice Recorder (CVR) and black box data to uncover the truth.

"I want justice. My daughter should get justice, and her money should be donated. I want to donate all of it," said Savita Ben, who lost her daughter and son-in-law in the crash.

Maresh Jirawala, a 34-year-old film-maker who produced Gujarati songs and albums, was one of the 19 people who died on the ground.



Nagaland Dy CM condemns brutal killing of 6 Nagas in Manipur

TONY DAS ■ Kohima

Expressing deep anguish and shock, Nagaland Deputy Chief Minister TR Zeliang has strongly condemned the abduction and brutal killing of six innocent Zeliangrong Naga men in Manipur, terming the incident a "barbaric and senseless act of violence."

In an official statement issued on Friday, the Deputy Chief Minister demanded an immediate, thorough, and impartial investigation by competent authorities to iden-



Nagaland Deputy Chief Minister TR Zeliang

tify and bring the perpetrators to justice without delay.

Describing the scale of cruelty inflicted on the victims, Zeliang said the nature of the killings had "shaken him to the core." He noted with immense grief that the men were slaughtered like animals, with parts of their bodies handed back to their families.

"No cause, grievance, ideology, or conflict can ever justify such extreme cruelty," the statement read, adding that the incident marks a direct assault on the core

values of humanity, peace, and coexistence.

The Deputy Chief Minister highlighted the disturbing contrast between the unprovoked violence and recent goodwill gestures made by the community.

He stated that rather than reciprocating the goodwill of the Nagas — who had recently released 14 Kuki hostages — the perpetrators responded with "animalistic savagery" that defies logical explanation.

Reiterating that every human

life is sacred and deserving of respect regardless of ethnicity, religion, or community, Zeliang called on the law enforcement agencies to ensure those responsible face trial in accordance with the provisions of law.

Extending his deepest condolences to the bereaved families and the larger Zeliangrong community, the Deputy Chief Minister stated that no words could adequately ease the pain of such a tragic loss of loved ones, praying for eternal peace to the departed souls.

Himanta calls for geographic equity at NITI Aayog meet with Northeast CMs

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Friday advocated for a new development framework centred on "Geographic Equity" during NITI Aayog's interaction with Chief Ministers and Chief Secretaries of the North Eastern states in the national Capital. He said India's journey towards Viksit Bharat 2047 must focus not only on expanding economic growth but also on ensuring that growth reaches every region of the country.

Addressing the gathering, the Chief Minister said that while the first phase of India's transformation was dedicated to accelerating growth, the next phase should concentrate on broadening the geography of growth so that all

regions can participate fully in the opportunities created by development. Sarma noted that under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, the North East has moved from the margins of national discourse to the centre of policymaking.

He highlighted major improvements in connectivity, infrastructure development, peace initiatives and the implementation of the Act East Policy, which have significantly enhanced the strategic importance of the region. According to the Chief Minister, these efforts have created a strong foundation for economic expansion and greater integration of the North East with the rest of the country.

Referring to Assam's recent progress, Sarma said the State is witnessing rising investor confidence and increasing investments



CM Himanta Biswa Sarma during NITI Aayog's interaction with Chief Ministers and Chief Secretaries of the North Eastern states in New Delhi

across multiple sectors, including manufacturing, logistics, renewable energy and technology.

He pointed to the upcoming Tata Semiconductor facility as an example of the State's growing industrial capabilities and asserted that Assam is no longer merely catching up with the rest of the country but is actively contributing to India's economic growth.

Despite the progress, the Chief Minister acknowledged that geography remains a major constraint for Assam and the wider North-Eastern region.

He observed that coastal states enjoy natural advantages such as access to ports, shorter supply chains and lower logistics costs. In contrast, Assam remains effectively landlocked and dependent on a narrow transportation corridor, resulting in higher infrastruc-

ture expenses and longer freight movement times.

"These are structural realities of the region," he said, stressing that such challenges require special policy consideration.

Sarma proposed that public investment in strategically important but geographically challenging regions should be assessed through the lens of national integration, regional balance and long-term competitiveness rather than expenditure efficiency alone.

He described this approach as the principle of 'Geographic Equity,' arguing that it would help bridge regional disparities while strengthening national economic cohesion.

Highlighting Assam's demographic strengths, the Chief Minister said the state's youth population is among the youngest in

the country and represents its greatest asset.

He called for the next phase of development to align skill development programmes with emerging industries such as semiconductors, artificial intelligence, green energy and advanced manufacturing. This, he said, would ensure that young people from the North East are fully integrated into India's growing knowledge economy. Concluding his remarks, Sarma said that if the last decade was about integrating the North East into India's development narrative, the coming decade should place the region at the centre of India's growth architecture.

He reaffirmed Assam's readiness to serve as a growth hub, a gateway economy and a strategic bridge connecting India with the wider Asian region.



Editor's
TAKE

Reimagining Centre,
State relations

PM Modi's call for partnership at the NITI
Aayog meet is welcome — but Centre-State
fault lines demand structural repair

When Prime Minister Narendra Modi chaired the 11th NITI Aayog Governing Council meeting, his assertion that “states play a vital role in furthering national progress” resonated with constitutional wisdom. After a long time, Chief Ministers of all 28 states sat together at the Governing Council table - a symbolic moment for cooperative federalism. Yet symbolism and structural reality remain stubbornly apart in India's Centre-State relationship.

The Indian Constitution envisioned a strong Centre with empowered states. Seventy-five years on, that balance remains contested. The grievances of states are not new, but they have grown louder and more urgent. At the heart of state frustrations lies the money question. The GST regime, hailed as a transformative reform, has effectively curtailed states' independent tax powers. Compensation promises have been honoured in part and delayed in practice. States routinely complain of shrinking untied funds - money they can spend according to local priorities - while centrally sponsored schemes come with rigid conditions that often ignore ground realities. A state like Tamil Nadu or Kerala, with strong development metrics, resents being subjected to the same formula applied to a newly formed state. The Finance Commission devolution figures tell only part of the story. What states receive on paper and what actually flows into their treasuries are different things. Delayed transfers, high cess and surcharge collections that do not enter the divisible pool, and the expanding footprint of central schemes leave state finance ministers perennially short.

Beyond money lies the question of jurisdiction. Governors appointed by the Centre have, in recent years, become a flashpoint in states governed by opposition parties. Prolonged delays in giving assent to Bills passed by elected state assemblies - in Kerala, Tamil Nadu and Punjab - have raised serious constitutional questions about the role of Raj Bhavan as an instrument of political interference rather than a constitutional check. The elected legislature's mandate is being held hostage to the Governor's pleasure, which cuts to the core of democratic federalism. The deployment of central agencies in states in ways perceived as politically motivated, often without the consent of the state concerned, is another irritant in Centre-State relations. What is needed is structural reform.

A revamped Finance Commission framework that ring-fences state transfers from cess dilutions would be a start. A codified, time-bound process for gubernatorial assent would restore constitutional propriety. Expanding the role of the Inter-State Council - a body that has met far too infrequently - as a genuine deliberative forum rather than a ceremonial gathering would give states a real voice.

PM Modi's Viksit Bharat vision is unachievable without genuinely empowered states. Districts, blocks and villages - the units he invoked - answer to state governments, not Delhi. A thriving democracy must trust its constituent units to lead. That trust must be backed by an institutional architecture that makes cooperative federalism real in its truest form.

From conflict zone to growth engine:
How Modi changed Chhattisgarh

As Prime Minister Modi completes twelve years in office, Chhattisgarh stands as evidence of what sustained political commitment and policy
continuity can achieve. The journey is not complete, but the direction is unmistakable



VISHNU
DEO SAI

As Prime Minister Narendra Modi completes 12 years in office, every state has its own story of change. Chhattisgarh's story is unique because it is not merely about development. It is about transformation. A decade ago, Chhattisgarh was known nationally for reasons that no state would want. Despite its rich mineral resources, vast forests and vibrant tribal culture, it was largely identified with Naxal violence, underdevelopment and administrative isolation. Large parts of Bastar were beyond the effective reach of governance. Roads were scarce, investment was hesitant, and welfare delivery struggled against both geography and insurgency.

Today, the conversation is very different. The most important change has been in security. For years, Naxalism denied generations of tribal youth the opportunities available elsewhere in India. It discouraged investment, disrupted education and kept entire regions trapped in uncertainty. Prime Minister Modi's government adopted a strategy that combined firm security action with development and rehabilitation. The objective was not only to defeat violence but also to ensure that governance reached the areas where insurgency had flourished.

The outcome became visible on March 31, 2026, when Union Home Minister Amit Shah declared India free from Naxalism in Jagdalpur, the heart of Bastar. For the country, it was a major security achievement. For the people of Bastar, it was the restoration of normal life.

Peace, however, has value only when it creates opportunity. That is where the Prime Minister's development vision has made a decisive difference.

Few projects illustrate this better than the NMDC Steel Limited plant at Nagarnar. For decades, Bastar supplied some of the world's finest iron ore, while the value addition took place elsewhere. By dedicating a world-class integrated steel plant in Bastar itself, Prime Minister Modi sent a powerful message: regions rich in resources should also share in the prosperity generated by those resources.

The same approach can be seen in the major infrastructure projects launched across Chhattisgarh in recent years. Whether it is power generation, petroleum connectivity, city gas networks or railway expansion, the



THE BROADER
LESSON FROM
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objective has been to integrate Chhattisgarh more deeply into India's growth story. These projects create jobs, attract investment and improve the state's long-term competitiveness.

Yet the true measure of development in Chhattisgarh lies not only in factories and infrastructure. It lies in the lives of tribal communities, which form the heart of our state's identity. As someone who comes from a tribal community, I have witnessed both the aspirations and the challenges of these regions. For decades, many tribal habitations remained disconnected from basic services. Development often arrived slowly, if at all.

The Modi government placed tribal welfare at the centre of its policy framework. Through initiatives such as PM-JANMAN for Particularly Vulnerable Tribal Groups and the Dharti Aaba Janatiya Gram Utkarsh Abhiyan, some of India's most neglected communities have become a national priority.

The impact is visible on the ground. Roads are reaching remote habitations. Houses are being built for vulnerable families. Schools are being upgraded. Healthcare and mobile connectivity are expanding into areas that once remained isolated. A road into a tribal village is not merely an infrastructure project; it is a pathway to education, healthcare, markets and opportunity.

Equally significant has been the effort to ensure that tribal communities benefit from economic activity rather than remaining passive observers. Programmes supporting forest-produce value addition and tribal entrepreneurship are helping to create local liveli-

hoods. The idea is simple but important: development must be inclusive if it is to be sustainable.

The broader lesson from Chhattisgarh's experience over the past twelve years is that security, development and social justice cannot be pursued separately. Peace creates the conditions for investment. Infrastructure improves access to welfare. Tribal empowerment strengthens social stability. Together, they reinforce one another. Of course, much remains to be done. Former conflict zones require sustained attention. Industrial investments must continue to generate local employment. Welfare programmes must be im-

plemented with efficiency and accountability. Development is an ongoing process, not a finished project.

Yet it is impossible to ignore how far Chhattisgarh has travelled over the last twelve years. A state once identified primarily through the lens of insurgency is increasingly being recognised for connectivity, investment and tribal empowerment. Regions that once symbolised conflict are beginning to symbolise opportunity. The distance between remote villages and the state has narrowed significantly.

As Prime Minister Modi completes twelve years in office, Chhattisgarh stands as evidence of what sustained political commitment and policy continuity can achieve. The journey is not complete, but the direction is unmistakable. A state that once struggled to overcome its challenges is steadily emerging as a confident participant in India's growth story.

The Pioneer

SINCE 1865

‘Nindak Niyare Rakhiye’ - Always keep a critic close by



SHANKAR
SAHAY

2ND OPINION

I am not very good at Sanskrit. Never have been. But these three words, *Nindak Niyare Rakhiye*, from a doha by Kabir, have been entrenched in my mind. Quite possibly because the words used are easily understandable to a person familiar with both Hindi and English.

When I was a child, I read a story. Like many old Hindi stories, it featured two brothers — Ramu and Shyamu. Both were all-rounders and exceptionally good in all spheres of life. Their family members and relatives were full of praise for them. The elder brother always encouraged the younger one, but at the same time offered constructive criticism. The idea was to guide him.

One day, the younger sibling confronted him, questioning his criticism. To this, the elder brother responded, “All the relatives who heap praise on us are not nec-



essarily our benefactors. We always need people who are frank enough and close enough to criticise us. That is the only way we can improve — and improve we must — because nobody in this world is perfect.”

When I was in high school, the cricket team of my school, Sardar Patel Vidyalaya, was very much in the news, largely due to the efforts of one of the senior administrators, ML Sharma ji. During a match against another school's visiting team, one of our players, Ashwini Sood, was going great guns. He was hitting every second ball for a six and, as expected, the entire school was cheering his heroics.

The Pioneer

SINCE 1865

As Mr Sharma was leaving the field, I overheard him say to one of Ashwini's classmates, “Please make him understand. At the state or national level, the boundary will not be as close to the pitch as it is on our ground. If he gets swayed by his popularity at school and continues hitting like this in those matches, he will soon get caught and never be able to play a long and meaningful innings. That will be the end of his career before it even begins.”

How often in our professional lives do we come across seniors who are open to criticism? Very rarely. Often, it is their pompous ego that gets in the way, but even more than that, it is the fear among subordinates and colleagues that criticism will not be taken in the right spirit. As a result, no one is willing to risk facing their wrath.

This ultimately leads to their downfall, as they continue repeating the same mistakes time and again.

Wouldn't it be better if our corporate organisations, political parties, and state and central governments had a Department of Criticism or even a Ministry of Criticism,

where open and constructive criticism was welcomed, instead of glorifying every minor achievement and sweeping every major debacle under the carpet? Time to think and ponder.

The writer is an educator author,
and corporate coach

CONGRESS'S IDEOLOGICAL CONSISTENCY:
THE BEST BET AGAINST THE BJP

Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi's assertion that the Congress remains ideologically consistent and therefore best positioned to challenge the BJP and the RSS deserves careful consideration.

In an era when political parties are frequently accused of shifting positions for electoral gains, ideological clarity can indeed provide a strong foundation for long-term relevance and credibility.

Addressing the party's senior leadership in New Delhi, Gandhi reportedly emphasised that the Congress would continue to strengthen because it has not diluted its core principles.

Whether this assessment translates into electoral success remains to be seen, but ideological conviction undoubtedly plays a vital role in

shaping a party's identity and vision.

Equally significant were his concerns regarding the state of the Indian economy. Describing it as being in a “very fragile” condition, Gandhi attributed the situation primarily to government policies rather than external economic challenges alone.

Such observations highlight the need for constructive debate on economic management and policy priorities.

A healthy democracy thrives on robust opposition and meaningful policy discussions. Political parties must move beyond rhetoric and present practical solutions to address the aspirations and concerns of the people.

BHAGWAN THADANI | MUMBAI

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com.
In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Drones enhance railway security

The Railway Protection Force's decision to deploy drones in the Karnal sector is a welcome step towards modernising railway security. These unmanned aerial systems, functioning as “eyes in the sky,” can monitor extensive stretches of railway tracks and vulnerable locations from heights of up to 800 metres, providing surveillance capabilities far beyond conventional ground patrols.

Equipped with high-resolution cameras and real-time video transmission, the drones can promptly detect suspicious activities, track the movement of stone pelters and relay precise information to response teams. Their ability to conduct regular aerial patrols, particularly during train movements through sensitive areas, significantly enhances the efficiency of security operations.

An equally important advantage is that the footage captured by these drones can serve as credible evidence in identifying and prosecuting offenders. The knowledge that areas are under constant aerial surveillance is also likely to deter acts of vandalism and attacks on trains. Such technology-driven measures will go a long way in ensuring passenger safety and protecting valuable railway infrastructure.

RS NARULA | PATIALA

The H-1B debate returns

The US court's ruling against Donald Trump's proposed H-1B visa fee is a reminder that immigration remains one of America's most enduring policy dilemmas. Unease over immigration did not begin with Trump. For decades, Republican and Democratic administrations alike have struggled to balance illegal migration, humanitarian obligations, border security and the country's need for global talent. Trump did not create this dilemma; he merely amplified it through executive orders, sweeping rhetoric and policy measures that often prioritised political theatre over lasting reform. The larger failure lies in the inability of the American political system to build a durable consensus on immigration.

The irony is that no wall can halt the movement of ideas, knowledge and talent in an era of digital connectivity and global innovation. America's economic strength and leadership in technology, research and entrepreneurship have long depended on its ability to attract the world's brightest minds. Its universities, laboratories and start-ups thrive because talent from across the globe finds opportunity there. The United States will continue to oscillate between protecting domestic interests and maintaining technological supremacy. In doing so, it must remember that talent remains its greatest strategic asset.

R NARAYANAN | NAVI MUMBAI

Lessons from the 2026 French Open

The 2026 French Open offered far more than thrilling tennis; it underscored enduring lessons about perseverance, resilience and renewal. Roland Garros has always rewarded those willing to endure hardship, and this year's tournament reaffirmed that greatness is often forged through adversity rather than talent alone.

Alexander Zverev's maiden Grand Slam triumph was particularly inspiring. Years of injuries, disappointments and near misses could have defined his career negatively. Instead, his victory demonstrated that persistence and determination can ultimately overcome setbacks.

His success serves as a reminder that sporting journeys are rarely straightforward. Equally compelling was Mirra Andreeva's emergence as a champion. Her achievement symbolises the constant evolution that sustains every sport, as each generation of athletes passes the torch to the next.

Her victory signals the arrival of a promising new force in women's tennis. In an age that increasingly values instant results, clay-court tennis continues to celebrate patience, endurance and mental strength. The 2026 French Open reminded us that uncertainty is often an essential ingredient of achievement and that those who persist despite adversity are ultimately rewarded by history.

VIJAY SINGH ADHIKARI | NAINITAL

The unvanquished statesman: Narendra Modi

In the last decade, a clear pattern has appeared. Politicians who focused only on opposing Modi have slowly become irrelevant. Those who expected him to fail have been let down. People who tried to get close to him for personal gain were pushed aside, and those who used flattery to gain influence had to look elsewhere



Twelve years is a long time in politics. In that span, leaders come and go, parties form and disappear, and slogans are made and forgotten. Sometimes, though, a leader stands out and becomes the main focus. Now that Narendra Modi's government has completed 12 years at the Centre, it is worth looking back at what this period has meant.

Over these years, Modi's supporters have praised him for many qualities, while his critics have made many accusations. People have often predicted his fall, and there have been many campaigns against him in India and abroad. Still, one thing has not changed: Narendra Modi has stayed at the centre of Indian politics, and he is still there today.

In the last decade, a clear pattern has appeared. Politicians who focused only on opposing Modi have slowly become irrelevant. Those who expected him to fail have been let down. People who tried to get close to him for personal gain were pushed aside, and those who used flattery to gain influence had to look elsewhere.

In a nation as vast, diverse, and complex as India, with numerous languages, castes, faiths, and regions, there are many languages, castes, religions, and regional interests. Yet Narendra Modi remains the main figure in national politics. After winning three elections in a row, he is more than just a party leader; he is the main reference point in Indian politics. Both his supporters and opponents plan their strategies around him. The opposition may have slogans against Modi, but they lack a strong alternative to his wide reach. This is why the belief that any group can capture political power merely through street mobilisation reflects a misunderstanding of both India and the Indian state.

If this approach were effective, movements such as the anti-CAA protests or the farmers' agitation would have fundamentally transformed the political landscape. However, Modi retained his position, while many of these movements became entangled in internal contradictions and failed to overcome him.

The principal error of the opposition lies in attempting to challenge Modi without first understanding his political strategies. Occupying public spaces, raising slogans, and fostering unrest can compel the government to retreat. However, empirical evidence suggests otherwise. Modi's most significant political asset is his consistent refusal to react, while his opponents depend on a reaction he withholds.

Opponents and protest groups often expect the government to respond. When that does not happen, many protesters lose focus, cross the line, and reveal their own weaknesses. The public then sees who stays calm and who is driven by chaos. People who wonder why the government does not crack down often miss a key point: in politics, the worst outcome is not jail, but becoming irrelevant.

When the public stops taking an opponent's accusations seriously and loses interest, that is a major political defeat. Modi has often managed to do this by being patient and steady. Some people see his restraint as weakness, but governments often hold back because they know that waiting can work in their favour.

Those who question the strength of the Indian state may consider recent operations against Left-wing extremism. Anyone who doubts the strength of the Indian state should look at recent actions against Left-wing extremism. Groups that once challenged the government in large forest areas had to come to the table when the government acted firmly. The message is clear: when the Indian state is determined, it can take strong action. Whether considering Khalistan-influenced elements within the farmers' agitation or protests against the Citizenship Amendment Act, Indian society ultimately rendered its own judgment. Those seeking to reshape national politics through demonstrations alone discovered that street power does not necessarily equate to



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AFTER TWELVE YEARS, IT IS NO ACCIDENT THAT MODI REMAINS AT THE CENTRE OF BOTH HIS SUPPORTERS' AND OPPONENTS' POLITICAL PLANS, AS WELL AS OF ELECTIONS AND NATIONAL DEBATES. THIS IS THE MAIN POLITICAL FACT OF OUR TIME, STEMMING FROM HIS LONG-LASTING INFLUENCE

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public legitimacy.

This distinction highlights how Modi's political style differs from that of many of his opponents. While his rivals often want quick results and focus on today's news, Modi looks ahead, thinking about the future and staying connected with voters. His primary challenge is not limited to electoral defeats; rather, it lies in his persistent inability to comprehend the reasons behind Modi's continued success. Consequently, the opposition often shifts focus from substantive political engagement to questioning the legitimacy of the electoral process, revealing its weakness more than Modi's.

At various times, reliance has been placed on foreign opinion, international pressure, media narratives, or street mobilisation. However, at times, people have depended on foreign opinions, international pressure, media stories, or street protests. But Indian democracy is not shaped by other countries, NGOs, the media, or social media trends. It is built on the trust and participation of hundreds of millions of Indian voters. Douglas Macgregor recently asserted, in the context of the Iran crisis, that the United States should consider Narendra Modi as a credible mediator. MacGregor's rationale is that India maintains working relationships with Israel, Iran, the United States, and China. He contends that India's stature, influence, and strategic importance are expanding, and that this development should be regarded as an opportunity rather than a challenge. Such assessments reflect not only recognition of Narendra Modi but also acknowledgement of India's growing global standing.

People who think that street protests, mass movements, or political disruption can overturn election results do not understand how India works. The country will continue to run according to its Constitution, its democratic institutions, and the will of its voters.

To effect governmental change, the appropriate course is to secure an electoral victory. If you want to change the government, you need to win an election. Policy disagreements should be handled through democratic debate. Trying to reverse election results with protests is not a real substitute for democracy or a lasting strategy. It is easy to criticise or oppose Narendra Modi, but understanding his political style is much harder. Not doing so only weakens the opposition.

Understanding society, building organisations, and governing at the state level, and who have subsequently remained the defining force in national politics for more than a decade.

After twelve years, it is no accident that Modi remains at the centre of both his supporters' and opponents' political plans, as well as of elections and national debates. This is the main political fact of our time, stemming from his long-lasting influence. Regardless of support or opposition, Narendra Modi continues to occupy the centre of the national discourse.

The colonial question: Ego as the first coloniser



ACHARYA PRASHANT

claiming that colonialism cannot explain poverty: Ethiopia was never colonised and stayed poor, Vietnam was colonised and bombed and now grows fast, so retire the excuse. The opposing camp produced its own ledger: the drain of wealth, the famines, the deindustrialisation of Bengal.

One counts what he took, the other counts what he spent, and the audit never closes because the principal actor appears in neither set of books. Colonisation, at its root, is less an event in economic history than an operation of the human ego; the man at the pass was running the empire's software on an ordinary morning. The debate about empires will remain what it has been for a century: two ledgers shouting across a question neither can answer, which is how a trading company's warehouse guards came to rule two hundred million people.

The East India Company received its royal charter in 1600 as a commercial venture, and a company, by definition, keeps no army. What it kept in India were factories, and the word in that era's vocabulary meant not production but storage. Warehouses need watchmen, and watchmen were the whole of the Company's armed presence for a century. Then Aurangzeb died in 1707, the imperial structure cracked into fragments, and the Company quietly joined the queue. At Plassey in June 1757, it fielded around three thousand men against the Nawab of Bengal's force of roughly fifty thousand. Bengal, then among the wealthiest provinces on earth, changed hands in a day.

The favourite explanation is treachery: Mir Jafar was purchased, the English were cunning. Bribery can decide an afternoon; it cannot administer a subcontinent for two centuries against the will of its inhabitants unless the will itself has gone missing, and the economic record says it went missing long before any Company ship dropped anchor. The coloniser impoverished India brutally, and the weakness that admitted him predated him by half a millennium. A subcontinent cannot be conquered at those odds; it can only be acquired, and an acquisition, unlike a conquest, requires somewhere in the transaction a seller, who is never a nation, because nations sign nothing and the signing is always done by egos.

The ego is the sense of being a separate, bounded something, and separation is its founding condition: inside the skin, me; outside the skin, the world. Speaking on the Isha Upanishad at Oxford earlier this month, I described the ego as a coloniser whose first colony is the body itself, kept alive not out of love but out of self-interest. Whatever

stands outside the boundary is encountered as an object; the object is assessed as material; the material is assigned a use. To call a river a water resource is to declare that the river's existence is justified by its utility to the one speaking.

Scale the operation and an empire appears. But appetite explains only the predator, never the catch. The ego converts the outer world into material, and when its own centre grows too heavy to carry, it performs the same conversion on itself, handing itself over as material to whatever promises to manage it. Out of the first direction come the world's colonisers; out of the second come its colonised.

India's case is the second direction. India's hub was its wisdom tradition, and just before the tenth century, Acharya Shankar had clarified what the tradition at its source actually says. The final authority a human being seeks is not stationed elsewhere; one's own centre is the seat of it. Within a few centuries, the teaching had been recaptured by the intermediaries it threatened and inverted into its opposite. Fatalism was never imposed on the ego; the ego purchased it, because carrying one's own authority is the heaviest load a human being is ever offered.

By the time the first sails appeared, the operation was complete. The Company never installed the colonised condition in India; it found the condition already installed and did little more than change the name on the lease. The fifty thousand at Plassey did not lose to three thousand; the losing had been done one interior at a time, generations earlier, and the field merely published the result.

In August 1947, the administration was transferred, and the transfer was real. The arrangement, though, was never territorial, and so no ceremony could reach it. The coloniser, in whichever century he arrives and whatever uniform he wears, never breaks the gates; he is received at gates opened from inside, by a gatekeeper grateful for the visit. Seeing the mechanism changes nothing by itself. What operates is seeing joined to intent: the deliberate withdrawal of consent, repeated at the exact points where consent is given.

The man at the pass, meanwhile, has begun his descent. Somewhere on the phone in his pocket, the debate about empire is still running, ledger against ledger; the nearest coloniser, the only one within his actual reach, is the one holding the phone. Somewhere on the way down, he may notice that the valley is being converted again, and the noticing will not stop the conversion, but it will break its automaticity. For a moment too brief to measure, the valley will simply be there, assigned to nothing. No treaty ever delivered that to anything, and no flag has either. The valley never needed his protection. It needed him to see what he does to it by the mere act of perceiving it. The seeing will rescue nothing and settle nothing, and it is still the only beginning that does not turn into one more form of the problem.



Acharya Prashant is a philosopher and author whose work centres on self-inquiry and its application to contemporary life

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Positioning himself as an alternative to both the DMK-led establishment and Vijay's emerging political force, Annamalai seeks to craft a new political narrative centred on clean leadership, aspiration and the legacy of APJ Abdul Kalam.

K Annamalai, the former head of the BJP in Tamil Nadu, has taken significant steps this week to shape his political future, including meeting top BJP leaders in Delhi and announcing his departure from the party. The move aims to raise his political profile and keep observers engaged with his evolving strategy.

Media reports have been abuzz with Annamalai's recent plans. He announced on June 5 that he was quitting the BJP and intended to start his own political party. With future electoral contests in mind, Annamalai has ambitious plans for his new venture. His meetings with key BJP leaders in Delhi have attracted attention, especially as he seeks to enhance his political standing.

These discussions have sparked speculation about the direction he intends to take, particularly after film star Vijay's recent political success, which appears to have encouraged him to explore new opportunities. Annamalai

views this move as the next phase of his public life. He wants to be seen as a key challenger to the TVK.

Annamalai has always been ambitious and has positioned himself against the ruling party leadership. The first reaction from the BJP Tamil Nadu President, Nainar Nagendran, was that Annamalai's exit would not affect the state BJP.

Who is Annamalai, and why is he making waves? Annamalai has a strong background, having joined the Indian Police Service (IPS) in 2011. His work in the Karnataka Police earned him respect and enhanced his public image. However, his recent absence from the candidate list for the 2026 Assembly elections has led supporters to question his future. Complex seat-sharing arrangements and party strategies have left many wondering what he will do next. Annamalai was reportedly niffed at being removed as the state BJP chief and unhappy with the AIADMK alliance. Vijay's rise has also altered the political landscape, challenging decades of Dravidian dominance.

The political scene in Tamil Nadu is changing, particularly as the traditional Dravidian model faces new realities. Annamalai seeks to play a significant role in this transformation by choosing Kalam as the ideological figurehead of his new movement. This strategic decision could reshape Tamil Nadu politics, where identities have long been influenced by ideology, personality cults and dynasties. By highlighting Kalam's life and achievements, Annamalai aims to promote a message of aspiration and unity,



potentially introducing a fresh political vocabulary to the state.

In 2018, after a significant visit to Manasarovar, he resigned from his position as a police officer to support actor Rajinikanth in politics. However, after a year of observation, he found that Rajinikanth remained uncertain about entering politics. The BJP had often viewed itself as junior to the AIADMK in Tamil Nadu. Annamalai wanted to take a bold new approach.

He publicly criticised the DMK over governance and corruption issues. He encouraged the AIADMK to ally with the BJP rather than the other way round. This alienated AIADMK chief and former Chief Minister E. Palaniswami, who

insisted that he did not want to deal with Annamalai before the 2024 elections. The BJP eventually replaced him with Nainar Nagendran.

Annamalai's leadership was defined by an aggressive, independent brand of politics.

Under his leadership, the state BJP transformed from a minor party dependent on the AIADMK into a significant third force. He led high-profile campaigns such as the En Mann, En Makkal (My Soil, My People) padayatra, which covered all 234 constituencies. As a result, the party's vote share increased from just 3.6 per cent in 2019 to more than 11 per cent in the 2024 Lok Sabha elections. Annamalai launched daily attacks on the ruling DMK, highlighting corruption allegations and challenging Piyarist ideologies. This confrontational approach compelled regional leaders to take the BJP more seriously but strained the NDA coalition, particularly its relationship with the AIADMK.

After leaving the national party, Annamalai focused on crafting a new political narrative in Tamil Nadu, emphasising the emergence of young, uncorrupted leaders independent of both the DMK and the AIADMK.

Annamalai faced challenges in electoral politics, leading him to withdraw from contesting and signalling that victory was no longer assured. His absence from the BJP's Tamil Nadu candidate list surprised supporters, especially as Coimbatore North was allotted to Vanathi Srinivasan, raising questions about the party's strategy.

Since Nainar Nagendran became state presi-

dent, Annamalai has largely remained out of the spotlight. When the candidate list for the Tamil Nadu elections was released on April 3, Annamalai's absence raised concerns among supporters because of complex seat-sharing decisions, including the allocation of Coimbatore North to Vanathi Srinivasan. Annamalai, who lost the 2021 Assembly election to the DMK's R Elango, made bold predictions about Vijay's political debut in 2026, stating: "Vijay will do well... He will attract a large segment of young voters and achieve a double-digit vote share."

After he was removed as state president in April 2025, speculation about Annamalai's future intensified. Many believed he would be given a national role or a powerful state-level position. However, those expectations faded when the candidate list for the upcoming elections was announced.

Now that Annamalai has taken the plunge, will his party find space in Tamil Nadu's crowded political landscape? Will his "ekla chalo" strategy succeed? Where will he find the resources to run a political party? Will his outfit attract recognisable leaders from other parties? Only time will tell. In the meantime, he is likely to project himself as an opponent to both Vijay and the DMK's Udayanidhi Stalin.

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Order Order

Jharkhand HC orders panel for jail inmates’ basic needs

The Jharkhand High Court on Friday directed the state government to constitute a three-member committee within 10 days for monitoring facilities provided to inmates in jails. A division bench of Chief Justice M S Sonak and Justice Rajesh Shankar was hearing a PIL initiated suo motu on directions of the Supreme Court to look after the condition of inmates in jails of different states, to be monitored by the respective high courts. The court directed the Jharkhand government to file a compliance report by June 24, when the case will be heard again. The committee will comprise a representative to be nominated by the executive chairman of the State Legal Services Authority, the home secretary or his representative not below the rank of an additional secretary, and a senior police officer of prisons, not below the rank of a DIG, to be nominated by the home department. The state government sought adjournment of the hearing, and said that a draft committee to look after the facilities for inmates is being shortlisted. (PTI)

Andhra Chief Justice offers prayers at Tiruchanoor temple

Andhra Pradesh High Court Chief Justice Lisa Gill on Friday offered prayers at the Sri Padmavathi Ammavari Temple in Tiruchanoor. TTD Joint Executive Officer A Sarath and temple priests received the chief justice and arranged her darshan, said a press release from TTD. Later, she was presented with Theertha Prasadam (consecrated offerings). Earlier in the day, Justice Gill also visited the Sri Kapileswara Swamy Temple in Tirupati and offered prayers, the release added. (PTI)

Delhi HC issues notice on Salman’s plea for stay on *Kala Hiran* release

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Friday sought the stand of the makers of the film *Kala Hiran: The Battle for Legal* on a plea by actor Salman Khan seeking a stay on its release. Khan’s counsel argued that the film was purportedly based on the blackbuck poaching case allegedly involving the actor and was in violation of a high court order protecting his personality rights. A vacation bench of Justice Neena Bansal Krishna issued notice to Amit Jani, Akshay Pandey and others on Khan’s application in the matter and listed it for hearing on June 19. The application is part of the 59-year-old Khan’s lawsuit for protection of his personality rights. The court was informed that while the film’s release



date was not known, the makers released a trailer earlier Friday. Khan’s lawyer contended that the individual in the film looked like him and even dressed like him. He further submitted that Khan was acquitted in three



SC turns down Meenakshi Natarajan’s plea

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Friday dismissed Congress leader Meenakshi Natarajan’s plea against rejection of her nomination papers for the Rajya Sabha election from Madhya Pradesh while granting her liberty to raise the challenge in an election petition.

A bench comprising justices Prashant Kumar Mishra and Atul S Chandurkar rejected the argument by senior advocate Abhishek Singhvi, appearing for Natarajan, that Article 32 can be invoked to cure “glaring and manifest” errors in the rejection of her nomination. The top court said whenever an attempt

has been made to invoke the jurisdiction of this court under Article 32, or that of the High Courts under Article 226, during the process of elections, it has repeatedly declined interference due to the constitutional mandate contained in Article 329(b) of the Constitution.

“If the court accepts arguments to find out glaring cases which are required to be interfered under Article 32/226, and the other sets of cases, where the rejection is not so improper prima facie to relegate them to election petitions, this court would be reading some principle which is not provided for under Article 329.

“We are afraid, that any



such interpretation that in some of the matters this court can interfere while leaving some others to avail the remedy of election tribunal cannot be encouraged,” the bench said.

Article 329 of the Indian Constitution bars courts from interfering in electoral matters, ensuring elections proceed without judicial delays. The apex court refused to accept Singhvi’s submis-

sion that SC should intervene where the rejection of a nomination is ex facie illegal, manifestly arbitrary and demonstrably erroneous.

“To accept the petitioner’s submission would amount to reading into the constitutional scheme an exception which has not been provided by the Constitution itself,” it said. The top court clarified that any observations made in this order concerning the basis of rejection of the petitioner’s nomination have been made only for the purpose of considering the maintainability of the present proceedings. “Nothing stated herein shall affect the rights and contentions of the petitioner, or of any other person, in any

election petition that may be filed before the competent High Court in accordance with law,” the bench said.

At the outset, Singhvi submitted that the returning officer acted completely arbitrarily and referred to Section 33A of the Representation of the People Act and said only the criminal cases where charges have been framed by the trial court need to be disclosed in the nomination papers. Singhvi submitted that Section 223 of the Bharatiya Nagarika Suraksha Sanhita stipulates that the potential accused has to be sent a notice before taking cognisance on a private complaint.

Delhi High Court refuses to direct reopening of CBSE class 12 re-evaluation portal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Friday refused to direct the reopening of CBSE’s portal for the re-evaluation of class 12 answer sheets on a PIL by the Congress’ student wing.

A vacation bench of justices Neena Bansal Krishna and Madhu Jain observed that an individual student was free to take appropriate action if aggrieved and that reopening the portal — which was operational from June 2 to 7 — would delay the entire process of result declaration.

“For you, it is one week, but the whole process gets delayed by a month... You are not understanding. It is not one step,” remarked the bench. “I am not giving further directions. Whoever is aggrieved, let the individual approach,” it further said.

As the counsel appearing for the National Students’ Union of India (NSUI) urged the court to order reopening of the portal for a few more days, Solicitor General (SG) Tushar Mehta, appearing for the authorities, submitted that the aggrieved



students have already submitted their requests and the disputed answer sheets are being considered.

Mehta said the PIL was based on “very general assumptions” and if the NSUI’s prayers were allowed, the undergraduate admission of more than 17 lakh students would be adversely affected. He added that the portal’s deadline can’t be extended at the petitioner’s behest, as it would not be in the interest of students. He informed the court that the deadline was earlier extended by a day, and the portal was closed on June 7 instead of June 6.

“The system has operated for those who wanted to apply... More than 1.67 lakh

students have requested, and 3.8 lakh answer sheets are being examined,” the SG said. “Students who were aggrieved have come before us. This is not a small figure. This means the portal has worked,” he added. Mehta also said that prior to the verification and re-evaluation platform, the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) opened a portal from May 19 to 25 for students to obtain their scanned answer sheets, pursuant to which around 4 lakh students requested more than 11 lakh answer sheets.

On a request by the NSUI counsel, the court listed the matter for hearing before the roster bench in July. On June 8, the court sought the stand of the Centre and the CBSE on NSUI’s petition, which has also sought an independent inquiry into the alleged irregularities in the on-screen marking (OSM) system for class 12 exam. The PIL, filed through advocate Rishav Ranjan, has further sought manual rechecking and physical verification of answer sheets of aggrieved students.

In the petition, the NSUI has said the sharp decline in overall performance in this year’s class 12 results has led to widespread concern among students and parents regarding the fairness, consistency and reliability of the OSM system, especially in the light of several requests for scanned answer books and complaints on discrepancies and technical issues acknowledged by the CBSE.

It asserted that concerns around OSM were not confined to a “small set of students” and those whose answer sheets were affected by scanning defects, mismatch errors or other technical failures cannot be made to suffer because of deficiencies in the system.

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SC sets six-month deadline in ex-IPS Amitabh Thakur case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Friday directed the Uttar Pradesh government and the Centre to conclude all the four pending disciplinary proceedings against former IPS officer Amitabh Thakur within six months.

Thakur, a 1992-batch UP cadre IPS officer, was compulsorily retired from service by the Union Ministry of Home Affairs on March 23, 2021 under relevant rules and on the ground that he was “unfit



to be retained” in the public interest following multiple departmental inquiries and disciplinary complaints. therwise, he would have served till 2028. A partial working day (PWD) bench comprising jus-

tices Satish Chandra Sharma and Sanjeev Sachdeva took note of the submissions of lawyer Ruchira Goel, appearing for the state government, that there were four disciplinary proceedings pending against Thakur.

The former IPS officer, on the other hand, alleged that the proceedings are being dragged on for the last 10 years despite him replying to the show-cause notices and consequently, his pending retiral dues, including Rs 10 lakh of gratuity fund, are still unpaid.

SC Bar Association condemns threats, violence against Justice Gautam Patel, family

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court Bar Association has condemned the reported threats, intimidation, harassment and acts of violence directed against former Bombay High Court judge Justice Gautam Patel and his family over a 2024 judgment in the Dawoodi Bohra succession dispute.

The Supreme Court Bar Association (SCBA), headed by Advocate Vikas Singh, passed a resolution saying reports of threats and physical harm allegedly inflicted

on a member of Justice Patel’s family were “deeply disturbing” and struck at the very foundation of the rule of law.

“In a constitutional democracy governed by the rule of law, judicial decisions may be challenged only through lawful remedies available under the legal framework. Disagreement with a judgment can never justify threats, violence,” the resolution said.

In April 2024, Justice Patel upheld Syedna Mufaddal Saifuddin’s position as the 53rd Dai al-Mutlaq (leader) of



the Dawoodi Bohra community, noting that he had a valid appointment.

The SCBA said that any attempt to threaten, intimidate or coerce a judge, whether serving or retired, or members of a judge’s family, on account of the discharge of judicial functions constituted a direct assault on the independence of the judiciary and constitutional values.

It emphasised that judicial decisions could be challenged only through lawful means available under the legal framework and that

disagreement with a judgment could never justify threats, violence or intimidation.

Stressing that judicial independence is a basic feature of the Constitution, the association said judges must be able to perform their duties without fear, favour, affection or ill will.

Expressing solidarity with Justice Patel and his family, the SCBA urged authorities in India and abroad to conduct a prompt and thorough investigation into the reported incidents and ensure their safety and security.

High Court seeks NIA reply on Elgar Parishad accused’s plea

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The Bombay High Court on Friday directed the National Investigation Agency (NIA) to respond to a plea of activist-poet Varavara Rao, an accused in the Elgar Parishad Maoist links case out on bail, seeking to shift to his hometown Hyderabad citing illness and rising expenses.

The 85-year-old was arrested in August 2018 and in February 2021 was granted temporary bail by the high court. He was granted perma-



nent bail by the Supreme Court in 2022.

One of the conditions in

the bail order was that Rao cannot leave the jurisdiction of the special NIA court

in Mumbai, which is hearing the case, without its permission. In April this year, Rao, through his advocate R Sathyanarayanan, filed a petition in the HC seeking permission to permanently shift to Hyderabad.

The petition said Rao’s continued stay in Mumbai has become difficult because of age, illness and rising expenses. The petition states that the activist-poet and his 76-year-old wife need the support of family members based in Hyderabad, where he owns a house and has access to rel-

atives. A bench of Justices AS Gadkari and Kamal Khata on Friday issued notice to the NIA, the prosecuting agency in the case, and sought its response to the plea.

The HC posted the matter for further hearing after two weeks. The special court had earlier rejected a similar plea filed by the octogenarian.

At least 16 people, including prominent lawyers, activists, and academics, were booked in connection with allegedly provocative speeches that were delivered at the ‘Elgar Parishad’

conclave held in Pune on December 31, 2017. According to the local police, the speeches triggered violence at Koregaon-Bhima, located on the outskirts of Pune city, the next day.

The Pune police, which initially probed the case, claimed that Maoists had backed the conclave. The NIA later took over the probe into the case.

Of the 16 accused, Jesuit priest and activist Father Stan Swamy died in custody in 2021. All the remaining 15 accused are out on bail.

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Meesho to acquire B2B platform Kirana Club for

E-commerce firm Meesho on Friday announced it will acquire community-led B2B platform Kirana Club for about ₹202 crore in an all-cash deal. According to a regulatory filing, Meesho's board approved the acquisition of a 100 per cent stake in Singapore-incorporated Kirana Club Pte Ltd and its Indian subsidiary, Retail Pulse Labs Pvt Ltd (RPLPL). The acquisition will be completed in three tranches on or before March 31, 2027, the company said.

"The Board of Directors of Meesho Ltd...has considered and approved the acquisition of 100 per cent of the share capital of Kirana Club Pte Ltd, a company incorporated under the laws of Singapore, and 0.41 per cent of the share capital of Retail Pulse Labs Pvt Ltd, an existing subsidiary of Kirana Club incorporated under the laws of India...for an aggregate consideration amounting to ₹2,02,08,52,202.40, in three tranches," it said.

The acquisition is expected to strengthen Meesho's presence and capabilities in the e-commerce ecosystem, the company informed the stock exchanges. Following the acquisition, Kirana Club will operate independently as a wholly-owned subsidiary within the Meesho group."Kirana Club has built deep trust among small retailers through its asset-light and community-first approach. We see significant opportunities to strengthen access, transparency and product discovery for kiranas in underserved markets across India and also extend this to all forms of B2B retail across India," said Vidit Aatrey, Chairman, Managing Director and Chief Executive Officer of Meesho.

Founded in 2020, Kirana Club operates a mobile-first platform that allows small retailers, primarily in Tier 2 to Tier 4 cities and rural areas, to discover, compare and order fast-moving consumer goods (FMCG) directly from brands. (PTI)

NLC India bags critical mineral block in Telangana

State-owned NLC India Ltd on Friday said it has secured a critical mineral block in Telangana. In a stock exchange filing, the company said NLC India has been "declared as preferred bidder for critical and strategic mineral block auctions conducted by the Ministry of Mines". The company said it has been declared the preferred bidder for the Parvathapur vanadium, titanium, and aluminous laterite block in Sanga Reddy, Telangana, following the critical and strategic mineral block auction held on June 11 by the ministry. NLC India's core business includes mining of coal and lignite as well as power generation.

State-run NLC India Ltd (NLCIL) on Thursday said it has signed a pact with CSIR-Central Electrochemical Research Institute (CSIR-CECRI), Karaikudi, for collaboration in the field of critical and strategic minerals beneficiation and extraction technologies.

Under the memorandum of understanding (MoU), detailed studies will be undertaken on overburden materials and tailings generated from NLCIL's Neyveli Mines to assess the potential for extraction and recovery of rare earth elements (REEs) and other trace elements.

Both parties will also explore similar opportunities across other mining and exploration projects of NLC India, with the objective of developing sustainable and economically viable technologies for resource recovery from secondary sources. (PTI)

India won't be second to anybody in developing AI models: IT Secretary

ferent applications, not just language models.

"For all those people who say that model making or these kinds of efforts cannot succeed in India, this (Avataar.AI's video platform) is an answer that shows that it can actually be done, and it's an answer that shows that India won't be second to anybody in an effort of this nature," Krishnan said.

Avataar.AI launched Varya, an indigenous AI video model developed with support from the IndiaAI Mission to make high-quality video generation more affordable, accessible and relevant for India.

Users can upload photos and raw videos on the plat-

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | SATURDAY | JUNE 13, 2026

No retail petrol, diesel for industries: Govt

RAJESH KUMAR ■ New Delhi

In a move aimed at ensuring uninterrupted fuel availability for ordinary consumers and preventing hoarding, the Centre through a Gazette notification on Friday barred industrial, commercial and institutional users from purchasing petrol and diesel from retail fuel outlets and directed them to procure fuel through designated bulk supply channels instead.

The Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas issued the Motor Spirit and High Speed Diesel (Temporary Regulation of Supply through Retail Outlets) Order, 2026, directing oil marketing companies and fuel retailers to restrict bulk purchases from retail outlets for periods extending up to 90 days. In Delhi, diesel at retail outlets costs ₹95.20 per litre, while bulk sale pricing stands at ₹134.50.

The Government said the measures were aimed at ensuring the "equitable availability" of petrol and diesel, preventing hoarding and diversion, and maintaining uninterrupted supplies across the country. State and Union territory administrations have also been tasked with ensuring full implementation of the order, including action against hoarding, black marketing, unauthorised procurement, diversion and other irregularities.

Under the new order, industrial units, commercial establishments and institutional consumers may be prohibited from buying petrol and diesel from petrol pumps and will instead have to source fuel through their own consumer pumps or authorised bulk supply arrangements.

By restricting bulk buyers from purchasing fuel at petrol

pumps, the Government aims to prevent long queues, local supply disruptions and panic buying in areas where demand has surged. The move is also intended to ensure that retail fuel prices, which remain significantly lower than bulk rates, continue to benefit ordinary consumers rather than large commercial users.

The Government said the move was necessitated by the "current prevailing geopolitical situation affecting certain regions of the world" that has adversely

impacted international petroleum supply chains, shipping logistics and the availability of petroleum products.

"It has been observed in current situation that abnormal increases in sales of Motor Spirit (petrol) and High Speed Diesel (diesel) through Retail Outlets in certain parts of the country are driven by shifting of industrial, commercial and institutional consumers to Retail Outlets owing to the price difference between retail and bulk sale prices," the notification said.

The notification also restricts diesel sales at retail outlets to vehicle fuel tanks or Petroleum and Explosives Safety Organisation (PESO)-approved containers, with purchases capped at 200 litres per customer or vehicle per day. Such diesel "cannot be resold", the order said.

While bulk users such as telecom towers and industries using diesel for power generation and other feed-stock needs are charged market price, the retail pump rates are way lower than cost.

Citing global conditions, the Government said the move was necessary because of the "current prevailing geopolitical situation affecting certain regions of the world", which has disrupted international petroleum supply chains, shipping logistics and the availability of petroleum products.

The order empowers public-sector oil marketing companies and other authorised fuel retailers to enforce the restrictions and requires State Governments and union territories to take action against hoarding, black marketing, unauthorised procurement and diversion of fuel supplies.

Flipkart strengthens technology leadership

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

E-commerce giant Flipkart on Friday announced high-profile appointments to its technology leadership team, signalling a deeper push into artificial intelligence, core engineering, and fintech capabilities.

Goda Ramkumar joins as Vice President, Data Science and AI Solutions, while Mohan Paliseti has been appointed Vice President, Fintech and Payments Engineering.

Nitesh Jain has joined as a distinguished architect and will drive technology strategy for Flipkart's engineering systems, with a focus on system reliability, developer productivity and long-term platform direction, the company said in a release.

Flipkart said the latest appointments cement the company's technology leadership as it focuses on scaling AI, data science and financial services capabilities across the business.

"As Flipkart continues to build products across commerce, payments and financial services, these appointments reflect the company's focus on innovation and the technology depth needed to serve India's growing base of digital consumers and sellers with greater relevance, reliability, and reach," the release said. With nearly two decades of experience, including her recent role as Head of Data Science and Applied AI at Swiggy, Ramkumar will lead the application of AI and data science across marketplace operations, customer trust

and safety, planning and fulfilment. These are areas where data-led decisions directly affect the experience of millions of consumers and sellers on the platform.

Paliseti brings over 24 years of extensive financial infrastructure expertise. Most recently, as Senior Vice President of Engineering at Mastercard, he led the technology strategy for global real-time payment capabilities connecting billions of card endpoints.

He has also held senior technology leadership roles at PayPal, JPMorgan Chase, Morgan Stanley and DE Shaw.

Additionally, Nitesh Jain, a veteran from Razorpay and Walmart Global Tech, has been appointed Distinguished Architect, and will spearhead the technology strategy for Flipkart's engineering systems, with a focus on system reliability, developer productivity and long-term platform direction.

The appointments follow those of Smita Ojha as Vice President, Engineering, and Amit Sharma as Vice President, Programme Management, earlier this year, Flipkart said, emphasising its focus on building a robust technology leadership bench.

Chhattisgarh attracts investment proposals worth ₹9,580 cr

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Hyderabad

Chhattisgarh on Friday attracted investment proposals worth ₹9,580 crore across high-growth sectors, including data centres, semi-conductors and GPU architecture, solar energy equipment, textiles, and pharmaceuticals at the State Investors Connect in Hyderabad. Seven major organisations submitted proposals that are expected to generate around 7,800 direct jobs, underscoring growing investor confidence in the State's industrial ecosystem and policy framework.

Chhattisgarh Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai handed over an "Invitation to invest letter" to the prospective investors, marking a significant step in the state's efforts to position itself as a preferred destination for technology-led and manufacturing investments.

Chhattisgarh Commerce and Industries Minister Lakhan Lal Dewangan and prominent industrialists, investors, and business representatives from southern India were present on the occasion.

The largest investment proposal has come from Hypernext Data Centre Limited. The company has expressed its intent to invest ₹4,200 crore to establish a modern data centre in Chhattisgarh, which is expected to generate approximately 250 jobs. In this era of the digital economy, data centres are considered a crucial foundation for a state's technological capabilities and future digital requirements.

Feegrade and Company

Private Limited has proposed an investment of ₹2,912 crore in the cement sector. Nivai Labs Private Limited has shown interest in investing ₹1,000 crore in the semiconductor and GPU infrastructure sector and SG Mart Limited, operating in the solar energy equipment manufacturing sector, has proposed an investment of ₹700 crore. The company is engaged in manufacturing solar structure components, and this project is expected to provide employment to about 450 people.

Shri Saravana Mills Private Limited has expressed its intent to invest Rs 528 crore in the textile industry. This project could employ approximately 2,500 people. Kabra Drugs, a company in the pharmaceutical sector, has proposed an investment of ₹200 crore. The company is engaged in pharmaceutical manufacturing and healthcare-related activities. Dinshaw's Dairy Foods Private Limited, a renowned company in the dairy sector,

has proposed an investment of ₹40 crore. This project, involving milk processing and value addition, will employ approximately 150 people and benefit milk producers as well.

Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai said Chhattisgarh is emerging as a preferred investment destination, supported by streamlined approvals, a robust single-window system, strong infrastructure and industry-friendly policies.

"Hyderabad's journey from an emerging IT destination to a global technology and innovation hub is inspiring. Chhattisgarh is working on a similar roadmap, and we are already witnessing encouraging results in sectors such as IT, manufacturing and services," Sai said while addressing the gathering at hotel Park Hyatt.

Inviting investors to explore opportunities in the State, he noted that Chhattisgarh has organised investor outreach programmes across major

Indian cities as well as in countries such as Japan and South Korea. These efforts have so far resulted in investment proposals worth more than ₹8 lakh crore, he said.

The chief minister also met representatives of the Swaminarayan Gurukul organization to discuss a proposal for setting up a 650-bed charitable hospital in Tatibandh, Raipur. The Hyderabad-based organization has a strong presence in the education and healthcare sectors.

Chhattisgarh Principal Secretary to HCM Subodh Singh, Chhattisgarh Chief Secretary Vikas Sheel (IAS), Chhattisgarh Secretary, Department of Commerce & Industries Shri Rajat Kumar (IAS), Chhattisgarh Investment Commissioner Ritu Sain (IAS), Managing Director, CSIDC Vishwesh Kumar (IFS), CSIDC Chairman Rajeev Agrawal, Chairman CII Chhattisgarh Bajrang Goel, and Chairman, CII Telangana M Goutham Reddy, were present at the occasion.

Crude oil falls as Trump halts Iran strike plans

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Crude oil prices retreated by Rs 140 to Rs 8,204 per barrel in futures trade on Friday, tracking weak global benchmarks after US President Donald Trump halted planned military strikes on Iran's oil infrastructure.

On the Multi Commodity Exchange (MCX), crude for June delivery declined by ₹140, or 1.68 per cent, to ₹8,204 per barrel in a business turnover of 12,005 lots.

Similarly, the July contract weakened by ₹137, or 1.66 per cent, to ₹8,103 per barrel in

4,711 lots. The decline mirrored moves in global markets, where Brent oil futures for August delivery slipped \$2.14, or 2.37 per cent, to \$88.24 per barrel and West Texas Intermediate (WTI) for

the July contract dipped 2.18 per cent to \$85.80 per barrel.

"Brent slipped below USD 89 and WTI below USD 86 per barrel after US President Donald Trump paused planned strikes on Iran, citing progress towards a peace accord backed by Saudi Arabia, the UAE, Qatar and Turkey," brokerage firm Kotak Neo said.

The comments made by the American President eased fears of an immediate escalation that could threaten energy supplies from the Gulf region. The optimism, however, was tempered by Tehran's response. Iranian

officials said no agreement had been approved, leaving investors to grapple with the possibility that negotiations could still unravel.

Meanwhile, the latest monthly report of the Organization of the Petroleum Exporting Countries (OPEC) showed crude production by the Declaration of Cooperation (DoC) countries declined by 1,90,000 barrels per day (bpd) to 33.13 million bpd in May.

The group also maintained that China, India and developing Asian economies would remain the primary engines of global demand growth.

Gold rises to ₹1.49 lakh/10g

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Gold prices rose nearly 1 per cent to ₹1.49 lakh per 10 grams in futures trade on Friday, tracking a firm trend in the overseas markets.

On the Multi Commodity Exchange, the yellow metal for August delivery increased by ₹915, or 0.61 per cent, to ₹1,49,847 per 10 grams in 9,122 lots.

"Gold prices surged nearly 1 per cent on Friday after US President Donald Trump announced that he had cancelled plans for a military strike on Iran," brokerage firm Axis Securities said.

The move eased immediate geopolitical concerns and boosted demand for precious metals, it added.

Globally, Comex gold futures for August contract appreciated by \$88.75, or 2.16 per cent, to \$4,202.75 per ounce in New York. "Bullion rebounded sharply from a six-month low after President Donald Trump said the US and Iran could

reach a peace agreement as soon as this weekend, gains were limited by uncertainty surrounding the negotiations, with Iranian officials denying that a final deal had been reached," Manav Modi, Commodities Analyst, Motilal Oswal Financial Services Ltd, said.

Optimism over a potential diplomatic breakthrough helped ease concerns over global energy supplies, triggering a sharp decline in oil prices and improving risk sentiment across global markets, he added. However, investors remained focused on the inflation outlook after US producer prices rose more than expected in May, highlighting the continued impact of elevated energy costs on the economy.

Market participants will monitor the developments in US-Iran negotiations and commentary from Federal Reserve officials, which will be key in shaping expectations for interest rates and precious metals, Modi said.

Ahead of G7, Carney softens tone toward Trump

ROB GILLIES ■ Ottawa

Canadian Prime Minister Mark Carney became a symbol of middle power resistance after a celebrated speech earlier this year, but he is expected to be more muted in his criticism of US President Donald Trump at an upcoming summit in Europe.

Carney's speech at the World Economic Forum in Davos, Switzerland, helped make him an international political star in January, when he declared the global rules-based order over and condemned coercion by great powers on smaller countries.

The prime minister received widespread praise and attention for his remarks and upstaged Trump at the gathering.

But the Group of Seven summit of industrialised democracies that begins Monday in France comes ahead of the scheduled July 1 review of the US-Mexico-

Canada Agreement, or USMCA, the latest iteration of the North American free-trade pact that has intertwined the economies of the United States, Mexico and Canada since the early 1990s. It is a crucial moment in trade talks, and Trump said this week that he may not renew the deal.

More than 70 per cent of Canada's exports go to the US, so preserving the accord is critical for Canada. Canadian historian Robert Bothwell said Trump is more of a problem for Carney "than anybody else because we are more exposed to the United States than anybody else."

Trump leaves for the G7 right after he hosts UFC fights at the White House on Sunday for his 80th birthday.

The summit will unfold as tensions are ramping up between Trump and Canada. One of the world's most durable and amicable alliances — born of geography, heritage and centuries



of common interests — is broken, as seen in several recent examples of tension between leaders.

Ontario Premier Doug Ford, the leader of Canada's

most populous province, had a reception with the US Chamber of Commerce in Washington cancelled Monday at the last minute. Vic Fedeli, one of Ford's min-

isters, said if Trump forced the chamber to cancel, "Ford should be wearing that as a badge of honour." Trump said again this week that the US doesn't need anything

that Canada has. Carney has set a goal for Canada to double its non-US exports in the next decade, saying Trump's trade war is causing a chill in investment.

In other developments, the opening of a major Canadian bridge across the Detroit River that Trump previously threatened to block was delayed Thursday due to unresolved issues.

Trump's actions, including launching a trade war and suggesting Canada become the 51st US state, have infuriated Canadians and created the political environment for Carney to win the job of prime minister after promising to confront Trump.

Trump administration officials keep noting that only two countries, China and Canada, retaliated against America in the trade war. US Trade Representative Jamieson Greer says Canada's retaliatory measures are a major issue in talks.

Daniel Beland, a political

science professor at McGill University in Montreal, said Carney seems to have moderated his tone toward the Trump administration to avoid worsening relations.

"There is a clear tension between what Prime Minister Carney said in his Davos speech about middle powers standing up to hegemony and his attempt to nudge the US administration in the 'right direction' with regard to the USMCA review and trade policy more generally," Beland said.

Carney has downplayed Trump's most recent comments about Canada becoming the 51st state.

Canada and Mexico want the USMCA to be renewed for another 16 years. Trump has mused about withdrawing from it. More likely it will be subject to annual reviews for the next 10 years.

Carney will meet with French President Emmanuel Macron on Friday in Paris ahead of the summit in Evian-les-Bains, France.(AP)

INDIA'S NEW ENVOY ARRIVES IN BANGLADESH

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Dhaka

India's new High Commissioner to Bangladesh, Dinesh Trivedi, arrived in the country on Friday through the Petrapole-Benapole land border to take up his diplomatic assignment.



Trivedi, who is the first politician to serve as India's envoy to Bangladesh, was seen walking into the country carrying his own trolley bag as the land border gate was opened. He was accompanied by his wife, Minral Trivedi. "Nice to be here," Trivedi said after crossing the border. Senior Bangladeshi and Indian High Commission officials received him at the Benapole land border.

Elon Musk could become world's first trillionaire with SpaceX's IPO

BERNARD CONDON ■ New York

Elon Musk may never colonise Mars as promised, but enough investors consider the SpaceX founder to be a sort of miracle man that they'll help him reach another fantastic goal on Friday when he takes the rocket company public. The world's richest man is set to become its first trillionaire.

Known for his brilliant technology breakthroughs, as well as wild claims and missed deadlines, Musk is expected to break that trillion-dollar mark in the biggest initial public offering ever as investors



place bets on a company with losses as big as its ambitions. Ahead of the first trade in SpaceX, Forbes puts Musk's net worth at \$982.6 billion.

In addition to establishing a one-million-person Martian colony, the company has promised to save humanity by establishing other outposts in space, launching data centres the size of football fields into orbit and outdoing rivals Anthropic and OpenAI in the race to make money from artificial intelligence.

To reach its goals, SpaceX needs billions more than it currently takes in from its rocket and satellite business. Between the start of 2025 and March 31, 2026, the company lost \$8.7 billion. (AP)

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PUBLIC NOTICE FOR - AUCTION OF PLEDGED ASSETS BEING GOLD ORNAMENTS					
The Borrowers, in specific and the public in general are hereby notified that public auction of the gold ornaments pledge in the below accounts is proposed to be conducted by the Axis Bank at the below mentioned Branch.					
That the below mentioned Borrowers has availed the credit facility from the Axis Bank Limited against the pledge of gold ornaments ("Gold Loan Facility") in favour of the Bank towards the security. The Demand notices were issued to the Borrowers/Guarantors calling up the Borrowers/Guarantors to pay their outstanding amount towards the Gold loan facility availed. As the Borrowers/Guarantors have failed to repay the outstanding loan amount, the bank is constrained to invoke the pledge and proposed to conduct an auction sale of pledged gold ornaments more particularly described in schedule of property hereunder on 13.07.2026 at 11:00 AM on "As Is Where Is", "As Is What Is", "Whatever There Is" and "No Recourse Basis". Auction will be held at					
DETAILS OF BORROWERS AND OUTSTANDING AMOUNT					
Customer Name	Loan A/c No.	Amount Outstanding (₹)	Date of Recall Notice	Gross Weight	Net Weight
B.O.-: ASHOK VIHAR, NEW DELHI [DL]					
AMIT MALHOTRA	XXXXXXXXXXXX2982	₹ 26,92,808.41	07-05-2026	385.400	323.900
AMIT MALHOTRA	XXXXXXXXXXXX5883	₹ 21,62,226.00	07-05-2026	311.500	292.200
AMIT MALHOTRA	XXXXXXXXXXXX5453	₹ 15,14,163.00	07-05-2026	276.900	270.200
AMIT MALHOTRA	XXXXXXXXXXXX3616	₹ 9,18,377.00	07-05-2026	168.600	161.600
ROMA THAKUR	XXXXXXXXXXXX2339	₹ 52,465.00	07-05-2026	9.900	9.400
ROMA THAKUR	XXXXXXXXXXXX0002	₹ 38,038.34	09-02-2026	6.900	6.300
URMILA	XXXXXXXXXXXX9998	₹ 5,19,258.00	09-07-2025	147.900	143.300
B.O.-: BADARPUR DELHI DL					
ALKA	XXXXXXXXXXXX4481	₹ 1,88,613.00	18-04-2026	22.120	21.220
AMIT KUMAR OJHA	XXXXXXXXXXXX6282	₹ 14,34,421.83	02-04-2026	221.050	206.250
SURAJ KUMAR SINGH	XXXXXXXXXXXX8860	₹ 56,181.00	27-10-2025	9.320	9.120
B.O.-: DARYAGANJ, DELHI [DL]					
AFSHAN	XXXXXXXXXXXX6668	₹ 1,43,756.00	13-04-2026	24.190	20.800
NAWAZISH AHMAD	XXXXXXXXXXXX3645	₹ 1,36,186.00	03-04-2025	27.650	26.800
B.O.-: DLF GURGAON [HR]					
SATISH KUMAR	XXXXXXXXXXXX7367	₹ 1,71,132.00	07-05-2026	20.400	19.400
B.O.-: DWARKA, DELHI [DL]					
ALI RAJA	XXXXXXXXXXXX0100	₹ 1,46,414.54	23-01-2026	32.200	30.700
B.O.-: FARIDABAD [HR]					
AJAY CHAUHAN	XXXXXXXXXXXX8515	₹ 52,456.71	07-05-2026	21.600	19.600
JITENDER	XXXXXXXXXXXX3942	₹ 29,17,950.00	07-05-2026	365.400	330.500
MANISH GUPTA	XXXXXXXXXXXX4312	₹ 23,078.00	18-05-2026	34.000	32.200
SUSHMA CHOPRA	XXXXXXXXXXXX4072	₹ 1,93,465.41	02-04-2026	190.100	182.300
TARA KHATOON	XXXXXXXXXXXX9276	₹ 68,950.00	02-04-2026	9.900	9.400
B.O.-: GEETA COLONY, NEW DELHI [DL]					
JIYAU RAHAMAN	XXXXXXXXXXXX8375	₹ 56,505.37	27-10-2025	21.830	20.730
VIKASH PANDEY	XXXXXXXXXXXX0300	₹ 3,00,433.00	02-04-2026	45.500	38.800
B.O.-: GHAZIABAD [UP]					
ANJALEE PATHAK	XXXXXXXXXXXX6796	₹ 3,54,627.11	07-05-2026	42.700	38.900
ARUN KUMAR	XXXXXXXXXXXX9057	₹ 8,25,834.00	18-05-2026	163.900	146.400
HITESH NAGAR	XXXXXXXXXXXX7866	₹ 1,09,336.00	07-05-2026	16.300	15.100
MD SHAKIR ALI	XXXXXXXXXXXX8278	₹ 70,637.00	12-02-2026	13.850	12.300
VINAY KUMAR CHAUBEY	XXXXXXXXXXXX1744	₹ 1,62,362.00	07-05-2026	20.000	19.050
B.O.-: GREATER NOIDA [UP]					
HEMANT SINGH	XXXXXXXXXXXX2174	₹ 1,63,322.00	07-05-2026	28.800	27.700
JOGIDRA	XXXXXXXXXXXX7656	₹ 68,888.00	07-05-2026	130.000	120.800
KAPIL CHAUDHARY	XXXXXXXXXXXX5217	₹ 44,380.22	02-04-2026	6.900	6.550
PRADEEP	XXXXXXXXXXXX8544	₹ 3,46,575.78	02-04-2026	66.100	45.500
RAHUL KUMAR	XXXXXXXXXXXX4934	₹ 20,17,688.26	07-05-2026	239.500	226.850
SUBAY	XXXXXXXXXXXX9094	₹ 3,81,509.00	07-05-2026	48.800	46.400
YOGENDRA SINGH	XXXXXXXXXXXX2457	₹ 13,05,407.00	07-05-2026	140.100	133.700
B.O.-: HAYATPUR GUR HR					
JUYEETA DEKA	XXXXXXXXXXXX6305	₹ 1,70,925.00	18-05-2026	33.600	29.300
SAURABH YADAV	XXXXXXXXXXXX6127	₹ 2,07,450.14	07-05-2026	32.500	27.800
B.O.-: INDIRAPURAM, GHAZIABAD [UP]					
POYAM KUMARI	XXXXXXXXXXXX3764	₹ 89,440.00	07-05-2026	15.100	14.500
B.O.-: JANAKPURI, NEW DELHI [DL]					
SONU YADAV	XXXXXXXXXXXX2762	₹ 64,593.00	02-04-2026	11.100	10.600
B.O.-: JYOTI NAGAR DEL DL					
AADISH MALIK	XXXXXXXXXXXX6574	₹ 1,37,776.00	07-05-2026	20.800	19.800
ARTI DEVI	XXXXXXXXXXXX7286	₹ 10,25,161.00	07-05-2026	144.100	129.600
JAIVINDER SINGH RANA	XXXXXXXXXXXX0518	₹ 15,49,534.00	07-05-2026	303.100	296.100
MOHD FURKAN	XXXXXXXXXXXX3865	₹ 2,66,739.24	07-10-2025	46.480	44.780
TUSHAR KUMAR	XXXXXXXXXXXX0554	₹ 1,88,821.00	18-05-2026	40.170	38.170
YUSUF MALIK	XXXXXXXXXXXX8708	₹ 13,27,254.82	18-04-2026	141.000	136.600
B.O.-: KALKAJI, NEW DELHI [DL]					
ABHINEET MISHRA	XXXXXXXXXXXX2288	₹ 1,18,082.26	02-04-2026	32.300	29.800
NAIYAR ALAM	XXXXXXXXXXXX3141	₹ 1,71,067.21	07-05-2026	17.700	16.700
B.O.-: KAPASHERA DL					
ASHISH GUPTA	XXXXXXXXXXXX1503	₹ 29,21,006.70	02-04-2026	324.920	311.020
B.O.-: KISHANGANJ OD DL					
ANIL KUMAR	XXXXXXXXXXXX7071	₹ 37,13,785.00	02-04-2026	496.500	445.320
GAGAN DEEP ARORA	XXXXXXXXXXXX9617	₹ 86,719.00	18-05-2026	12.540	12.090
SHRI NIVAS GUPTA	XXXXXXXXXXXX9238	₹ 2,07,944.00	28-11-2024	40.500	39.000
WINOD KUMAR	XXXXXXXXXXXX8646	₹ 3,48,567.00	02-04-2026	37.850	36.070
VINOD KUMAR	XXXXXXXXXXXX6547	₹ 2,57,163.00	02-04-2026	25.600	24.500
VINOD KUMAR	XXXXXXXXXXXX7896	₹ 1,65,289.00	02-04-2026	19.450	18.700
B.O.-: LAJPAT NAGAR, NEW DELHI [DL]					
AAROSH KOHLI	XXXXXXXXXXXX6779	₹ 13,21,387.00	07-05-2026	164.100	151.100
RAKESH RANJAN	XXXXXXXXXXXX1071	₹ 6,06,485.73	07-05-2026	99.200	88.700
B.O.-: MANESAR [HR]					
AMIT KUMAR	XXXXXXXXXXXX1987	₹ 18,17,823.44	09-02-2026	244.700	216.700
RACHNA RAWAL	XXXXXXXXXXXX0004	₹ 8,16,718.00	19-12-2025	138.300	117.100
VIKAS GURAWALIA	XXXXXXXXXXXX6709	₹ 3,37,960.00	02-04-2026	54.900	46.700
B.O.-: MEERA BAGH, NEW DELHI [DL]					
AMAR DEEP SINGH	XXXXXXXXXXXX0912	₹ 8,12,964.37	18-04-2026	84.300	81.900
AMRIT PREET SINGH	XXXXXXXXXXXX5883	₹ 56,758.00	07-05-2026	14.900	13.300
DHRUV KOHLI	XXXXXXXXXXXX5699	₹ 1,27,148.00	18-05-2026	44.900	42.300
B.O.-: NANGLOI DEL DL					
CHANDER SHEELA	XXXXXXXXXXXX1033	₹ 3,16,809.00	02-04-2026	59.300	56.200
GEETA	XXXXXXXXXXXX5570	₹ 4,18,912.60	02-04-2026	60.600	58.200
NAMAN AGGARWAL	XXXXXXXXXXXX6588	₹ 4,29,024.00	12-02-2026	86.400	82.000
B.O.-: NEHRU PLACE DELHI [DL]					
SUNIL KUMAR	XXXXXXXXXXXX9524	₹ 40,391.00	30-01-2025	9.300	8.900
B.O.-: NEW FRIENDS COLONY, NEW DELHI [DL]					
RIFAQAT ALI	XXXXXXXXXXXX5833	₹ 1,71,905.88	10-12-2025	35.300	32.700
B.O.-: NEW RAILWAY ROAD, GURGAON [HR]					
DEEPAK	XXXXXXXXXXXX9370	₹ 4,28,828.28	02-04-2026	82.000	78.300
MITESH VERMA	XXXXXXXXXXXX7186	₹ 2,57,506.00	05-08-2024	71.600	59.000
B.O.-: NOIDA [UP]					
DEEPAK BHATI	XXXXXXXXXXXX5541	₹ 8,15,308.00	09-02-2026	109.680	103.430
NASIR ALI	XXXXXXXXXXXX9870	₹ 1,79,686.71	02-04-2026	47.070	44.620

B.O.-: NOIDA EXTENSION GNO UP					
BRIJESH KUMAR	XXXXXXXXXXXX3955	₹ 1,05,218.00	07-05-2026	15.200	14.000
INDU DEVI	XXXXXXXXXXXX9070	₹ 33,46,766.33	18-05-2026	372.900	352.900
MOHIT KUMAR	XXXXXXXXXXXX4643	₹ 7,57,770.00	02-04-2026	90.900	85.500
MUKEEM	XXXXXXXXXXXX7738	₹ 2,81,383.00	13-04-2026	41.200	39.000
MUKEEM	XXXXXXXXXXXX5402	₹ 1,26,806.00	02-04-2026	17.100	15.000
NAGENDRA KUMAR GAUTAM	XXXXXXXXXXXX8271	₹ 4,21,783.00	07-05-2026	51.700	47.300
NAGENDRA KUMAR GAUTAM	XXXXXXXXXXXX4947	₹ 3,51,186.00	07-05-2026	56.400	39.400
POOJA	XXXXXXXXXXXX3277	₹ 3,09,154.63	02-04-2026	35.200	33.300
POOJA	XXXXXXXXXXXX5365	₹ 2,99,287.00	02-04-2026	34.600	33.100
SANDIP TIWARI	XXXXXXXXXXXX7062	₹ 1,57,899.00	18-05-2026	22.800	21.600
SANJAY	XXXXXXXXXXXX9952	₹ 11,92,997.31	07-05-2026	122.700	119.000
SHIVAM SAXENA	XXXXXXXXXXXX1303	₹ 85,766.00	02-04-2026	10.900	9.400
SHOBHA	XXXXXXXXXXXX2003	₹ 4,42,796.00	02-04-2026	85.000	81.500
B.O.-: PALAM VIHAR, GURGAON [HR]					
ANIL KUMAR PODDAR	XXXXXXXXXXXX5616	₹ 1,79,549.00	07-05-2026	30.600	28.400
RAHUL SINGH	XXXXXXXXXXXX1085	₹ 2,15,287.31	07-05-2026	48.100	45.200
SONALI PRIYA	XXXXXXXXXXXX9637	₹ 7,45,740.87	02-04-2026	113.000	108.700
B.O.-: PARADISE MALL S GUR HR					
DEEPAK KUMAR	XXXXXXXXXXXX8572	₹ 5,15,700.00	07-05-2026	67.500	65.100
IZHAR AHMED	XXXXXXXXXXXX4297	₹ 1,05,694.41	07-05-2026	16.100	15

Ukrainian drones strike deep into Russia

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Kyiv

Ukrainian drone strikes on refineries, depots and pipelines. Tanker trucks were attacked and left ablaze along the land corridor from Russia to Crimea. Motorists are waiting in long lines at gas stations.

In a new blow to the Kremlin's narrative that Moscow is winning the 4-year-old war in Ukraine, Kyiv's forces have targeted supplies to Crimea, triggering the worst fuel crisis on the Black Sea peninsula since it was illegally annexed by Russia in 2014.

The persistent attacks reflect the growing intensity and efficiency of Ukraine's drone strikes and have caught Russia off-guard and struggling for a response.

As the country marks the Russia Day national holiday

on Friday, signalling the start of summer vacations, the gas shortages are threatening to cause further disruptions to the tourism-dependent region with its beaches and resorts.

In a rare public acknowledgement, the Kremlin has recognised the scope of the problem and promised to address the issue quickly.

Ukraine's successes have highlighted its ability to inflict painful damage to Russia and change the course of the conflict, while Moscow's advances recently have ground to a near halt. On Thursday, Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine reached its 1,569th day, surpassing the duration of World War I.

Crimea has been a jewel in Russia's imperial crown since it was seized from Turkic-speaking Tatars in the 18th



century after Moscow defeated the Ottoman Empire.

Soviet leader Nikita Khrushchev transferred Crimea from Russia to Ukraine in 1954 when both republics were part of the USSR. When the Soviet Union collapsed in 1991, the diamond-shaped peninsula became part of newly inde-

pendum that most of the world refuses to recognise.

Soon afterward, a Moscow-backed separatist insurgency erupted in eastern Ukraine, and fighting there raged with varying intensity until the February 2022 invasion. Russian troops concentrated in Crimea quickly seized large parts of southern Ukraine early in the war and secured the land route to the peninsula.

Since early in the war, Ukraine has fired missiles and drones to try to dislodge Moscow's hold on the territory. The Ukrainian military sank several Russian warships in the Black Sea and at their Crimean bases, crippling Moscow's naval capability and forcing it to re-deploy its fleet to Novorossiysk.

Ukraine also methodically targeted munitions depots, airfields and Putin's prized

King Charles celebrates Indian diaspora contributions to British Asian Trust

ADITI KHANNA ■ London

King Charles celebrated the contributions of the Indian diaspora at a special event in London to mark the 20th anniversary of a charity he founded to combat poverty in South Asia.

As the Royal Founding Patron of the British Asian Trust, the 77-year-old monarch joined hundreds of celebrity guests to spotlight the impact the charity made through its support of more than 18.8 million people across the region.

The gala evening earlier this week also helped raise more than 1 million pounds towards the charity's many causes spread across India, Pakistan, Bangladesh and Sri Lanka.

"We are grateful for the continued interest our Royal Founding Patron, His Majesty the King, takes in the Trust's work," said Hitan Mehta, the CEO of British Asian Trust.

"His deep and longstanding support for the British Asian Trust is a source of inspiration for our ambitions," said Mehta, awarded

an Order of the British Empire (OBE) for services to the British Asian community by the king two years ago.

"We also celebrate the extraordinary impact being delivered across South Asia, made possible by the commitment and generosity of the British Asian diaspora and our wider partners," he added.

The British Asian Trust was created under the royal patronage of Charles, then Prince of Wales, after an India-Pakistan charity cricket event in 2007 as a diaspora-led international development organisation to deliver high-quality programmes in South Asia.

The king was presented with a framed photograph from that match, featuring the royal in conversation with both team captains — Rahul Dravid and Shoaib Malik.

"This year marks a particularly special milestone as we begin celebrating the Trust's 20th anniversary... and the work is far from complete," said Lord Jitesh Gadhia, chair of the British Asian Trust. (PTI)



Britain's King Charles III exchanges greetings with British Asian Trust CEO Hitan Mehta, right, and Lord Jitesh Gadhia, centre, during an event in week in London

Pakistan welcomes submarine at Karachi Port

SAJJAD HUSSAIN ■ Islamabad

Pakistan's first Hangor-class submarine built under an agreement with China arrived at Karachi Port, marking a significant milestone in the Navy's modernisation, according to a statement.

Upon arrival at the Pakistan Navy Dockyard on Thursday, a reception ceremony was held and Commander Pakistan Fleet Vice Admiral Abdul Munib attended as the chief guest. According to a statement by the Pakistan Navy, the submarine on arrival was accorded a traditional naval welcome attended by Pakistan Navy officers and personnel, as well as family members of the crew.

"Cadets of Pakistan Naval Academy presented a ceremonial salute to the incoming submarine and its crew, accompanied by a fly-past by PN Z9EC helicopters," said the navy. The submarine was built in China under an



agreement signed in 2015 for eight Hangor-class diesel-electric attack submarines.

The initial four submarines are being built in China by the China Shipbuilding and Offshore International Company (CSIC), while the other four are undergoing construction and assembly in Pakistan at the Karachi Shipyard and Engineering Works (KSEW) via a transfer-of-technology.

The word 'Hangor' comes from Bengali meaning 'shark', honouring the pre-1971 traditions when Bangladesh was part of Pakistan. The original Hangor was a French-built Daphne-class submarine, a series of attack submarines in the Pakistan Navy. (PTI)

Nepal Govt opens energy sector for private investments

SHIRISH B PRADHAN ■ Kathmandu

The Nepal Government has cleared the way for private players to enter the Himalayan nation's energy sector, said Federal Minister Biraj Bhakta Shrestha on Friday.

Speaking at the annual general meeting of the Independent Power Producers' Association, Nepal (IPPAN) in Kathmandu, the Energy Minister said that the private sector will now be involved in transmission, distribution, and trading of power.

IPPAN is a non-profit autonomous organisation that works with the



Government in the sectors of energy and irrigation. The Government has started amending laws hindering energy development and discouraging invest-

ment in the sector, he said, adding that the government will also introduce bills related to renewable energy and energy efficiency in the ongoing Parliament session.

Indian-origin police constable killed in line of duty in Canada

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Ottawa

An Indian-origin provincial police constable in Ontario, who was killed in the line of duty, was on Friday remembered by Foreign Minister Anita Anand for his "courage, dedication, and commitment" to keeping Canadians safe.

Originally from Brampton, 29-year-old Tarun Bali, a constable with the Ontario Provincial Police (OPP), was killed when he and the members of the James Bay detachment tried to stop a vehicle in which a person from a mental health facility had fled in Hearst, 950-odd kilometres northwest of Ottawa.



"We mourn the loss of Provincial Constable Tarun Bali, who gave his life in service to others. His courage, dedication, and commitment to keeping Canadians safe will not be forgotten," Anand said in a post on X on Friday in a tribute to Bali's death on Tuesday.

She also described his death as a "tragic loss" and expressed her "deepest condolences" to his family and OPP colleagues among others.

Canadian Broadcasting Corporation (CBC) said Bali had volunteered for a back-fill assignment in northern Ontario to help police services during staffing shortages.

CHANGE OF NAME

I, Abhishek Kumar S/O Shri Dinesh Singh R/0615, Gulshar second, Near Railway Crossing, Sector-23, Sanjay Nagar, Ghaziabad, hereby declare that my name was recorded as 'Abhishek (ABHISHEK)' in my old Aadhaar Card, whereas my name is recorded as 'Abhishek Kumar (ABHISHEK KUMAR)' in my new Aadhaar Card. Both names, Abhishek and Abhishek Kumar, refer to one and the same person. Henceforth, I shall be known and identified by the name 'Abhishek Kumar (ABHISHEK KUMAR)' for all purposes.

NOTICE

Notice is hereby given to the General Public on behalf of our client Mrs. Anuradha Gupta that Mrs. Anjana Jain & Mr. Anant Kumar Jain & Ajay Kumar Jain are jointly claiming to be the owners of Property bearing No.C-11, area measuring 410 sq.yds., in Block-C, situated at Green Park, New Delhi-110016, as per registered will dt.27.11.2009, executed by late Raj Kumar Jain, & after demise of Late Sarla Jain & Late Vijay Kumar Jain. All persons including other surviving Members of late Raj Kumar Jain are here by informed that above mentioned Claiming Owners wants to sale Entire First floor of the said property to Mrs. Anuradha Gupta or her nominee, if anybody has any objection/s on the ownership of above owners over the said property, its sale/mortgage/pledge, & any other objections, kindly inform the undersigned in writing on the below mentioned address within 07 days of the present.

Kumar & Associates (Advocates & Consultants)
200, Ind Fir, 23, Shivaji Marg, Moti Nagar, N. Delhi-15
Regd.Off:NewDelhi
Ph: 011-2112222-28

NORTHERN RAILWAY

Tender Notice NO. 19/2026-2027 Dated: 12.06.2026

Invitation of Tenders through E-Procurement system

Principal Chief Materials Manager, Northern Railway, New Delhi-110001, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites e-tenders through e-procurement system for supply of the following items:-

S. No.	Tender No.	Brief Description	Qty.	Closing Date
01	02261692A	LED LIGHT FITTING	9840 NOS	06.07.26
02	07261857	NON ASBESTOS BASED ORGANIC BRAKE PADS	52973 SET	06.07.26
03	77265201	WEDGE FOR SLIDE CHAIRS	53600 NOS	09.07.26
04	19262116	POH MAINTENANCE KIT	9 NOS	09.07.26
05	08265304	5 WATT VHF	739 NOS	09.07.26
06	77269041	FISH PLATE FOR 52 KG. RAIL	4880 NOS	14.07.26
07	77269008	FISH PLATES FOR 60 KG. RAIL	31676 NOS	15.07.26

NOTE:- 1. Vendors may visit the IREPS website i.e. www.ireps.gov.in for details. 2. No Manual offer will be entertained.

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

कार्यालय नगर निगम, हरिद्वार

पत्रांक:- 169 / सीएचएन(एन/निगम) / 2026-27

दिनांक:- 12.06.2026

दर निविदा सूचना

नगर निगम हरिद्वार द्वारा मांगे महापौर महोदय व नगर आयुक्त महोदय नगर निगम हरिद्वार की स्वीकृति उपरान्त कांवेड मेला-2026, चार घाम यात्रा व अन्य स्नातकपर्वों के दृष्टिगत निगम क्षेत्रांतर्गत सफाई व्यवस्था सुचारु एवं प्रभावी रूप से किये जाने हेतु वित्तीय वर्ष 2026-27 में सफाई उपकरण, कीटनाशक रसायन क्रय किये जाने हेतु www.uktenders.gov.in पर निविदा आमंत्रित करता है जिसका विवरण निम्नानुसार है:-

S.No.	Scheduled/Information	Date	Time
1	Date of Online publication	15.06.2026	11:00 AM
2	Document Download start Date	15.06.2026	12:00 PM
3	Online Bid Submission Start Date	15.06.2026	01:00 PM
4	Pre-bid meeting (Nagar Nigam Haridwar)	22.06.2026	12:00 PM
5	Online Bid Submission End Date	29.06.2026	02:00 PM
6	Offline Submission of Hard/Original copy of Document End date	29.06.2026	03:00 PM
7	Bid opening Date	29.06.2026	03:00 PM

उक्त निविदियों व निविदा में किसी भी प्रकार का कोई संशोधन मात्र www.uktenders.gov.in पर प्रेषित किया जायेगा।

सफाई उपकरण	कीटनाशक
बुझा हुआ चुना द्वितीय ग्रेड	मैलाथियान 50 प्रतिशत
ब्लीचिंग	पायरेथ्रम एक्सट्रेक्ट 2 प्रतिशत
साबुन	डेटा-मैथीन 2.5 प्रतिशत
फावड़ी बिन्टा सहित	साईफोथीन 5 ईंसी०
तखल (18 इंच)	टैमोफोस (एण्टी लावो)
रंगीन चूना (लाल)	फिनायल काला
रंगीन चूना (पीला)	फिनायल सफेद
रंगीन चूना (हरा)	टॉयलेट ब्लीचर
झाड़ू सीख वाली झण्डा सहित	-
मास्क युक्त एण्ड थ्रो	-
गलब्स रबड	-
गलब्स युक्त एण्ड थ्रो	-
फ्लोरोसेंट जैकेट	-
गम बूट	-

उप नगर आयुक्त नगर निगम हरिद्वार

PROSPECT

Additional Chief Secretary LS Changsan reviews progress of Guwahati Ring Road Project



Additional Chief Secretary to the Government of Assam, Revenue and Disaster Management Department, LS Changsan, on Friday chaired a review meeting on the progress of the Guwahati Ring Road Project at the conference hall of the District Commissioner's Office, Amingaon. The meeting reviewed the status of land-related works and other key aspects of the project across the concerned districts. District Commissioner, Kamrup, Deba Kumar Mishra; District Commissioner, Darrang, Ayushi Jain; and representatives from the District Administration, Kamrup (Metro), presented updates on the progress of the project and the steps taken to facilitate its timely implementation. During the meeting, Changsan stressed the need to expedite the ongoing work and ensure the timely completion of the project. She urged all concerned departments and district administrations to maintain close coordination and proactively address any issues arising during the implementation process. She also assured necessary support from the Revenue and Disaster Management Department and directed officials to submit proposals, wherever required, for early resolution of pending matters.

(PNS)

CATC-42 concludes successfully at JNV Nalbari



The Combined Annual Training Camp CATC-42 of 1 Assam Battalion NCC, Guwahati Group, concluded successfully at Jawahar Navodaya Vidyalaya (JNV), Nalbari, with 550 cadets from schools and colleges across Kamrup Metro, Dispur, Guwahati, Nalbari, and Rangia completing 10 days of intensive training. Organised under NCC Group Headquarters Guwahati, the camp focused on 'Unity and Discipline' through drill, weapon training, map reading, field craft, first aid and leadership development. Cadets also underwent firing practice and took part in cultural events, debates and sports to build all-round personality. During the camp, as part of Special Training Modules to broaden the exposure, cadets attended lectures and demonstrations by personnel of 1 NDRF Battalion, who trained them in disaster response, rescue techniques and earthquake safety protocols relevant to Assam.

(PNS)

Yoga: The finest instrument for healthy ageing



PRATAPRAO JADHAV

As life expectancy continues to rise across the world, an important question confronts us: how do we ensure that people not only live longer, but also live healthier, more active, and more fulfilling lives? This question lies at the heart of the International Day of Yoga 2026 theme, "Yoga for Healthy Ageing." The theme reflects a growing recognition that healthy ageing is one of the most important public-health priorities of our time and that preventive healthcare must begin long before old age.

Across the world, rising life expectancy is a testament to human progress. Yet longevity alone cannot be the measure of that progress. The real challenge is ensuring that these additional years are lived with vitality, independence, dignity, and purpose. Modern healthcare has helped extend lifespan, but societies are increasingly recognising the importance of extending healthspan: the years spent in good health. As India advances towards the vision of Viksit Bharat, healthy ageing becomes not only a personal aspiration but also an important public-health objective, reflecting a nation's commitment to the well-being and resilience of its people. As we continue our journey of demographic and economic transformation, ensuring that citizens

remain healthy, active, and productive across all stages of life will be critical to building a stronger and more developed nation.

The adoption of "Yoga for Healthy Ageing" as the theme for International Day of Yoga 2026 reflects an emerging global reality. As populations age and lifestyle-related health challenges increase, healthcare systems are increasingly recognising the importance of prevention, active living, and long-term well-being. The theme seeks to bring this conversation to the forefront and encourage people to adopt healthy practices long before age-related challenges emerge.

The conversation around ageing is often confined to older adults, when in reality it is a lifelong process. The quality of our later years is shaped by choices made much earlier in life. Physical inactivity, chronic stress, poor sleep habits, and sedentary lifestyles can gradually undermine long-term well-being, while healthy habits adopted in youth can strengthen resilience, mobility, and emotional well-being for decades to come. Preventive health, therefore, cannot begin at retirement; it must begin much earlier, through conscious investments in physical, mental, and emotional wellness.

This is where yoga assumes particular significance. Rooted in India's timeless knowledge and embraced across the world, yoga offers a holistic approach to health that nurtures harmony between body, mind, and breath. Through asanas, pranayama, meditation, and mindfulness, individuals can enhance physical strength, flexibility, balance, mental clarity, and emo-



tional stability. More importantly, yoga encourages a preventive approach to health: one that focuses not merely on managing illness, but on cultivating resilience and well-being throughout life. In this sense, yoga is not an intervention for old age; it is a lifelong companion that supports healthy ageing from an early age.

The growing scientific interest in yoga's role in healthy ageing further reinforces this understanding. As mentioned on PubMed Central, studies relating to "Yoga for Healthy Ageing" increased from 183 in 2014 to 1,207 in 2025. This more than six-fold increase reflects growing global interest in understanding how yoga can contribute to mobility, cognitive well-being, emotional resilience, and overall quality of life as people age. It also underscores the increasing relevance of preventive and lifestyle-based approaches to health in the twenty-first century.

Importantly, yoga is accessible. It can be practised by people of different age groups, backgrounds, and levels of physical ability. Whether one is a student preparing for

examinations, a professional managing workplace pressures, a home-maker balancing responsibilities, or a senior citizen seeking to remain active and independent, yoga offers a pathway towards healthier living.

Over the past decade, the International Day of Yoga has evolved into a global movement for wellness and collective well-being. Participation in International Day of Yoga activities has grown manifold over the years, reflecting increasing recognition of yoga as an accessible, low-cost, and effective tool for health promotion. The theme "Yoga for Healthy Ageing" carries this journey forward by focusing attention on one of the most important health challenges of our time.

The Ministry of Ayush has consistently sought to encourage citizens to move beyond annual observances and adopt yoga as a daily practice. Initiatives such as the Common Yoga Protocol provide a simple and structured framework for practitioners, while Yoga365 promotes the integration of yoga into everyday life throughout the year. These efforts reflect a broader

belief that lasting health benefits emerge not from occasional participation but from sustained practice.

The growing acceptance of yoga also signals an important shift in how societies approach healthcare. Increasingly, there is recognition that sustainable health outcomes require greater emphasis on prevention, self-care, and healthy lifestyle choices. Healthcare systems will always play a vital role, but lasting wellness also depends on empowering individuals to take responsibility for their own health long before illness occurs.

As India advances towards becoming a healthier, more resilient, and developed nation, healthy ageing must become a shared societal goal. This responsibility does not belong only to governments, healthcare institutions, or senior citizens. It belongs to each one of us. The choices we make today will shape not only how long we live, but how well we live.

As we observe the International Day of Yoga 2026, I invite citizens across the country and the world to embrace yoga not merely as a practice, but as an investment in their future selves. We often prepare financially for the years ahead, yet rarely devote the same attention to preparing our bodies and minds for the future. Yoga offers a simple, time-tested, and accessible pathway to do exactly that. In embracing yoga today, we can take a meaningful step towards ensuring that the years we gain are years lived with health, vitality, and purpose.

The writer is Union Minister of State (IC) for Ayush and Minister of State for Health & Family Welfare

Assam emerges as India's next concert economy hub

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Once peripheral to India's live entertainment circuit, Assam is fast emerging as one of the country's most compelling concert destinations. Backed by progressive policies, strategic infrastructure investments, rising audience demand and key public-private partnerships, the state is demonstrating how live entertainment can serve as both a cultural asset and a catalyst for economic growth.

In a landmark step towards institutionalising this vision, BookMyShow, India's leading live entertainment and culture platform, in collaboration with the Assam Tourism Development Corporation Ltd (ATDC) and EY-Parthenon, a strategy and consulting firm, has unveiled The Assam

Blueprint: Turning Live Music Economy into a Tourism Multiplier, a comprehensive report capturing the economic, tourism, workforce and cultural impact of live entertainment in Assam, following one of Guwahati's largest live entertainment spectacles: Post Malone's first-ever India solo headline concert, produced and promoted by BookMyShow Live.

Far beyond the economic impact assessment of this single event, the BookMyShow, ATDC and EY-Parthenon report positions Assam as an early example of how strategic ecosystem-building, destination development and long-term investment can transform live entertainment from a standalone cultural moment to a recurring economic multiplier. It



estimates that a structured pipeline of marquee events could generate over ₹700 crore in cumulative economic impact within Assam over the next five years.

The BookMyShow, ATDC and EY-Parthenon report highlights Post Malone's first-ever India solo headline concert in Guwahati as a case study to demonstrate how live entertainment can generate tangible economic

value across tourism, hospitality, mobility, retail and local services. According to BookMyShow's and EY-Parthenon's estimates, the concert generated ₹43 crore in total economic impact across multiple industries, including ₹32 crore injected directly into Assam's economy through attendee-led spending, and ₹5 crore in GST revenue into the Government's coffers.

Punjab Special DGP outlines strategies to curb illicit trade



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Chandigarh

Illicit trade is a complex challenge with far-reaching economic and social consequences, said Amardeep Singh Rai, Special Director General of Police, Punjab, while addressing a capacity building programme for police officers on 'Tackling Counterfeiting and Smuggling: Strategies for Effective Enforcement' on Thursday.

"Counterfeiting and smuggling not only undermine legitimate businesses and government revenues but also threaten consumer safety and fuel illegal networks. Tackling these challenges requires robust enforcement, continuous capacity building and coordinated action among government agencies, law enforcement authorities and industry stakeholders," Rai said.

The programme, organised by FICCI-CASCADE, brought together senior police officers, Government officials, legal experts and industry representatives to deliberate on the growing threat of counterfeiting, smuggling and other forms of illicit trade.

Mohammed Tayyab, Secretary, Jails Department, Government of Punjab, highlighted the need for institutional preparedness. "As illicit trade networks become increasingly sophisticated, enforcement agencies must remain equipped with the knowledge, skills and tools required to effectively detect, investigate and prevent such crimes," he said.

Ankurjeet Singh, Additional Secretary Home, Government of Punjab, noted that counterfeiting and smuggling are now linked to organised criminal activities. "Effective enforcement today requires a combination of intelligence-led policing, inter-agency cooperation and awareness of emerging trends. Strengthening the capabilities of frontline officers is critical to safeguarding the economy and protecting citizens," he added.

Deep Chand, Advisor, FICCI CASCADE and Former Special Commissioner of Police, New Delhi, said illicit trade inflicts significant losses on legitimate businesses and distorts fair market competition.

A new take on urban mobility with MG Comet EV

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The MG Comet EV is redefining what a city car can be. Compact on the outside yet packed with technology and practicality, it has been designed specifically for modern urban life. Its distinctive two-door design, compact dimensions, and futuristic styling make it stand out in crowded city streets while offering an efficient and intelligent driving experience.

At the heart of the Comet EV is a 17.3 kWh prismatic lithium-ion battery engineered for durability and thermal stability, qualities especially valuable in Indian driving conditions.

The battery delivers an ARAI-certified range of 230 km on a single charge, making it well-suited for daily commuting and routine city travel. Paired with an electric motor producing 41.4 bhp and 110 Nm of torque, the Comet offers smooth, responsive performance with the instant acceleration that EV drivers appreciate.

Inside, the Comet EV brings premium technology to the compact-car segment.

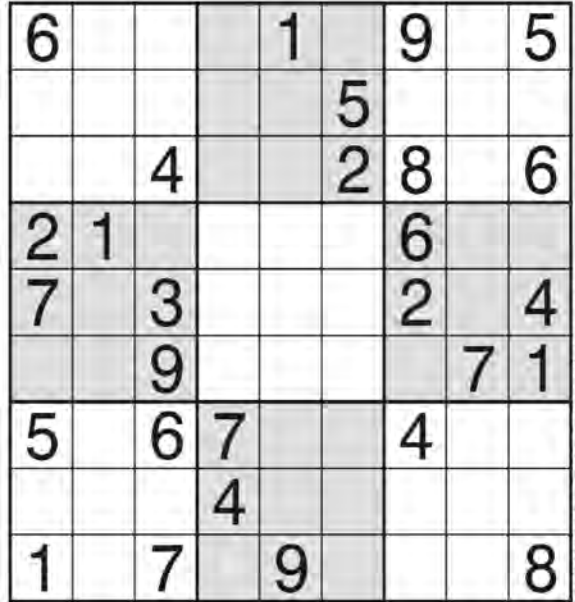


It features MG's iSmart connected car platform with more than 55 connected features and over 100 voice commands. A floating twin-screen setup includes a 10.25-inch touchscreen infotainment system with wireless Android Auto and Apple CarPlay, creating a modern and connected cabin experience that feels far larger than the car's footprint.

One of the Comet's most innovative features is MG's Battery-as-a-Service (BaaS) programme. By separating the battery cost from the vehicle purchase, buyers can access the Comet EV at a lower upfront price, with battery usage charged on a per-kilometre basis.

Combined with an assured 60 per cent buyback value after three years, the model offers a compelling ownership proposition for urban drivers.

DAILY SUDOKU



DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

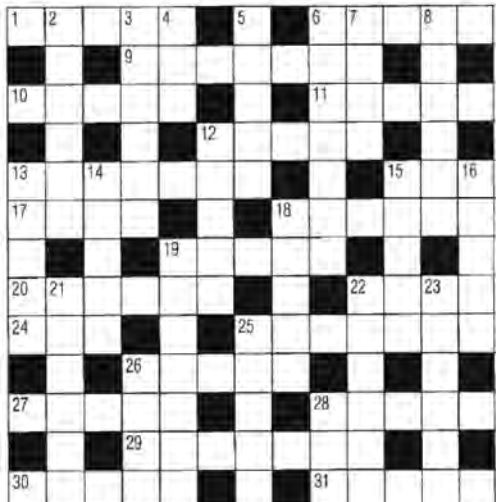
HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



SOLUTION (12.6.26)								
1	6	4	9	5	3	7	2	8
2	8	3	7	4	1	6	9	5
5	7	9	2	8	6	4	3	1
9	4	1	6	2	5	3	8	7
7	2	5	8	3	9	1	6	4
8	3	6	1	7	4	2	5	9
6	1	2	5	9	7	8	4	3
3	9	8	4	1	2	5	7	6
4	5	7	3	6	8	9	1	2

DOUBLE CROSSWORD SATURDAY | JUNE 13, 2026



ACROSS

- Hit out, getting a century and a half (5)
- Roguish letters to a politician (5)
- Like the energy of an eccentric uncle with a warm heart (7)
- Such letters do not form such mail (5)
- Drive for a short time in open country (5)
- Soldiers love to be in semi-tropical surroundings! (5)
- Land of men in song (7)
- Determined to assume a certain hardness (3)
- Guide to a poetic area at Land's End (4)
- Is able to join a woman abroad (6)

DOWN

- House in real disorder somewhere in Pakistan (6)
- Joined the club (6)
- It largely has an alcoholic content (3)
- She records a century by a famous batsman (5)
- Source of Russian tea (7)
- Cut with a whip (4)
- Suggested by a low fellow (6)
- In extremes of tragedy, she's sick at heart (5)
- Smart, but maybe he could lose a kilo (5)
- Half the team get angry about being

- Like the glass uncle Arthur has (5)
- Girl with a heart of stone (6)
- A sporting warning, of course (4)
- Are such gloves juvenile? (3)
- Piece of plaid tied in a knot or intertwined (7)
- German town orchestra (5)
- One of a pack for Jack to back (5)
- In short, the governmental head named Barnaby (5)
- A stick for a dog (7)
- Wat, whose tyre burst going round a corner (5)
- Blue boy? (5)

beaten (5)

- Shoe, for a time like a spanner in the works? (5)
- Subdued, thanks to me, on the first of December (5)
- A ropy kind of car? (5)
- Reactor designer? (7)
- It's from hilarity that this name is derived (6)
- Reckon to keep in shape (6)
- West Indian pop (6)
- It flies down a quiet country road (5)
- Trust the flight will have a safe conclusion (4)
- Intrepid traveller? (3)

SOLUTION (12.6.26)

- ACROSS
- Cliff
 - Rip-ro
 - Light
 - Ten
 - Lemon
 - Croster
 - Wendy
 - Hoe
 - Corse
 - Pitcher
 - D-rp
 - Sh-op

- DOWN
- Se-a-tle
 - Arches
 - Roe
 - Shear
 - Careful
 - Libe-l
 - Pen
 - Gnome
 - Te-ns
 - As-pen

- Ideas
- Plece
- Sleeper
- Eric-s
- Tor
- Rh-l-no
- Hai-MA
- Funny
- Cede
- Fee
- Central

BRIEFLY

Canada is ready to become a soccer nation



Luke Reece never played hockey growing up in the Toronto suburb of Mississauga. Instead, he played soccer, like many Canadians who are now adults. The sport is so popular that it has surpassed hockey and all other sports in youth participation, according to a recent report by Jumpstart, a Canadian charity that helps low-income youth play organised sports. It said half the nation's youth participate in organised soccer.

Reece was one of many locals sporting Canada soccer gear on Thursday ahead of their nation's World Cup opener on Friday against Bosnia-Herzegovina.

"Wish I had tickets to the game tomorrow, but I don't," Reece said. "I'm going to a game in Vancouver. It was cheaper to get a ticket out there."

Is Canada about to have a soccer moment? "It already has a good hold in this country in terms of participation. I think we all expect that to grow. These tournaments inspire so many next-generation people to find their heroes, play the game," said Christina Linz, president of the women's Northern Super League. (AP)

Talwar shoots 5-under, lies Tied-6th at Interwetten Open



Saptak Talwar carded an opening round of 5-under 64 on the par-69 Schlading-Dachstein Golf Club to be placed as the best Indian at T-6th spot after the opening round of the Interwetten Open. He sits three strokes behind first-day leader Christian Braeunig, who carded 8-under 61.

The other Indian player in the field this week is Veer Ahlawat, who had a difficult opening day where he carded 2-over 71 to find himself all the way back in T-128 after the first round. Ahlawat will need to pick up the pace if he wants to avoid an early end to the week.

Talwar began his round on the back nine and made his first birdie on the 10th hole. A second birdie on the 12th hole was quickly followed by the only bogey of the round on the 14th hole.

Talwar would wrap up the back nine with a birdie on the 18th before moving onto the front nine, where he carded birdies on the first, second and fifth holes. The round included six birdies and one bogey. (PTI)

Golfer Sahith Theegala among six co-leaders at Canadian Open

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Ontario (Canada)

Golfer Sahith Theegala grabbed a share of the lead in the opening round of the RBC Canadian Open, carding a 6-under 64 to join five others at the top of the leaderboard.

The Indian-American, who last had a share of the first-round lead at the 2026 Players Championship, is placed in the lead group alongside Major Winner Brooks Koepka, Emiliano Grillo, Eric Cole, Sam Burns and Matthew Anderson.

Among other Indian-origin players, Aaron Rai and Sudarshan Yellamaraju had slow starts as both players carded 1-under 69 to be placed 73rd on the leaderboard. Indo-Canadian qualifier Jeevan



Sihota carded 1-over 71 to be T-120 in his first PGA Tour event.

Koepka, whose second U.S. Open title came at Shinnecock Hills in 2018, was in sublime form, making four birdies over his final five holes to grab a share

Pioneering Indian shooting coach Jaspal Rana dies at 49

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Jaspal Rana, one of India's finest pistol shooters who made a hugely successful transition to coaching and guided Manu Bhaker to epoch-making twin bronze medals at the Paris Olympics, has shockingly died at a mere 49 years of age after battling cardiac complications.

Rana is survived by his wife, Reena Rana, daughter Devanshi, son Yuvraj, father Narayan Singh Rana, and his two siblings, Sushma Singh and Subhash Rana.

National Rifle Association of India (NRAI) president Kalikesh Narayan Singh Deo said Rana breathed his last at Delhi's Max Super Speciality Hospital on Thursday night.

Dr Balbir Singh, Group Chairman (Cardiac Sciences, Pan Max & Chief of Interventional Cardiology and Electrophysiology) at Max, said Rana was brought to the hospital in a critical condition on June 1.

"Mr Jaspal Rana presented with an acute heart attack that was already three days old. He had been travelling and continued to experience chest pain before arriving at the hospital in a very critical condition," Singh said.

"The artery responsible for the heart attack was completely blocked. His heart's pumping function was severely weakened, and he was in heart failure," he added.

The hospital said Rana responded well to treatment and had shown significant recovery before the sudden deterioration.

"Mr Rana had recovered significantly and was fit for discharge today. However, he unfortunately suffered a sudden cardiac rupture while asleep, which led to his demise," Singh said.

Rana's untimely death has left the shooting fraternity in a state of shock. His last rites would be conducted in Varanasi on Saturday.

His stunning death has created



a massive void in India's coaching leadership staff as the shooters gear up for the Asian Games later this year, and the NRAI would have to thrash out a fresh plan to ensure that the preparations remain on track.

Rana was serving as the high-performance coach for Indian pistol shooters.

He had initially fallen ill

aboard the Indian contingent's return flight from the ISSF World Cup in Munich, Germany. After landing in New Delhi, he was immediately hospitalised and had a stent installed to clear a cardiac blockage.

The pistol ace, who was considered a maverick in Indian shooting circles for his outspoken demeanour and passion for the sport, was a prodigal talent and won his first national-level gold at just 12 years of age.

His international breakthrough was the 25m centre fire pistol gold medals at the 1994 Commonwealth and Asian Games.

In fact, the Asiad gold was India's first in 16 years after Raja Randhir Singh opened the account in 1978. Randhir had passed away recently after battling age-related ailments.

Unmatched legacy, there won't be another Jaspal Rana: NRAI

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

"There would never be another Jaspal Rana," said a shocked National Rifle Association of India (NRAI) on Friday as it mourned the demise of the pistol ace who "churned out champion after champion" during his coaching career.

The 49-year-old Rana passed away due to cardiac complications following a massive heart attack at a city hospital. The multiple-time Commonwealth

and Asian Games gold-winner and recipient of the Arjuna and Dronacharya awards was weeks away from turning 50. "The whole shooting fraternity is in a state of shock, and we are still not able to process it as we were hearing that he was recovering after undergoing surgery," NRAI President Kalikesh Singh Deo said in a statement issued by the body.

Hailing from Uttarakhand, Rana first made his mark as an 18-year-old by winning gold in the 25m Centre Fire Pistol event at the 1994 Asian Games in Hiroshima.

Rana's passing profound loss to Indian sports: PM Modi



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi joined the sporting world in mourning the untimely demise of renowned Indian shooter and Coach Jaspal Rana, describing his passing as "a profound loss to the nation."

Rana, 49, who brought laurels to the country through his achievements as an elite shooter and later played a key role in nurturing young talent as a coach, died due to complications related to heart.

"Deeply saddened by the passing of Shri Jaspal Rana ji. His passing is a profound loss to the world of



Prime Minister added.

Sports Minister Mansukh Mandaviya too remembered Rana's contributions to Indian shooting.

"Deeply pained by the passing of Indian shooting legend Shri Jaspal Rana ji. His incredible contributions to our nation, as a champion athlete and an exceptional mentor, leave behind an inspiring legacy. My heartfelt condolences to his family, friends and the sporting fraternity. Om Shanti," Mandaviya said.

Olympic champion shooter Abhinav Bindra said he was heartbroken by Rana's passing, recalling their association as teammates and his contribution to Indian shooting.

PV Sindhu storms into Australian Open semis; Tanvi crashes out

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Sydney

Two-time Olympic medallist PV Sindhu stormed into the women's singles semi-finals of the Australian Open Super 500 badminton tournament with a commanding straight-game victory on Friday.

The third-seeded Indian outclassed Chinese Taipei's Chen Su Yu 21-6, 21-9 in a one-sided quarter-final contest that lasted just 27 minutes.

The former world champion Sindhu will next face top seed Akane Yamaguchi of Japan, who ended the impressive run of Indian



teenager Tanvi Sharma with a 21-14, 21-14 victory in 32 minutes.

Sindhu incidentally holds a narrow 15-13 head-to-head advantage over the world No. 3 Japanese.

Sindhu dominated proceedings from the outset, using her superior reach and court coverage to keep her opponent under constant pressure.

She raced through the opening game before maintaining the momentum in the second to seal her place in the last-four.

The semi-final appearance marks a significant boost for Sindhu, who

has endured an inconsistent season and has been searching for rhythm on the BWF World Tour and is in search of her first title since the Syed Modi International in December 2024.

Earlier, Sindhu had defeated compatriot Isharani Baruah in the pre-quarterfinals to advance to the last eight.

But the Indian men's doubles pair of Hariharan Amsakarunan and MR Arjun exited in the quarterfinals after conceding their match while trailing 19-21, 9-16 against Chen Cheng Kuan and Liu Kuang Heng of Chinese Taipei.

Amateur Ananyaa Sood joins Riya, Anvitha in WPGT's seventh leg

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mysuru

Amateur golfer Ananyaa Sood, a 15-year-old who has fine-tuned her game in Dubai, became the joint leader alongside Anvitha Narender and overnight leader Riya Jadon after two rounds of the ₹17 lakh seventh leg of the Women's Pro Golf Tour (WPGT) at the Jayachamaraja Wadiyar Golf Club on Friday.

Ananyaa, the 2024 US Kids European Championship winner, picked up five birdies against two bogeys and a double bogey in her round of 1-under 69 on the par-70 course. Anvitha, a former winner on the Tour in 2024, returned the day's best card of 2-under 68, which included a fine front nine of 3-under 31.

Riya Jadon had a rough day, with three bogeys and no birdies in her round of 73, but she managed to



retain a share of the lead at even-par 140 after 36 holes.

Durga Nittur (71), Amandeep Drall (72), Vidhatri Urs (73) and Anvitha Dahhiya (73) were tied for fourth at 2-over 142, while Tvesa Malik, who was second after the first round, dropped to tied-eighth following a card of 5-over 75 that included a quadruple bogey on the par-4 17th.

Tvesa was tied for eighth with Karishma Govind (73) at 3-over 143. Ananyaa, who trains under former Indian pro Sujjan Singh, has been showing good progress. She has played on the WPGT in the past and has also posted good results in junior events in Dubai and elsewhere while training at the Claude Harmon III Centre in Dubai.

Anvitha, who was born in the US, is now based in Bengaluru. She tasted success by winning on the WPGT in 2024. A prolific winner on the amateur circuit, the 20-year-old won a title in only her second professional start in her hometown of Bengaluru. Riya, 17, had a distinguished amateur career and turned professional at the start of 2026.



World Cup: Mexico starts with big win while US-Canada prepare for openers

DAVID BRANDTAP ■ Jersey

Mexico opened the World Cup on Thursday with a dominant 2-0 win over South Africa in front of a boisterous home crowd at Mexico City's Azteca Stadium.

On Friday, the United States and Canada both get their opportunity for a fast start in front of their respective home countries.

Julian Quinones scored the first goal of the World Cup in the ninth minute, booting a cross through the legs of South Africa goalkeeper Ronwen Williams. El Tri made it 2-0 midway through the second half when veteran Raul Jimenez delivered a header that found the back of the net.

It was an emotional moment for Jimenez, who had tears in his



eyes as Mexico's crowd roared in approval. Jimenez suffered a fractured skull after a scary collision in 2020, but has rebuilt his career and now has his first World Cup goal.

In Thursday's nightcap, South Korea rallied for a 2-1 win over the Czech Republic in Guadalajara, Mexico. All three goals were scored in an entertaining second half.

What to watch June 12: Fox is the exclusive U.S. broadcaster of the World Cup with all 104 matches in English on Fox or FS1. All matches are also available on the Fox One app. Telemundo and Universo



will broadcast all of the matches in Spanish. Peacock is the streaming home for Spanish-language broadcasts, while

Telemundo also has an app that includes all the matches.

Canada seeks first World Cup win in

Toronto. The Canadians are searching for their first World Cup win when they face Bosnia-Herzegovina on Friday after going 0-3 in both 1986 and 2022.

Canada has been on the rise over the past decade in the soccer world, moving to Number 30 in FIFA's rankings after being ranked below 100 as recently as 2017. Forward Jonathan David — who plays for Italian club Juventus — is the country's career scoring leader with 39 goals in 77 matches.

Bosnia is playing in its second World Cup and first since 2014, when the country was eliminated in the group stage.

US hopes games on home soil lead to World Cup breakthrough. The Americans — who enter the tournament ranked 17th by FIFA — hope that matches on their home soil can lead to a World Cup breakthrough. The US has advanced to the knockout

round in four of the last six World Cups it has played, but hasn't been able to get past the quarterfinals. Coach Mauricio Pochettino was hired in 2024 after successful stints at several European clubs. It's a big tournament for forward Christian Pulisic, who enters this World Cup in his prime and with high expectations.

The Americans' first opponent, Paraguay, is the lowest-ranked team in Group D at Number 47 and back in the World Cup for the first time in 16 years. Ramon Sosa and the Julio Enciso are among the team's best players.

FIFA President Gianni Infantino defends World Cup ticket prices FIFA President Gianni Infantino defended World Cup ticket prices on Wednesday, saying "if we do something wrong, then probably everyone selling tickets in North America is doing something wrong." (AP)

Williamson announces retirement from international cricket

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Christchurch/London

One of the finest batters of his time and the face of New Zealand cricket's most successful era, Kane Williamson announced his retirement from international cricket on Friday, ending a distinguished career marked by consistency, impeccable temperament and exemplary leadership.

Arguably New Zealand's greatest ever batter, Williamson's announcement pulls the curtain down on a glorious 16-year international career that has seen him play 378 games for his country, setting countless batting records and earning the respect and admiration of

the cricketing world. His decision follows an earlier call to step away from T20 Internationals in 2025.

"I've thought about it for a while, but over the last few days it's become clear now is the right time. I've always felt a strong drive and hunger for international cricket, and I take pride in knowing I've given it my all in every match I've played for New Zealand," Williamson said in a statement issued by New Zealand Cricket. "Continuing with anything less wouldn't be right, and I feel fortunate to step away on my own terms," he added.

The 35-year-old finishes as New Zealand's all-time leading international run-



scorer across all formats with 19,346 runs, including over 9500 runs in Test cricket with 33 centuries and six double tons. Across formats, he slammed 48 centuries and six double-centuries.

Under his leadership, the Black Caps made two ICC

World Cup Finals, three semi-finals, and won the inaugural World Test Championship in 2021. His personal accolades include being named the ICC Cricketer of the Year for 2015 and the Test player of the Year for 2019. Williamson is currently in England for an

ongoing Test series, and the Kiwis lost the opening match by 115 runs. Williamson could not make much of an impact in the game, logging scores of 0 and 18. Asked why he chose to step aside at this point, Williamson said it's been a "process". "...it sort of dawned on me in the last few days that it felt like the time was right for me to step away..."

"The other side of that is I see a group, a really, really talented group that have that journey ahead of them that are totally invested in wanting to do some special things with this New Zealand cricket team that I've been incredibly fortunate to have been a part of for such a long period of time.

VALUE OUR FRIENDSHIP: VIRAT KOHLI

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Ace Indian cricketer Virat Kohli on Friday paid tribute to Kane Williamson following the New Zealand batting great's retirement from international cricket, saying he cherished their friendship and that it was time for the charismatic batter to celebrate the rewards of a lifetime devoted to the game.

Arguably New Zealand's greatest ever batter, Williamson's announcement pulls the curtain down on a glorious 16-year international career that has

seen him play 378 games for his country, setting countless batting records and earning the respect and admiration of the cricketing world.

His decision follows an earlier call to step away from T20 Internationals in 2025.

Kohli and Williamson's friendship dates back to the 2008 Under-19 World Cup.

Since then, the two batting greats have faced each other across formats for their respective countries and in the IPL, where Kohli has been a long-time mainstay of Royal Challengers Bengaluru, while Williamson represented

Sunrisers Hyderabad and Lucknow Super Giants.

"From an opponent to a friend over the years. It's been a pleasure watching you bat and compete against you over so many years, but more than that, I value our friendship and shared perspectives on the game and beyond," wrote Kohli on 'X'.

"I continue to cherish every time we speak or meet. Wishing you nothing but the best, always, brother. You've done your bit, you deserve to enjoy all of it now and put your feet up. Well done, mate, life's only just begun," Kohli added.

Afghanistan relying on seasoned spin trio to win over India



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Dharamsala

Afghanistan captain Hashmatullah Shahidi is banking on the Rashid Khan-led spin trio to script their first-ever win over India across formats as they face the hosts in the three-match ODI series beginning here on Saturday.

Like India, Afghanistan's preparations for the 2027 World Cup start with the three ODIs against the Shubman Gill-led side.

Speaking to the media ahead of the series opener, Shahidi said his team is looking forward to playing India in a bilateral series for the first time, and he is relying on Rashid, AM Ghazanfar and veteran Mohammad Nabi to challenge the mighty hosts.

"We have experience of playing on this ground. We

played last in the 2023 World Cup against Bangladesh. I still remember that.

I think in Indian conditions, when it's hot, most probably its spin wickets. So, I think, I feel that our advantage will be spinners. "Of course, everyone knows that India is tough opposition in the ODI format. They were in the finals last time in the World Cup. We are starting from here our World Cup journey. But no one has shown yet which team is going to be qualified for the World Cup. But still we have 7th ranking in our ICC ODI rankings," said Shahidi, looking ahead of the ODI showpiece in South Africa in October-November 2027.

Afghanistan, who were outplayed in the one-off Test, have gained confidence from their last five ODI series going into the India contest.

Rohit, Reddy in spotlight as India begins WC 2027 journey

BHARAT SHARMA
■ Dharamsala

Rohit Sharma's match fitness will be tested, but India's team management would also closely monitor Nitish Kumar Reddy's performance as a back-up for injury-prone Hardik Pandya when they formally begin their 2027 World Cup preparations with the first-ever ODI series against Afghanistan here on Saturday.

Having nursed a hamstring niggle during the IPL, Rohit has managed to regain full fitness just in time for the three games against Afghanistan, while top draw Virat Kohli will miss the series due to a rare hamstring injury. As India plans for the World Cup in South Africa in



October-November 2027, there are doubts over whether the 39-year-old Rohit can last till the ODI showpiece.

India is scheduled to play 25-odd ODIs before the mega event, giving the team enough time to experiment with players and combina-

tions. With two losses in three series, the start to Shubman Gill's ODI captaincy has not been smooth and working alongside head coach Gautam Gambhir, he would be looking to expand his footprint in the dressing room. Shubman and Rohit are expected to open the

innings, while there would be a toss-up between comeback man Ishan Kishan and Yashasvi Jaiswal at number three in Kohli's absence.

Newly appointed T20 captain Shreyas Iyer will bat at number four. Both Rohit and Shreyas were linked with the India squad in Chandigarh before the team travelled to the picturesque hill town on Thursday.

KL Rahul, the number one wicket-keeper batter in the side, is part of the middle-order, and Nitish Kumar Reddy is likely to follow him in the batting line-up at number six. Reddy's batting credentials have never been in doubt, but whether he can consistently do the job with the ball as Hardik's back-up remains to be seen. (PTI)

MORKEL PLEASD WITH REDDY'S IMPROVEMENT AS A BOWLER

Dharamsala: Nitish Reddy, groomed as a back-up to injury-prone India all-rounder Hardik Pandya, would be keenly watched in the ODI series against Afghanistan beginning on Saturday. Reddy's improvement as a medium pacer was on full display in the recent IPL. With the next World Cup in October-November 2027, India would like to have a ready backup for Hardik. With what Morkel have seen of Reddy the all-rounder of late, he is happy with his progress.

"You plan, you look at your options like we do in batting and bowling. Same as with the all-rounders. Unfortunately, Hardik is missing this series. He picked up a niggle, quite a niggle, very close to joining camp.

"But again, it's another opportunity now for Nitish Kumar Reddy. He's been playing beautifully in the last two years," said Morkel when asked how India is planning for life beyond Hardik. Reddy has increased his pace after making some technical adjustments. He picked up crucial wickets for Sunrisers Hyderabad in the recent IPL and was equally impressive with the bat. "When the players get the opportunity to work and develop their own game, look at areas where they can improve. (PTI)

In Kohli's absence, India could try out KL Rahul at number 3

BHARAT SHARMA
■ Dharamsala

Ishan Kishan performing wicket-keeping drills instead of KL Rahul attracted immediate attention on the eve of the first ODI between India and Afghanistan.

Rahul has been India's number one wicket-keeper batter for several years in limited-overs cricket, but now, with Kishan back in the ODI set-up, he could be relieved of his duties behind the stumps, going by what transpired on the only training session here before the game on Saturday.

While Kishan was going about his wicket-keeping drills, Rahul was seen taking high catches in the outfield of the scenic stadium. Virat

Kohli's absence from the series due to an injury has allowed India to try out players at the number three spot. Here too, Rahul could see a change in his role with the bat despite being settled nicely in the middle-order, specifically number five, over the last four years.

Speaking to the media, India bowling Coach Morne Morkel said not just Rahul, Kishan and Yashasvi Jaiswal could be tried out at the number three spot over the course of the Afghanistan series. "In terms of that number three slot, that's something that in this series we'll play around with. Even if it's Ishan or KL or Yashasvi, it's a nice opportunity now. We've got a couple of one-day games coming up, and

we'll give guys an opportunity in different slots.

"Just to give ourselves a better idea in terms of how we can go and structure the team and have different options," said the former South Africa pacer.

It seems Prince and Gurnoor have been around for four to five years.

Prince Yadav or Gurnoor Brar could make their India debut on Saturday. India trained in Chandigarh before travelling to Dharamsala.

As a fellow pacer, Morkel is impressed with both Prince and Gurnoor, who have been net bowlers for India for many years.

"My first impression, it is sort of, almost like they've been part of the squad for five years. I saw no nervous-



ness on their face. Although I can imagine coming into the squad, they would be pretty nervous. But I think the way they've gone about their training, the energy they've trained with, was very, very nice and good to see.

"In terms of their skills, I can also see that they've

Morkel said. "How can we do that better? But definitely, on first impressions, very happy with what we saw as a group," he added.

Morkel expressed hope that India's chief coach Gautam Gambhir will try the duo out in the Afghanistan series.

"I'm pretty sure Gautam will give those guys an opportunity and see how they go in the Indian shirt. It's different playing for international cricket with an Indian badge. We're excited to have them." Rohit Sharma too was part of the training session, having regained full fitness following his hamstring injury. While the team would miss Kohli, Morkel said it was good to have Rohit's experience in the side. (PTI)

SA20 has given cricket back to the country: Dale Steyn

G UNNIKRISHNAN
■ Bengaluru

Former South African fast bowler Dale Steyn has termed the synergy between SA20 and IPL as a big factor in the success of the Protean league, which he said brought the crowd back to stadiums in his country.

The SA20 has evoked enthusiastic support from fans across the nation in its previous four editions, and Cricket South Africa is hoping for an encore during season five later this year.

"South Africa has been desperate for cricket. The world went through a pandemic, and sport was definitely taken away from South Africa. Local sport took a hit

in South Africa. I think (SA20 Commissioner) Graeme Smith and the league have given the sport back to the country," Steyn said during a select media interaction organised by SA20 ahead of season five.

"You've been desperate for cricket, and we've given it back to the fans and the spectators. They have grabbed it with both hands, and SA20 has delivered. Now, the spectators are delivering. They are coming back season after season, supporting their teams," he added.

Steyn also thought that Indian ownership in SA20 and the regular presence of South African players in the IPL have contributed to the league's success. "South



Africa's relationship with India has been phenomenal. With the introduction of the SA20 and having Indian owners for Sunrisers Eastern Cape, MI Cape Town, etc., so having that relationship feeds really well.

"When it comes to scheduling, CSA is pretty certain

that they've got no cricket that interferes with the timeline of the IPL. So, a lot of those white ball players are going to be available for the IPL - class players for a full tournament. "It's not, oh, we're resting them for the first four weeks, or they're unavailable because there's

a series coming up, etc. Coaches and teams know that," he said. So, is it feasible for SA20 to play a match in front of an Indian audience similar to the Big Bash League? The season opener of BBL 2026-27 is scheduled to be played in Chennai.

"The biggest takeaway from the SA20 is the spectators. So, I would feel harsh to rob the South Africans of one game. The Indians have got the IPL, the biggest competition. They're spoiled with the IPL. I can promise you that. To give them another game and then take it away from the South Africans, I feel like you're just shooting yourself in the foot." The 42-year-old was not clearly impressed by

the idea of having an SA20 game away from South African shores. "You've finally got a competition here in South Africa that's working. And now, you're taking one of those games to India. Where do we see that going?"

"But maybe the Big Bash is suffering a slow death, and they're just trying to rejuvenate their competition by getting some support from India. I think the players will enjoy it - travel to India and play in Chennai. "I don't think that that would be an option for the SA20. I think it's doing really well in South Africa. And there's a saying, if it isn't broke, don't fix it," he added. (PTI)

Chopra to miss Doha Diamond League



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Star Indian javelin thrower Neeraj Chopra is set to miss the Doha Diamond League, to be held on June 19, as he is still recuperating from a back injury in Switzerland.

Chopra, who won gold and silver medals at the 2020 and 2024 Olympics respectively, began his Diamond League campaign in Doha last year and breached the 90m mark.

The 28-year-old from Haryana is currently in Bienne, Switzerland, for a 47-day off-season training camp along with his long-time physiotherapist Ishaan Marwaha and coach Jai Choudhary ahead of this year's Commonwealth

Games and Asian Games.

The world's best, including Sri Lankan world leader Rumesh Tharanga Pathirage, who threw a national record 92.62m to win the Diamond League meeting in Rome on June 4, will line up at the Qatar Sports Club alongside Paris Olympics gold medallist Arshad Nadeem of Pakistan and reigning world champion Keshorn Walcott of Trinidad and Tobago. In a field bursting with talent, the trio will be joined at the Mazzratty Doha Meeting by a host of stars, including former two-time world champion and Olympic bronze medallist Anderson Peters of Grenada, and world bronze medallist Curtis Thompson of the USA. The precedent has been set for standout performances.

US Open 26: Scheffler trying to make history, Shinnecock tries to avoid recent history

DOUG FERGUSON
■ Southampton (New York)

So much history is involved when the US Open returns to Shinnecock Hills, the only golf club to host this major championship in three centuries. Scottie Scheffler will try to take his place in history when the Number 1 player goes after the final leg of the career Grand Slam. Should he win, he would be the seventh player to win all four majors and join Tiger Woods as the only players since 1960 — the



modern era of the slam — to get it done on his first try.

That ordinarily would be the sole focus of the 126th US

Open, to be played June 18-21, except for the recent history at Shinnecock Hills.

It has not been smooth

sailing off the Great Peconic Bay on Long Island.

"It's hard when you run one tournament a year — and you run it on a different golf course every year — to get it just right," Scheffler said. "And you're trying to make it hard. I think in the US Open, they push the boundaries. If they're going to continue to push the boundaries, eventually they'll screw up, and then they'll dial it back."

The 2004 US Open was already brutally tough when the USGA failed to account

for the strength of the warm wind. The par-3 seventh, with its Redan green, became so impossible to hold that officials had to douse it with water between groups on the final day. No one broke par, and the average score was 78.73.

Among the blistering comments came this from Jerry Kelly: "I think they're ruining the game. They're ruining the tournament. This isn't golf." When the US Open returned to this New York gem in 2018, the greens were so

glassy from sun and wind that the last 45 players on the tee sheet Saturday failed to break par. Phil Mickelson staged a bizarre protest by swatting a moving ball on the 13th green.

Brooks Koepka saved the week by becoming the first repeat champion in 29 years. So a return to the fabled course evokes one thought: What will go wrong this time? "Hopefully, they get the balance right of all the different challenges, and it's not contrived," Adam Scott said.